



Galaxy Z Fold8 Ultra | Fold8

Galaxy AI

EMI starting ₹ 2150/month*

Model Name	Galaxy Z Fold8 Ultra	Galaxy Z Fold8
Retail price	₹ 199999	₹ 179999
Exchange value of old device~ (Max)	₹ 90000	₹ 90000
Exchange bonus^ Samsung Upgrade	₹ 4000	₹ 4000
Net effective price (1 unit)	₹ 105999	₹ 85999
Per month EMI starting	₹ 2650**	₹ 2150*

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Image simulated. Samsung account login may be required for certain AI features. Actual UX/UI may differ. Samsung promotes responsible use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) features. T&C apply. *EMI amount ₹ 2150 is computed on 40 months No Cost EMI including 10 months down payment at the price of ₹ 85999 for 1 unit of Galaxy Z Fold8 12|256GB, inclusive of Exchange Value of old device, Exchange bonus with EMI @ ₹ 4000. EMI rounded off to nearest rupee for ease of reference. Eligibility for EMI at the sole discretion of the financiers including those listed on Samsung Finance+ (Financier T&C applies). Samsung disclaims any liabilities with the same. **EMI amount ₹ 2650 is computed on 40 months No Cost EMI including 10 months down payment at the price of ₹ 105999 for 1 unit of Galaxy Z Fold8 Ultra 12|256GB, inclusive of Exchange Value of old device, Exchange bonus with EMI at ₹ 4000. EMI rounded off to nearest rupee for ease of reference. Eligibility for EMI at the sole discretion of the financiers including those listed on Samsung Finance+ (Financier T&C applies). Samsung disclaims any liabilities with the same. ~Approximate value on exchange of 1 unit of Galaxy Z Fold7 12|256 GB. Exchange value varies basis model & condition of old device. Exchange at the sole discretion of dealer. ^Customers of Galaxy Z Fold8 Ultra 12|256GB & Galaxy Z Fold8 12|256GB are eligible for benefits of maximum exchange bonus of ₹ 8000 on full swipe at select cards. Customers availing any NBFC EMI will be eligible to get upto ₹ 4000 exchange bonus. Exchange Bonus as per Samsung Upgrade program, provided by brand/dealer at their sole discretion upon exchange of select devices. Aforesaid calculations are for illustrative purposes, final price at the sole discretion of retailer.



SAMSUNG

Galaxy S26 Series
Galaxy AI ✨



EMI starting ₹ 1050/month*

Retail price# of Galaxy S26 FE	₹ 79999
Exchange value of old device~ (Max)	₹ 35000
Exchange bonus^ Samsung Upgrade	₹ 3000
Net effective price** (1 unit)	₹ 41999
Per month EMI starting*	₹ 1050



Galaxy S26 Ultra
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Tuesday, September 22, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

What's driving the churn in India's workforce?

BY SHELLEY SINGH

India's job market is undergoing a churn. Multinationals are cutting roles, particularly in IT, even as opportunities emerge in global capability centres (GCCs), niche artificial intelligence (AI) areas and semiconductors. *Mint* explains the changes reshaping the job market.



ISTOCKPHOTO

1 Are multinationals laying off employees?

Yes. Global majors, including Oracle, PayPal, Amazon, Adidas and Meta have together trimmed 12,000–15,000 roles in India in the past 12 months as part of worldwide cuts, taking total global reductions to more than 100,000 jobs. Indian IT firms such as TCS have also reduced headcount. According to global layoffs tracker layoffs.fyi, around 122,000 people were laid off in 2025, while close to 130,000 have been let go so far in 2026. The job cuts are concentrated in engineering, support and sales functions, reflecting global restructuring and AI-driven efficiency efforts. India's IT hubs are among the worst hit.

ISTOCKPHOTO

2 What is driving the layoffs?

AI adoption, automation and cost optimization are reshaping workforce requirements. Companies are reallocating budgets from legacy functions to cloud, data and AI infrastructure. Routine coding, testing and back-office roles are shrinking, while demand is rising for niche skills in cybersecurity, product design and advanced analytics. Economic pressures, including rising input costs, funding slowdowns at startups and global market uncertainty, are adding to the churn. With AI assistants taking on routine tasks, companies are reshaping workforce models and also hiring for specialist roles.

3 Is the churn mostly in technology?

India's top five IT firms have shed nearly 7,000 jobs in FY26, reversing earlier expansions. Global technology companies have also made large cuts to their India teams as part of AI-led restructuring. Banking, fintech, e-commerce and consumer electronics have also seen cuts in software engineering and data-science roles.

4 Where are jobs being created now?

Despite the job cuts, India remains a key offshore base, with firms continuing to invest in specialized talent even as they shrink routine roles. GCCs are projected to add 120,000 specialized roles in 2026, according to UnearthInsight. These centres, run by global banks, retailers, hospitality, pharma and other companies hire talent in AI, data, cybersecurity, and product engineering. Seasonal hiring is also strong: The festive season alone is expected to generate 200,000–250,000 gig and retail jobs.

5 Will semiconductor push create jobs?

Yes. India's semiconductor push under Semicon 2.0 and manufacturing driven by Production-Linked Incentives (PLI) schemes are expected to create more than 200,000 direct and indirect jobs by 2030. Union IT minister Ashwini Vaishnaw projects 50,000–60,000 direct jobs in fabs, ATMP/OSAT units and chip design, alongside training of more than 100,00 engineers over the next few years. The jobs span manufacturing, packaging, R&D and ecosystem support.

QUICK EDIT

Brics: new tailwinds

While India's exports have kept up a healthy momentum, its efforts to diversify markets are also working out well. Shipments from India to the other original members of the Brics grouping, namely Brazil, Russia, China and South Africa, reportedly surged 34% to \$19.9 billion in April-August. To China alone, these grew 39%. Though these gains are on small bases, increasing diversification will help India reduce its reliance on a few markets as world trade falls victim to the vagaries of geopolitics. With China, India has a wide trade deficit. If the current export momentum continues, it would help narrow this gap. This may take a long time, given how heavily imports from China outweigh exports. Still, the trade relationship would evolve in the desired direction. Whether prospects of a better balance strengthen may depend on how ties are managed. China has eased barriers to Indian goods lately, just as India has lowered bars to Chinese investment. That Brics partners must cooperate was a message from its recent summit in New Delhi. It wasn't just a coincidence that emphasis was laid on their share of world exports: around a quarter. This shouldn't be hard to expand.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

At a time when there is uncertainty around the world in trade, ...India and New Zealand show that we can agree to terms that are beneficial for trade and businesses.

TODD MCCLAY
TRADE MINISTER,
NEW ZEALAND

The minister was speaking at an event announcing the ratification of the treaty in New Zealand



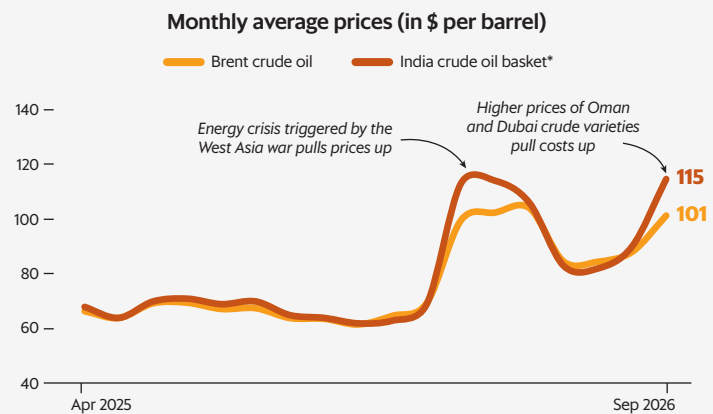
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mint | DATA BITES

HOW HAS WEST ASIA WAR PUSHED UP INDIA'S OIL COSTS?

India's crude oil basket prices typically move in tandem with the benchmark Brent crude. However, with the West Asia conflict driving up premiums on regional oil, the cost of India's crude basket has once again outpaced global benchmarks.



*The Indian crude oil basket is a derived benchmark comprising sweet grade (Brent dated) and sour grade (Oman & Dubai average) crudes imported by Indian refineries each month. The ratio stood at 77.81:22.19 for September 2026, with data tracked until 18 September.

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan
Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Petroleum planning and analysis cell, Yahoo Finance

COLUMNS



M. S. SAHOO & RAGHAV PANDEY
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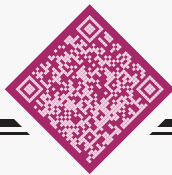


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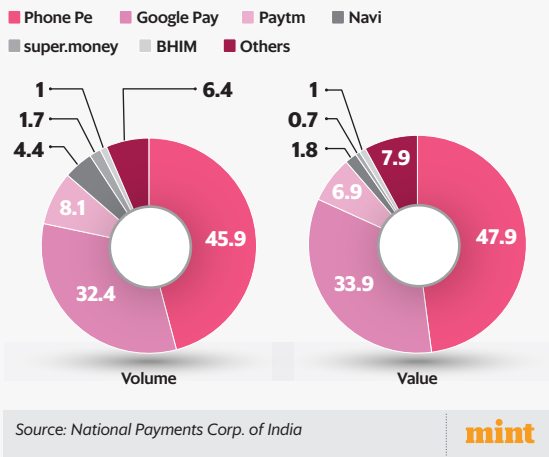
WHAT INDIA'S NEW FEE MEANS FOR UPI SYSTEM

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

Come 15 October, a 0.4% merchant discount rate (MDR) will apply to UPI merchant payments. Person-to-person (P2P) transactions, person-to-merchant (P2M) payments below ₹2,000, and small vendors receiving up to ₹1 lakh a month remain exempt. High-value payments will now generate revenue for payment providers. The move addresses a gap in UPI infrastructure: the government allocated ₹437 crore in fiscal year 2026 (FY26) against an estimated network operating cost of ₹20,000 crore. However, concerns remain whether fee-sensitive businesses will steer customers towards other instruments, whether the benefits will accrue disproportionately to the largest players, and whether revenue will cover fraud, downtime and constraints.

PhonePe and Google Pay dominate the UPI apps market by volume and value

Share in UPI app market (in %), top players



MARKET CONCENTRATION

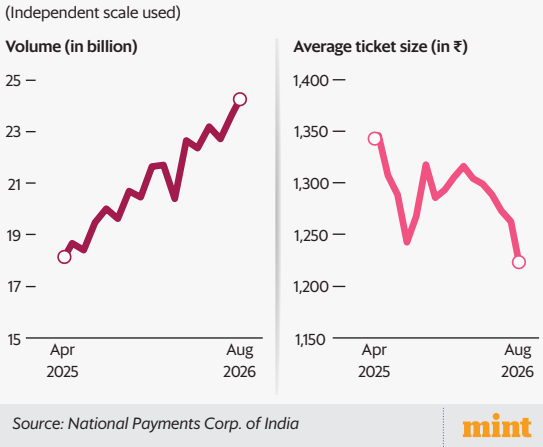
INDIA'S UPI market is already highly concentrated. PhonePe and Google Pay account for 78.3% of transactions and 81.8% of transaction value. Paytm is a distant third, with 8.1% of transaction volume, while Navi, super.money, BHIM, FamApp and WhatsApp Pay together account for less than 10%. The MDR creates a new revenue stream for the industry. Of collections, 40% will go to issuing banks, 30% to acquiring banks, 20% to third-party application providers (TPAPs) and 10% to payer banks. Goldman Sachs estimates annual industry revenue pool could reach ₹20,600 crore by FY28. If the current market structure persists, PhonePe and Google Pay would capture most of the TPAP share of this pool. Paytm could benefit as both a payment app and merchant acquirer, potentially strengthening larger players. In 2020, the National Payments Corp. of India (NPCI) directed that no TPAP should process more than 30% of UPI transaction volumes. The cap has yet to take effect, due to practical challenges.

REVENUE SPLIT

THE GOVERNMENT expects the MDR to have limited impact on everyday UPI usage because it applies only to merchant payments above ₹2,000. NPCI data shows that more than 95% of P2M transactions are below that threshold. UPI is increasingly dominated by small-value payments: P2M transactions account for about 63% of total volume, and 86% are below ₹500. The average UPI ticket size has fallen steadily as adoption has widened, from ₹1,338 in April 2025 to ₹1,217 in August 2026. The fall has continued as consumers increasingly use UPI for smaller purchases. P2P transfers, about 37% of transaction volume and more than 70% of transaction value, remain exempt regardless of amount. Small merchants receiving up to ₹1 lakh a month through UPI QR codes are also exempt. Together, these provisions leave most consumer and small-business transactions outside the MDR framework. The question is whether the fee on higher-value merchant payments could nonetheless alter consumer behaviour or slow UPI's growth.

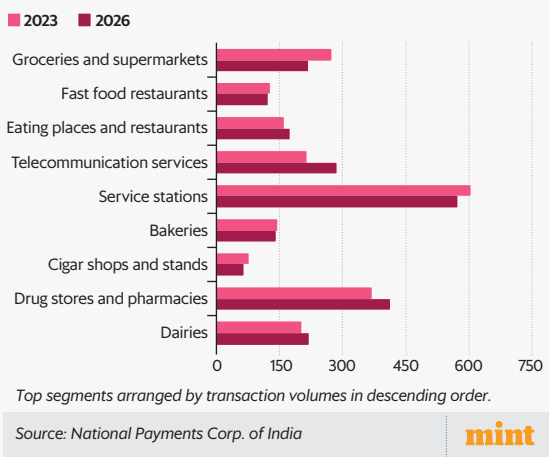
While volumes have risen, average ticket size of UPI transactions has been falling

Details of UPI transactions, monthly



Average ticket size has dropped for most of high volume merchant transactions

Average ticket size (in ₹)



LOW-VALUE PUSH

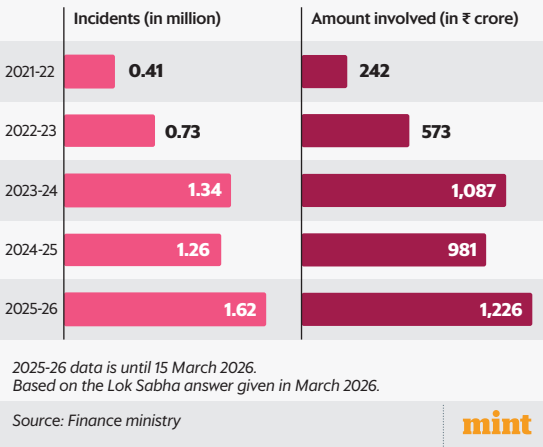
UPI'S GROWTH is increasingly being driven by small retail purchases. NPCI data shows that groceries and supermarkets account for 25.8% of P2M transaction volume, with an average ticket size of just ₹217. Fast-food outlets and restaurants account for another 10% of transaction volume, with an average ticket of ₹122 in 2026. The corresponding figures were ₹272 and ₹126 three years earlier. The decline in ticket sizes suggests that UPI adoption is spreading deeper into everyday purchases rather than being driven by larger payments. It is also unclear whether merchants will assess the new 0.4% MDR against the cost of other payment instruments—typically 1.5%-2.5% for credit cards and up to 0.9% for debit cards—or against the previous zero-MDR regime. Merchant resistance is already evident. A 16 September LocalCircles survey of 32,796 businesses across 242 districts found that 41% were unwilling to absorb any MDR on UPI transactions above ₹2,000.

FIGHTING FRAUD

THE GOVERNMENT has said the MDR revenue will help strengthen infrastructure, and cybersecurity and fraud prevention across the payments ecosystem. Fraud has emerged as a key challenge facing the UPI. Finance ministry data shared in the Lok Sabha in March showed that reported UPI payment fraud rose from 407,000 incidents involving ₹242 crore in FY22 to 1.63 million involving ₹1,226.37 crore in FY26, through 15 March. The increase broadly tracks UPI's rapid adoption, but it also underscores the need for continued investment in security. The payments industry argues that tackling these threats requires sustained spending. In media interviews, PhonePe chief executive Sameer Nigam said fintech firms and banks had been absorbing the costs of fraud losses, chargebacks and cybersecurity investments while operating in a zero-MDR environment. The additional revenue could give payment providers greater scope to invest in fraud detection and system security.

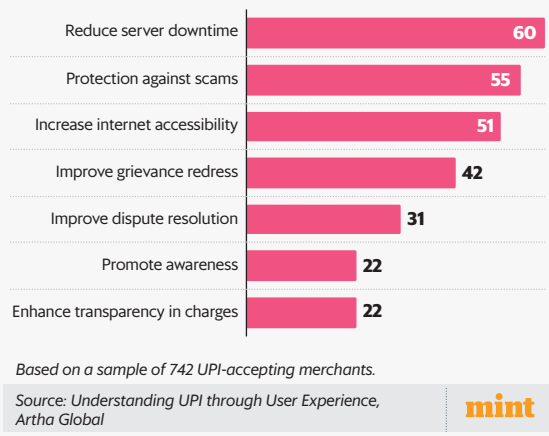
UPI payment frauds have risen along with the rapid adoption of the payment system

(Independent scale used)



UPI server downtime and scams are top concerns for merchants

Share of respondents who suggested the following improvements related to UPI (in %)



INFRA INVESTMENT

UPI is now deeply embedded in small-business operations. An Artha Global survey across urban and rural markets last year found, 84% of merchants said UPI had a positive impact. Benefits were instant bank settlement (75%-76%), lower cash dependence (60%), higher customer footfall (54%), and better transaction records (47%). But 60% cited server downtime and transaction failures as the biggest areas needing improvement. "Although NPCI and banks have made backend improvements, capacity expansion lags behind transaction growth," the report said, adding that under the zero-MDR regime, banks and payment service providers lacked commercial incentives to invest in server upgrades. MDR policy earmarks 5% of collections for a Small Merchant Development Fund for merchant onboarding, technical support and digital safety initiatives. www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data.

Tuesday, September 22, 2026

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Assam's flood resilience meets a changing landscape ▶P12



SAP told to resume Nayara IT aid frozen after EU curbs ▶P8

SENSEX **74,858.99** ↑ **564.03**

NIFTY **23,414.3** ↑ **67.9**

DOLLAR **₹95.78** ↓ **₹0.18**

EURO **₹109.99** ↑ **₹0.09**

OIL **\$98.15** ↓ **\$13.19**

POUND **₹128.24** ↓ **₹0.04**

Temp staff rule auto as firms shrink costs

Share of temporary workers up to about 90% over four years

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

Temporary workers now comprise about 90% of the total worker count at India's leading automobile and component manufacturers, as companies look to quickly tweak their staffing levels in line with the production cycles to optimize labour costs.

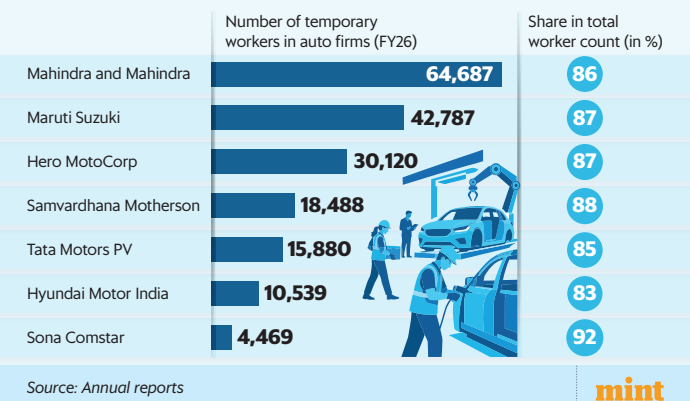
A *Mint* review of the annual reports of leading auto firms shows that the share of temporary workers has risen sharply over the past four fiscal years, as they expanded production, added shifts and increased factory capacity to capitalize on growth in the Indian market.

The trend is visible across major automakers, with temporary workers accounting for 83-92% of the workers at Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Motors, Hyundai Motor India and Hero MotoCorp, as well as homegrown component makers Samvardhana Motherson and Sona Comstar.

The shift towards a predominantly temporary workforce gives companies flexibility in managing costs and adjusting staffing levels to production cycles. But it also exposes them to risks on labour

LABOUR LEEWAY

Share of temporary workers rose as the firms expanded production, added shifts and increased factory capacity to capitalize on growth



COST CALCULUS

THE move gives auto companies flexibility in managing costs

IT helps firms adjust staffing levels to production cycles

BUT it also exposes them to risks on labour availability

availability, workforce continuity and potential disruptions arising from wage disputes and protests.

“Contractual manpower has given automakers flexibility to manage costs and adjust manpower with production cycles. But when 85-90% of the shopfloor is non-permanent, maintaining continuity of

skills, experience, productivity and shopfloor discipline becomes much harder,” said Vinay Piparsania, founder of MillenStrat Advisory and Research.

The workers include those involved in production on manu-

TURN TO PAGE 4

UPI charge to sting big-bill retail; quick comm may duck it

Sowmya Ramasubramanian & Vaeshnavi Kasthuril

BENGALURU

The proposed 0.4% charge on unified payments interface (UPI) transactions of over ₹2,000 is set to increase costs for retailers and consumer internet companies such as Nykaa and Lenskart, where spending by customers typically exceeds this threshold, analysts said.

The merchant discount rate (MDR), which will apply to specified person-to-merchant UPI transactions of over ₹2,000 from 15 October, is a departure from the zero-MDR regime that has supported UPI's rapid adoption. Payments up to ₹2,000 and person-to-person transactions will remain free, while the fee on transactions of ₹75,000 and above will be capped at ₹300. The charge is to be borne by merchants.

The impact on profitability will be higher for businesses where customers regularly spend over ₹2,000, while food delivery and quick-commerce entities with lower per-customer order values are likely to be less affected, executives and analysts told *Mint*.



Food delivery, q-comm seen less affected. ISTOCKPHOTO

According to Ankur Bisen, senior partner at The Knowledge Company, a retail consultancy, the change could affect internet-first businesses such as FirstCry and Lenskart. FirstCry's India multi-channel business reported an average order value (AOV) of ₹2,284 in FY26. It sells products for babies and children.

Lenskart operates in the higher-ticket eyewear category, where purchases can more frequently top ₹2,000, although the company does not disclose an AOV. Bisen said the impact will vary significantly by category.

“Any extra charge on some-

TURN TO PAGE 4

Bearish FPI bets at record high on war, oil concerns

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MUMBAI

Amid hardening global interest rates and oil prices, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) raised their bearish positions on Indian equity index futures to a record high last week, signalling persisting uncertainty in stocks.

FPIs increased their net cumulative short position on Nifty and Bank Nifty futures to 290,546 contracts on Monday, up from 288,428 contracts on Friday, according to data from the National Stock Exchange (NSE).

“Normally, such excessive bearishness indicates an over-sold condition and the possibility of a recovery on a sliver of good news, but this time around I am not so certain,” said Rohit Srivastava, founder of analytics firm IndiaCharts.

Net short positions have remained elevated since 6 August, when the Nifty recovered 11% to 24,636 from a low of 22,181.55 on 2 April at the height of the West Asia hostilities.

During this period, FPIs had reduced their net shorts

DON'T MISS



NSE IPO gets 5.7x subscription amid subdued demand

National Stock Exchange of India's \$2.4 billion initial public offering was subscribed 5.7 times as investors delivered their verdict on the long-awaited deal. The demand was mainly driven by institutional buyers who bid for 12.7 times their allotted portion. ▶P4

India-New Zealand free trade deal to take effect on 20 Oct

The India-New Zealand free trade deal will come into force on 20 October, commerce minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday, with the pact providing duty-free access to New Zealand for 100% of Indian exports from the first day of implementation. ▶P2

'Tata Trusts- Tata Sons split will make Jamsetji turn in his grave'

Lawyer Abhishek Singhvi, senior lead counsel for Tata Trusts, said the fundamental issue in the Tata Trusts versus Tata Sons imbroglio is that the rights of shareholders and owners cannot be nullified. ▶P6

Drug regulator targets loophole in doctors' direct med supplies

India's apex drugs regulator plans to tighten rules for doctors dispensing medicines directly to patients by setting a stock limit for registered medical practitioners (RMPs), according to two government officials and documents *Mint* reviewed. ▶P2

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MINT SHORTS

India, Canada to hold next round of trade talks from 5 Oct: Goyal

New Delhi: The next round of talks for a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (Cepa) between India and Canada will be held from 5 October, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday. "...the next 90 days should be a very defining period in the Canada-India relationship," he told reporters. The fourth round of negotiations concluded in New Delhi on 18 September. **PTI**

IOC board clears \$2,449 crore investment on KTPL in Kerala



New Delhi: The board of directors of Indian Oil Corp. (IOC) has approved an investment of ₹2,448.70 crore for the construction and operation of the 424.65-km Kochi-Kanyakumari-Thoothukudi Pipeline (KTPL) for natural gas, according to a regulatory filing on Monday. The pipeline will have a system capacity, including common-carrier capacity, of 6.84 million standard cubic metres a day (mmscmd), the company said. **PTI**

ONGC strikes gas in Mahanadi deepwater well near Odisha

New Delhi: Oil and Natural Gas Corp. (ONGC) has struck gas in a deepwater well off India's eastern coast, with the discovery's proximity to Odisha potentially allowing faster development if appraisal confirms commercial viability, the state-run explorer said on Monday. ONGC made the discovery on 18 September, the company said in a statement. **PTI**

Nearly 40% of coal power plants running low on fuel



New Delhi: Nearly 40% of India's coal-fired power plants are operating with critically low fuel stocks due to a surge in power demand amid hotter-than-usual weather linked to El Niño, government data showed on Monday. The number of power plants with critically low coal stocks of less than 25% of the required inventory or only able to generate power for less than three days rose sharply to 74 as of 19 September from about 60 plants last week, data from the Central Electricity Authority showed. **REUTERS**

Soyoil imports to rise to record high on price competitiveness

Mumbai: India's soyoil imports are likely to surge to a record high in the 2025/26 marketing year as rallies in rival palm and sunflower oils make soyoil more competitive for price-sensitive Indian buyers, industry officials told *Reuters*. Soyoil imports are likely to rise 4.2% from last year's record purchases to 5.7 million tonnes in the current marketing year ending 31 October, said Aashish Acharya, vice president at Patanjali Foods Ltd. **REUTERS**

Delhi lawyers strike work at district courts over traffic challan rules

New Delhi: Lawyers on Monday abstained from work in all seven district courts in the national capital to protest amendments to the traffic challan system, particularly the requirement to deposit 50% of the challan amount before approaching a court. The day-long strike followed a call given by the Coordination Committee of all district court Bar Associations. **PTI**

CCPA grapples with surge in grievances over jurisdiction

The authority is receiving a host of grievances spanning sectors it does not directly regulate

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NEW DELHI

The Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) has recently been receiving requests from unexpected quarters to help resolve consumer grievances, leaving it grappling with jurisdictional questions over how to proceed.

The top consumer protection watchdog is increasingly finding itself at the centre of grievances spanning sectors it does not directly regulate, as government ministries, departments and sectoral regulators seek its help in resolving complaints that fall between regulatory jurisdictions, three government officials involved in the process said.

The department of consumer affairs is receiving complaints from varied sectors, for refund of airfares, problems in vehicles due to blended petrol, non-delivery of housing projects on time and pesky calls, among others, the first of the three persons cited earlier, said, all speaking on the condition of anonymity. "We are, therefore, directing these complaints to the concerned authorities for redressal," the person added.

As complaints across government departments continue to rise, the nodal ministries and departments, including those of finance, petroleum and natural gas, civil aviation and hous-



The department of consumer affairs is receiving complaints on varied matters such as airfare refunds, and problems in vehicles due to blended petrol. ISTOCKPHOTO

ing and urban affairs are increasingly approaching CCPA for help in resolving consumer-related grievances, they said. A case in point is the country's capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) seeking CCPA's assistance in addressing consumer grievances involving a wallet-related issue. Given that such grievances often involve issues that cut across regulatory jurisdictions and require coordination with the concerned regulator or service provider, CCPA has been reluctant to expedite such requests, citing concerns over its jurisdiction and the need to fol-

low due process in matters that fall under the purview of sector-specific regulators. Queries sent to spokespersons of department of consumer affairs, Sebi, and ministries of finance, petroleum and natural gas, civil aviation, and housing and urban affairs remained unanswered till press time.

Given that CCPA is empowered to go beyond routine grievance redressal and take up cases via its mechanisms, including hearings and proceedings under the consumer protection framework, ministries and regulators are increasingly approaching the authority to examine such com-

plaints and take appropriate action.

"All such ministries have been asked to address these grievances at their level. If they fail to resolve them, CCPA will take up some of the cases in coordination with the concerned ministry or department," said the second official.

"Sebi has sought the help of CCPA to address wallet-related complaints involving securities-market intermediaries. The complaints are understood to relate to issues such as the handling, withdrawal or refund of money kept in wallets or digital balances linked to trading and investment platforms," said the third official.

"While Sebi regulates stock brokers and other securities-market intermediaries, including the handling and segregation of client funds, the consumer-protection aspects of such complaints may require intervention by CCPA," this person said.

Experts said that CCPA's broad mandate allows it to examine consumer grievances even in sectors governed by specialized regulators, while coordinating with the sectoral authority concerned. Pendency of public grievances with states and Union territories on the Centre's Centralized Public Grievance Redressal and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS) portal was at 216,032 at the end of June, 26% higher than in December 2025.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

216,032
Pendency in June of complaints on CPGRAMS portal

26%
Increase in pendency from December 2025

Core growth eases as India-NZ FTA to take effect on 20 Oct

Harsh Kumar
harsh.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's output across eight core infrastructure sectors grew 4.8% year-on-year in August, easing from 5% growth in July, as strong expansion in cement, electricity and iron ore was partly offset by contractions in coal, natural gas, crude oil and fertilizers.

The growth in the Index of Core Industries (ICI), released by the Office of Economic Adviser on Monday, was led by cement, which expanded 12.5%, followed by electricity at 11.6% and iron ore at 5.5%. Steel and refinery products grew 3.4% and 2.6%, respectively. Coal output contracted 3.8% in August, while natural gas and crude oil production declined 4.9% and 3.6%, respectively. Fertilizer production fell 12.4% during the month.

The eight core industries

account for 40.27% of the weight of items included in the Index of Industrial Production (IIP), making their performance an important indicator of industrial activity.

July's growth was revised down to 5% from the provisional estimate of 5.4%. The July core sector index was also revised to 120.8 from 121.2.

Core sector output grew 4.3% during April-August 2026, compared with 2.4% in the corresponding period of the previous year.

Electricity, iron ore and cement were the main contributors to growth during the five-month period, expanding 21.8%, 9.6% and 10.3%, respectively. Steel output increased 4.1%.

Coal output contracted 3.2% during April-August, while natural gas and crude oil production declined 4.4% and 4.1%, respectively. Refinery product output fell 1.4%, and fertilizer production declined 6.7%.

Cement led the growth in the Index of Core Industries, expanding by 12.5%, followed by electricity at 11.6%

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The India-New Zealand free trade agreement will come into force on 20 October, Union commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday, with the pact providing duty-free access to New Zealand for 100% of Indian exports from the first day of implementation.

Goyal announced the implementation date after the countries completed their domestic procedures for the agreement. He said India and New Zealand aim to double bilateral trade in goods and services to ₹35,000 crore by 2030. "A *Vijay* (victory) for both nations," Goyal said in a post.

The agreement is expected to improve market access for Indian exporters, particularly in labour-intensive sectors like textiles and apparel, leather and footwear, gems and jewellery, engineering goods, processed foods, ceramics and carpets. Indian exports will receive duty-free access across all tariff lines in New Zealand from the day the pact takes effect.

New Zealand's Parliament approved legislation to imple-



Goyal announced the implementation date after the countries completed domestic procedures for the agreement. BLOOMBERG

ment the agreement on 16 September by 93 votes to 29, clearing domestic legislative processes needed for the agreement to take effect.

The pact was signed in April. New Zealand prime minister Christopher Luxon said the agreement would create greater opportunities for businesses and exporters. "Almost three years ago, I committed that National would secure a free trade deal with India within our first term

if elected. And today, we finalised the deal, which comes into force next month," Luxon said in a post on X.

The deal is expected to improve access for Indian exporters, chiefly in sectors that use a lot of labour

"It is exciting to think of how many businesses will grow as a result of this FTA, and then consider what it means for them, for the people who work for them, and for the country. It means more opportunities for exporters, stronger growth for businesses, and more jobs and higher incomes for New Zealand," Luxon added.

Under the agreement, New Zealand will provide duty-free access for 100% of tariff lines covering Indian exports. India, meanwhile, has offered tariff liberalization covering around 70% of tariff lines, accounting for about 95% of the value of bilateral trade.

land," Luxon added.

Under the agreement, New Zealand will provide duty-free access for 100% of tariff lines covering Indian exports. India, meanwhile, has offered tariff liberalization covering around 70% of tariff lines, accounting for about 95% of the value of bilateral trade.

India has retained protection for several sensitive sectors, including dairy and a range of agricultural products. Products such as peas, onions, chickpeas, almonds, and sugar have been excluded from the tariff concessions.

The agreement covers trade in both goods and services and includes provisions relating to the temporary entry of skilled professionals, student mobility and cooperation in areas such as agriculture and technology.

The pact also includes a commitment by New Zealand to facilitate up to \$20 billion of investment into India over 15 years. Goyal has said New Zealand companies could invest in and manufacture in India to serve the domestic market, and use India as a base to export to other markets with which it has trade agreements.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Drug regulator targets loophole in doctors' direct medicine supplies

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India's apex drugs regulator plans to tighten rules for doctors dispensing medicines directly to patients by setting a stock limit for registered medical practitioners (RMPs), according to two government officials and documents *Mint* reviewed.

Rajeev Singh Raghuvanshi, the drugs controller general of India (DCGI), discussed last Friday the proposal to review the scope of Schedule K under the Drugs Rules, 1945, to plug a regulatory loophole that

authorities fear could lead to commercial misuse and compromise patient safety, said the government officials on the condition of anonymity.

Schedule K grants an exemption allowing RMPs to supply and dispense prescription medicines directly to their patients without obtaining a retail drug licence, provided they do not run an open shop. However, the existing provisions do not specify a ceiling on the quantity of medicines a medical practitioner can stock for this purpose.

Narcotic, psychotropic and habit-forming drugs under Schedule X, meanwhile, can-



DCGI proposes to plug a regulatory loophole that leaves scope for commercial misuse of drugs. ISTOCKPHOTO

not be stocked or dispensed without strict licensing, record-keeping and specific authorizations.

The deliberation focused on "clearer guidelines for RMPs on their dispensing rights and responsibilities and restric-

tions on the quantity of stock they can hold, requiring them to rely on pharmacies for routine patient supply," showed one of the government documents reviewed by *Mint*.

"The amendment will define a prescribed maximum quantity of drugs that can be stocked by an RMP for dispensing to their own patients at any given time, and provide clear direction to be dispensed by the physician himself," said a communication forwarded by L. Martemjen Longkumer, controlling and licensing authority, Drugs Control Administration of Nagaland, to the DCGI, seen by *Mint*.

This is not the first time authorities have considered the plan. A similar proposal to restrict medicines dispensed by RMPs was approved by the 56th Drugs Consultative Committee in June 2019 but was subsequently rejected by the Drugs Technical Advisory Board (DTAB) at its 84th meeting in August 2019 on the grounds that it would interfere with doctors' clinical autonomy.

The domestic retail pharmacy market sells an estimated ₹2-2.2 trillion worth of medicines annually. Doctors directly dispense an estimated 5-8% of overall retail volumes,

with the share significantly higher in semi-urban and rural clinic settings, according to pharma market intelligence and trade estimates.

"Basically, the Drugs Control Administration of Nagaland submitted a representation that the lack of stocking thresholds creates an enforcement grey area, enabling the exemption to act as a broad substitute for retail pharmacies rather than serving its limited, intended purpose of emergency or immediate patient dispensing," said one of the two officials.

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CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE
74,858.99	0.76	23,414.30	0.29	22,860.05	0.09	72,083.95	0.08	24,560.35	0.25	16,856.97	-0.02	7,209.70	0.09
PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN
74,294.96	74,535.18	23,346.40	23,330.20	22,840.55	22,823.40	72,025.40	72,077.65	24,498.75	24,488.30	16,859.55	16,856.61	7,202.89	7,217.26
HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW
74,987.40	74,454.18	23,466.80	23,314.80	22,905.05	22,815.80	72,299.80	72,043.80	24,614.85	24,478.60	16,894.22	16,836.49	7,226.12	7,195.03

Adani Total Gas: frothy valuation

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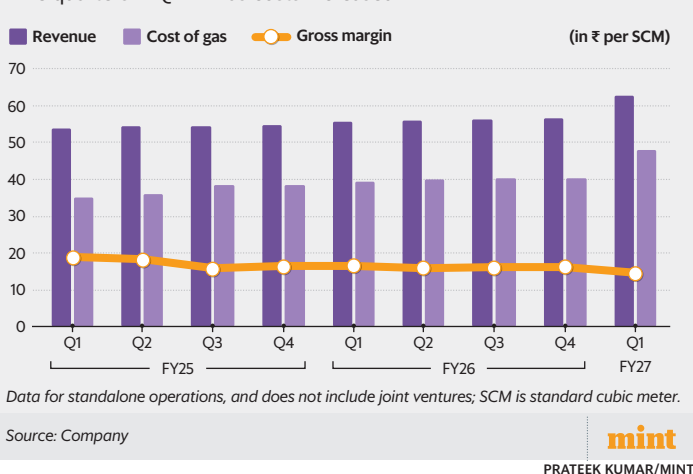
Adani Total Gas Ltd (ATGL) stock rose nearly 13% to ₹660.70 on Friday. The rise was accompanied by trading volume of 39 million shares, the highest since 27 May, indicating strong buying interest. Shares cooled off a bit on Monday, falling by 3%.

While the reason for the sudden jump in volume and price is unclear, ATGL's market capitalization (mcap) of ₹70,000 crore remains significantly higher than comparable city gas distribution (CGD) peers such as Indraprastha Gas Ltd (IGL) and Mahanagar Gas Ltd (MGL), which have market values of ₹20,800 crore and ₹10,600 crore. This compares with ATGL's consolidated net profit of ₹656 crore in FY26, well below IGL's ₹1,390 crore and MGL's ₹850 crore. The same trend is evident in Q1FY27 financials.

The ATGL stock trades at a price-to-earnings multiple of over 100

Profitability pressure

Adani Total Gas's gross margin per SCM was the lowest in at least nine quarters in Q1FY27 as costs increased.



Data for standalone operations, and does not include joint ventures; SCM is standard cubic meter.

Source: Company

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

based on FY26 earnings, and the gauge is likely to be above 100 based on FY27 estimated earnings arrived at by annualizing Q1FY27 net profit. The question then is why the stock enjoys such a high valuation? Do future earnings prospects merit the Street's optimism?

True, there is the advantage of

having strong parentage as Adani group and TotalEnergies have equal stakes of 37.4% each. The presence of France's TotalEnergies, the world's second-largest private player in the liquefied natural gas (LNG) market, should help in strategic sourcing of imported natural gas. As of Q1FY27, 38% of the required

natural gas is imported, while the rest is sourced domestically.

While TotalEnergies could ensure gas availability, there is currently no pricing advantage when the blended cost of gas is taken into account. For instance, ATGL's blended cost of gas per standard cubic meter (scm) in Q1FY27 was ₹48 versus ₹43 for IGL and ₹40 for MGL. In fact, the higher cost meant ATGL's gross margin per scm was the lowest in at least the last nine quarters at ₹14.60.

ATGL's key advantage over its CGD peers is its wider, relatively underpenetrated geographical footprint. It is present in 53 geographies (19 via joint ventures with Indian Oil Corp.) in 125 districts. In comparison, IGL serves across 12 geographical areas covering 32 districts. MGL has the smallest geographical footprint, serving 8 areas. Also, unlike IGL and MGL, which are dominant in metro cities and adjoining areas that are relatively

more saturated, ATGL operates across wider, less-penetrated geographical areas.

But its wider geographical presence is yet to translate into higher revenues. ATGL's revenues are less than half of the biggest player IGL's FY26 and Q1FY27 revenues. Despite

this, investors may have been shunning IGL lately due to Delhi-NCR's clean transportation policy. For now, the policy aims to pivot from CNG to electric-based commercial transport, but there is a possibility of passenger vehicles being brought under similar restrictions in future.

This could hurt IGL's revenues, and in the meantime ATGL's revenues may well catch up.

But will that justify the steep valuation that ATGL enjoys? Not really. Perhaps investors should consider if they are better off investing in relatively cheaper options like IGL and MGL.

REACH VS REVENUE

ATGL's advantage is its wider, relatively underpenetrated geographical footprint

ATGL's revenues are less than half of the biggest player IGL's FY26 and Q1FY27 revenues

NSE IPO gets 5.7x subscription amid subdued demand

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National Stock Exchange of India Ltd's (NSE) \$2.4-billion initial public offering (IPO), one of the largest in India's history, was subscribed 5.7 times as investors delivered their verdict on the long-awaited deal.

The demand was mainly driven by institutional buyers who bid for 12.7 times their allotted portion, according to data on BSE Ltd's website. The non-institutional investor category—reserved for wealthy individuals—was subscribed 6.5 times, while the retail investor portion was covered 1.3 times.

The subscription brings NSE closer to completing a decade-long journey to the second-largest IPO in India. The exchange first filed to go public in 2016, but the plan was delayed for years amid regulatory and governance issues.

Still, demand was subdued compared with other large Indian IPOs in recent years. I.G. Electronics Inc.'s \$1.3 billion offering of its Indian unit was subscribed about 54 times in October last year, while SBI Cards & Payment Services Ltd's IPO was subscribed almost 27 times in 2020. HDB Financial Services Ltd.'s offering drew bids for about 17 times the shares on offer last year.

NSE offered shares at ₹1,700-1,785 apiece. The offering consists entirely of shares sold by existing investors, meaning the exchange won't receive any proceeds. At the top end of the range, the offering set to raise about ₹22,600 crore, trailing only Hyundai

Institutional buyers drove demand for the NSE IPO, as they bid for 12.7 times their allotted portion



NSE offered shares at ₹1,700-1,785 apiece. REUTERS

Motor India Ltd's ₹27,900 crore share sale in 2024 among Indian IPOs.

With lower than expected demand, NSE's grey market premium fell to about 3% on Monday from a peak of about 16% on 7 September, according to *ipowatch.in*.

One key risk is tighter regulatory scrutiny of speculative derivatives trading, a business central to NSE's profitability. Options trading accounted for about 60% of operating reve-

enue in the year ended March, leaving the exchange exposed to measures aimed at curbing activity in the segment.

Before opening the order book, NSE allocated ₹6,746 crore of shares to anchor investors. They included global money managers such as Goldman Sachs, HSBC, Fidelity and Eastspring, as well as sovereign wealth funds GIC and Abu Dhabi Investment Authority. Among domestic investors, Life Insurance Corporation of India, SBI Funds Management Ltd and ICICI Prudential Asset Management Co. Ltd were among the largest participants.

The IPO, which opened on Thursday, closed for subscription on Monday.

JSW Cement's cost trends to decide near-term fate

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As competition for market share intensifies among large cement makers, JSW Cement's expanding reach augurs well for medium-term growth. In March, JSW commissioned its first greenfield integrated manufacturing plant in north India at Nagaur in Rajasthan. This plant achieved an average utilization of 55% in Q1FY27 and a further ramp-up should buoy volume growth in the north.

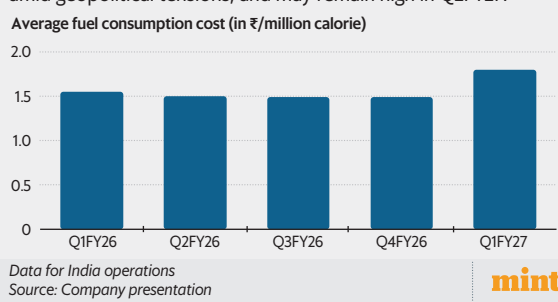
To expand the addressable

market in north India, JSW is boosting its presence beyond Rajasthan and Haryana into Punjab, western and central Uttar Pradesh, the management said on an earnings call. It has also identified central India as a priority market, with new expansions likely soon.

JSW is looking to become a pan-India cement maker. It targets a grinding capacity of 35.3 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) by 2028 from 24.1 mtpa. In the same span, clinker capacity is expected to rise from 9.74 mtpa to 13 mtpa. JSW is moving from a predominantly south-

Heading north

JSW Cement's average fuel consumption cost rose in Q1FY27 amid geopolitical tensions, and may remain high in Q2FY27.



Data for India operations

Source: Company presentation

DEEPAK MISHRA/MINT

ground granulated blast furnace slag (GGBS)-led franchise toward a more diversified, integrated and geo-

graphically balanced cement company, Motilal Oswal Financial Services said on 18 September. The firm has

easy access to GGBS raw materials from group company JSW Steel. The north India plant is a key growth driver, providing both incremental capacity and access to a more profitable/balanced market, Motilal Oswal said. The south India cement market has been grappling with oversupply, which has kept pricing muted in this market. This has been a constraint for cement makers with exposure in south India. North and central India have relatively more favourable demand-supply dynamics and better pricing prospects.

In Q2FY27, cost control

efforts by companies would be a distinguishing factor.

Higher power and fuel costs, packaging expenses and elevated operating costs at the Nagaur plant dragged consolidated Ebitda down 7% year-on-year to ₹299 crore in Q1. The management expects Q2 costs to remain broadly similar to Q1, with a reduction expected from Q3. The JSW Cement stock has declined 21% from its initial public offering issue price of ₹147 in August 2025. JSW expects volume growth in the high teens in FY27, but costs are a near-term re-rating trigger.

UPI fee to sting retailers with fatter bills, spare others

FROM PAGE 1

thing that was completely seamless will have a negative impact," he said.

Jewellery, electronics and some fashion categories could be more affected as purchases in these categories often exceed ₹2,000, Bisen added.

Surendra Mehta, national secretary of the Indian Bullion and Jewellers Association, said the proposed MDR on UPI transactions could have a significant impact on jewellers. "Jewellery is a high-value item. So, in our case, almost in every transaction there would be MDR. So, it is going to affect not only big jewellers but even the smallest of the small jewellers," he said, adding that the impact would extend to online jewellery buys, as they can exceed ₹50,000-₹75,000.

Brokerage firm Elara Securities estimates Nykaa could take a ₹29.9 crore annualized hit from MDR, equivalent to 2.6% of its estimated FY27 Ebitda. Its beauty and personal-care business now has an estimated average net sales value of ₹1,567, while Nykaa Fashion has a net AOV of ₹1,759. Net AOV is the amount paid by the customer after discounts and GST.

The estimated impact on DMart, the other major listed retailer, is 2.1% of estimated FY27 Ebitda, Elara said.



The impact on profitability will be higher for businesses where customers regularly spend more than ₹2,000. ISTOCKPHOTO

"Trent is better insulated because its AOV of ₹1,600 of Westside is offset by Zudio's much lower ₹900 basket, leaving an estimated 0.5% Ebitda impact," Karan Taurani, executive vice president at Elara Capital, told *Mint*.

The contrast is sharper with food delivery and quick-commerce firms such as Zomato, Swiggy and Blinkit, where average orders range are at ₹380-540, keeping most transactions well below the threshold.

Bisen of The Knowledge Company expects some businesses to explore ways of changing payment or purchase behaviour. "Something that was previously an impulse purchase may become a planned one," he said, pointing to likely changes such as splitting bills or opting

for installment payments.

The finance ministry has said MDR is not a charge on customers and banks have been advised to ensure it's not pass on, and UPI application providers are prohibited from levying platform fees or hidden charges.

While merchants can't pass on MDR charges, that does not mean businesses have no way of dealing with higher costs. "Every time the cost of doing business goes up, merchants have to find a way to absorb it. Sometimes that means raising the price and sometimes it means reducing the gram-mage, so the price point stays the same," Bisen said.

Elara's Taurani said firms such as Nykaa with a premium customer base and higher-value orders have relatively more flexibility to absorb the additional burden.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Mastercard to exit Pine Labs, sell 4.3% stake

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MUMBAI

Payment card services major Mastercard Inc. seeks to sell up to 49.7 million shares in Indian fintech firm Pine Labs Ltd on Tuesday through a block deal valued at up to ₹893 crore (\$93 million), according to a term sheet reviewed by *Mint*.

Mastercard Asia/Pacific Pte Ltd is offering shares at a floor price of ₹179.50 per share, which represents a 7.3% discount to Pine Labs' closing price of ₹193.70 on the National Stock Exchange on Monday.

The total volume offered represents approximately 4.3% of the firm's total outstanding equity shareholding. The proposed transaction would therefore mark the New York-based entity's exit from the company. Citigroup Global Markets India Pvt. is acting as the sole placement agent for the transaction.

Mastercard first invested in Pine Labs in 2020, putting \$100-150 million into the firm and propelling it to unicorn status. The global giant then off-loaded part of its 5.22% holding through the Pine Labs initial public offering in November 2025 by participating in the offer for sale. Mastercard's exit comes four months after its lock-in period ended in May.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Auto firms up temp hiring for cost flex

FROM PAGE 1

facturing lines as well as employees in non-production roles within factory premises, including logistics, maintenance, sales and dispatch.

The growing reliance on temporary workers comes as labour shortages and wage-related protests have disrupted industrial activity in parts of Haryana and Uttar Pradesh this year. Workers' demands have included higher wages and permanent jobs, throwing light on the rising share of non-permanent workers.

Maruti, India's largest carmaker, saw the share of temporary workers rise from 71% at the end of fiscal year 2023 (FY23) to 87% in FY26, as it expanded its factory operations. It added nearly 30,000 non-permanent workers over the period. This also reflects the amalgamation of Suzuki Motor Gujarat (SMG) with Maruti Suzuki in FY26. SMG operated the firm's largest plant in Hansapur, Gujarat.

At M&M, the share of temporary workers rose from 77% in FY23 to 86% in FY26, with the company adding nearly 30,000 workers and almost doubling its temporary workforce. Tata Motors' passenger vehicle business reported a temporary workforce share of 85% in FY26, while the figure for Hyundai was 83%. Comparable FY23 figures for the two companies were not available.

At Hero MotoCorp, India's largest two-wheeler maker, the share of temporary workers rose from 82% to 87% during the period, having added nearly 10,000 workers.



Maruti saw the share of temporary workers rise from 71% at the end of FY23 to 87% in FY26. PTI

Not all automakers have a sizable temporary workforce. At Bajaj Auto, non-permanent workers accounted for 4% of the total workforce, while TVS Motor reported no temporary workers at its factories.

A sharper shift was visible at Samvardhana Motherson, the country's largest auto component maker, where the share of temporary workers rose from 35% in FY23 to 88% in FY26. The company was among those whose work was disrupted by protests at facilities in Noida.

Although companies do not clearly disclose differences in wages between permanent and temporary workers, disclosures show shorter contract tenures provide more flexibility in managing labour costs.

Piparsania said the shift towards a predominantly non-permanent workforce should

be seen as an operational issue. "Labour shortages and worker protests this year are two sides of the same issue—the need to balance workforce flexibility with stability. When a large part of the workforce is transient, both continuity and availability can become challenges, with a direct impact on production," he said.

In July, M&M management said some of its suppliers were affected by labour crunch, curtailing output of some models.

"We were impacted. At least three or four of our suppliers were impacted pretty badly by labour shortages, first because of the gas shortage issue, then elections, and then migration of labour to the north, where wage rates had gone up," said Rajesh Jejurikar, executive director and CEO (auto and farm sector) at M&M.

Labour law covers temporary workers too. Sonam Chandwani, managing partner at K.S. Legal and Associates, said companies can cut costs by engaging temporary or contract workers, but that doesn't take them outside the labour law framework.

"The real legal issue is often the substance of the arrangement, rather than the label attached to it. If a worker is technically shown as a contract worker but is effectively recruited, supervised and controlled by the company, the arrangement can come under scrutiny." This could result in claims for employment benefits, statutory dues and other liabilities, she said.

Auto manufacturing hubs had witnessed protests over higher inflation amid the West Asia war and demands for higher minimum wages. This prompted the Haryana and Uttar Pradesh governments to hike minimum wage levels.

According to Ashim Sharma, senior partner at Nomura Research Institute, that auto firms could have invested in automating lines as seen globally for enhancing output per employee.

"Although leading amongst industries in India, automation at Indian automotive factories remains low when compared to other global markets which has driven the rising share of the contractual workforce. Companies could gain a higher competitive advantage in global value chains through investment in automation and robotics," he said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



JP Morgan's India chief aims wholesale banking top spot

Badhwar measures success through clients, wallet share, talent retention and regulatory trust

Shayan Ghosh & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Fresh into his role leading the India business of JP Morgan, the world's largest bank, Rahul Badhwar wants the unit to rank at the top in the world's sixth-largest economy. Badhwar, who joined as senior country officer in July, said in his first interview that JP Morgan can outpace rivals as a wholesale bank in India. "It's not just revenues. It's the number of clients we bank, share of wallet, do they trust us? Are we an employer of choice? Are we able to retain talent and grow talent? It's about how regulators see us," Badhwar, who spent 30 years at HSBC before joining JP Morgan, said.

In India, the bank operates investment banking—including merger and acquisition advisory, equity capital markets, and debt capital markets—alongside corporate banking spanning large companies, medium businesses, and startups. The operations are collectively classified as wholesale banking. The top job at JP Morgan was vacant since the departure of Kaustubh Kulkarni in September 2025. Kulkarni later joined rival lender Citi in December.

While the lending market is fiercely competitive due to large domestic lenders, the dealmaking space isn't void of rivals. The bank operates its investment banking business through JP Morgan India Pvt Ltd, while corporate lending falls under JPMorgan Chase Bank. As per regulatory disclosures, the bank's total credit exposure in India stood at ₹2.3 trillion as of 31 March, compared with ₹3.1 trillion for Citi India.

The Wall Street bank ranked second to Citibank in investment banking revenue earned, shows data compiled by global platform Dealogic. Preliminary data from 1 January to date shows JP Morgan earned around \$46 million in fees. It topped the league tables in



Rahul Badhwar, senior country officer, India, JP Morgan.

2025, bringing in \$116 million in fees from the Indian market.

Marquee deals the firm has advised on this year include Sun Pharma's \$13 billion buyout of US's pharma major Organon and NSE's mega IPO.

With Badhwar at the helm, the bank is now trying to grab a bigger slice of the

"I am an ambassador for India, and JP Morgan in India, with our regional management, with our global management in the US. The pulse that you get sitting in the country is very different from what you would get reading research reports or just meeting people once in New York, London or Hong Kong," said

Data from NSDL shows that overseas investors have been net sellers of \$26.3 billion in local equities so far this year, while making net purchases of \$7.2 billion in debt. In 2025, foreign investors net sold \$18.9 billion in equities and bought \$6.6 billion in debt. "I think one of the challenges India has had historically is that it has traded at a considerable valuation premium over the MSCI Emerging Market Index," he said.

He added that while high valuations are acceptable at times, they become far more noticeable when a market is seen as a laggard—especially over the past couple of years, when artificial intelligence has emerged as one of the primary drivers of equity markets. "Then people start thinking about it and questioning it, which is why, we've definitely seen capital at times leave India in search of other opportunities within Asia Pacific," he said.

Another challenge, Badhwar said, is rising US Treasury yields. As these yields climb, global capital typically flows back toward such safe-haven assets rather than riskier emerging markets. The yield on the 10-year US sovereign bond recently crossed 5%, hitting a 19-year high.

"When your risk-free yields are rising, the bar that you set in terms of the returns you want from your investments in emerging markets also moves higher. That is the same in all markets, not just India," Badhwar also urges clients to focus on what India has, not what it lacks.

"All the capital can't be chasing the same theme—AI for instance. If one needs to have another theme, for me that's where India comes in."

Meanwhile, JP Morgan chairman and CEO Jamie Dimon is in India for the bank's conference in Mumbai on 21–22 September. He and other senior executives met Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday.

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LEADERSHIP GOALS

JP Morgan serves firms of all sizes via its corporate lending and investment banking businesses

IT ranked second to Citi in investment banking fees this year, after leading the tables in 2025

BADHWAR plans to deepen India client relationships and identify growth opportunities

HE believes India still offers an alternative investment theme amid the AI boom

pie in India. He said his immediate priorities include executing J.P. Morgan's strategy in India, meeting all clients to understand their needs, and interacting with the local team to understand their requirements. Having spent most of his career abroad, Badhwar now wants to leverage his on-ground presence to highlight the opportunity in India.

Badhwar. The aim, he added, is to ensure that the bank continues to invest and double down on the opportunities.

Foreign investors have pulled back from Indian markets recently, particularly equities. India underperformed the broader emerging markets index, with the Nifty generating a return of negative 10.40% year-to-date in 2026.

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DailyObjects, which makes lifestyle accessories, is finalizing a ₹350 crore funding round led by Xponentia Capital along with Anicut Capital's growth equity fund, three people familiar with the matter said.

The funding round is likely to take place at a higher valuation of about ₹1,000 crore, the people added. "The transactions will be a mix of primary and secondary share sale by existing investors," one of the people cited above said, adding that The Rainmaker Group is advising the company on the transaction.

A second person added that the primary component would be used to expand its product line and distribution access to tap into a wider customer base. While DailyObjects declined to comment, Xponentia, Anicut and The Rainmaker Group did not respond to *Mint's* requests for a comment till the time of publishing. The fresh developments



The round is expected to take place at a valuation of about ₹1,000 crore.

come as the Indian consumer demographic is evolving, and with it, tastes. The country's tech market is now driven heavily by younger buyers, especially Gen Z, who treat their gadgets as part of their personal style. They are design-literate, aware of global trends and increasingly unwilling to settle for products that don't fit into their aesthetics, *Mint* reported in August.

Founded in 2012 by Pankaj Garg and Saurav Adlakha, DailyObjects began with the aim

of reimagining everyday items by combining great design, tech and utility. Its product offerings include phone cases, watch accessories, charging solutions, tech add-ons, laptop sleeves, stands and organizers.

It has a presence across over 250 retail spaces in over 85 cities, including major cities and key airports, as well as select Apple Premium Retail locations across India, according to the company's website.

It also sells bags and wallets, pouches and work essentials spanning desks, stands and other stationery items, according to its official website. It competes with top lifestyle and tech accessory brands like Spigen, Casetify and Chumbak, as per online reports.

Firki Wholesale Pvt. Ltd, which operates the DailyObjects brand, reported an operating income of ₹10.3 crore in FY25, compared with ₹84.4 crore a year earlier. Its losses widened to ₹15.91 crore from ₹10.07 crore, show documents sourced by Tofler from the ministry of corporate affairs.

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Expert's View

BUSINESS ENTERPRISES OF TOMORROW

2026

Flavio Moraes Junior
MD & CCE
Ingram Micro

through a wide range of cutting-edge features, functionalities and capabilities. One such example is the Xvantage Enable AI program that empowers partners with the digital adeptness required to envision and drive a success-driven AI journey. Similarly, our Xvantage Integration (XI) Hub and Model Context Protocol (MCP) Servers provide a secure integration layer that enables real-time, intelligent connectivity and integration of data, platforms, tools, and AI assistants. All these play a pivotal role in removing friction from our partners' AI journey and enable them to accelerate innovation and drive growth.

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INGRAM MICRO

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Expert's View

BUSINESS ENTERPRISES OF TOMORROW

2026

Vinod Patel
Founder Director
Almonard Pvt Ltd

products that are not only technologically sound, but commercially relevant across industries.

Competition keeps every business alert, and we view it as a catalyst for continuous improvement rather than a distraction. Our focus remains on creating greater value for customers and reaching them in the most meaningful ways. When that commitment is consistent, growth becomes a natural outcome.

What key systems or capabilities has Almonard strengthened to support sustained scale?

Almonard has strengthened its foundation for sustained scale through strategic investments across manufacturing, operations, technology, and people. A key milestone in this journey has been the commissioning of our new manufacturing unit in Maharashtra, which significantly enhances our production capacity, improves supply chain flexibility, and enables us to respond faster to evolving market demands across India.

Operationally, we have focused on disciplined raw material planning and robust inventory control systems to improve efficiency, optimize costs, and ensure continuity in an increasingly dynamic business environment. These measures have helped us build a more agile and resilient organization.

On the market side, we have strengthened our digital lead generation and customer outreach capabilities, allowing us to engage more effectively with both industrial and retail

customers across geographies. Equally important has been our investment in people and leadership development. We have built empowered teams with strong execution capabilities, while also fostering a culture where leaders are encouraged to make decisions that serve the company's long-term growth, sustainability, and values.

How is Almonard positioning itself to compete in both domestic and global markets?

India remains our core market—our karma-bhoomi. For over five decades, Almonard has built its reputation by serving everyone from SMEs and mid-market enterprises to some of India's largest industrial players. Our focus continues to be on delivering dependable, high-performance solutions tailored to the evolving needs of Indian industry.

Having said that, we are steadily expanding our global footprint. The Middle East continues to emerge as a strong growth market for us despite geopolitical uncertainties, driven by increasing demand for robust industrial ventilation and air management solutions. We also see significant long-term potential in emerging African economies, where industrial infrastructure is rapidly developing. Our strategy is clear: strengthen our leadership at home while building a sustainable and future-ready international presence.

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GAIL Gas looks for bankers to manage its ₹3,100-cr IPO

Agnidev Bhattacharya
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MUMBAI

GAIL Gas Ltd has begun the process of appointing investment banks for an initial public offering (IPO) that could raise up to ₹3,100 crore, according to a document reviewed by *Mint*.

The city gas distribution company, a wholly owned subsidiary of state-run GAIL (India) Ltd, is seeking up to four book-running lead managers to manage the offer.

"The company is planning on conducting a pre-bid meeting with all interested merchant bankers this week to address their queries, with bids expected to start coming in by early next month," a person aware of the developments told *Mint*, seeking anonymity.

The advisers will draft and file the draft red herring prospectus and final prospectus with Securities and Exchange Board of India and exchanges, according to the scope of work in the document.

Besides, they will oversee the appointment and work of transaction intermediaries, including domestic and international legal counsel and registrars.

The IPO is part of India's Asset Monetisation Pipeline 2.0, under which state-owned companies will divest stakes in their subsidiaries between FY27 and FY30. The proceeds will be retained by the companies as monetized value. Niti Aayog's February report projected GAIL Gas IPO for FY28.

A query to GAIL Gas did not elicit a response till press time.



GAIL Gas is a wholly owned subsidiary of GAIL. REUTERS

Incorporated in 2008, GAIL Gas implements city gas distribution projects. It operates in 16 geographical areas across nine states, including Madhya Pradesh, Haryana, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and Karnataka, and is eyeing Andhra, Goa and Assam.

The firm plans to acquire six geographical areas from its parent for a consideration of ₹1,500 crore. It expects the areas to have strong growth potential.

The city gas distribution firm is seeking up to four book-running lead managers to manage the mooted share sale

"However, amid the Middle East conflict and resultant reduction in LNG shipments, gas supplies to industrial customers have curtailed, which may impact industrial customers volumes in the near term," India Ratings said in a 26 April note. "Nevertheless, Ind-Ra expects the impact to be partly mitigated by the relatively stable and higher-margin CNG volumes, supported by priority gas allocation and expansion of CNG infrastructure."

In FY26, GAIL Gas reported turnover of ₹12,681 crore, up from ₹12,229 crore in FY25.

Value-commerce players bet on deeper user engagement

Firms are expanding their playbook beyond low prices to win shoppers, drive repeat demand

Sowmya Ramasubramanian
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BENGALURU

India's value-commerce market is moving beyond the simple promise of cheap products, with platforms experimenting with new ways to attract shoppers, deepen engagement, and drive repeat purchases.

Flipkart's Shopsy, launched in 2021, has rebuilt its app around artificial intelligence-powered personalization, video-led discovery and gamification, turning shopping into a more interactive experience for Gen Z and the country's next 100 million shoppers.

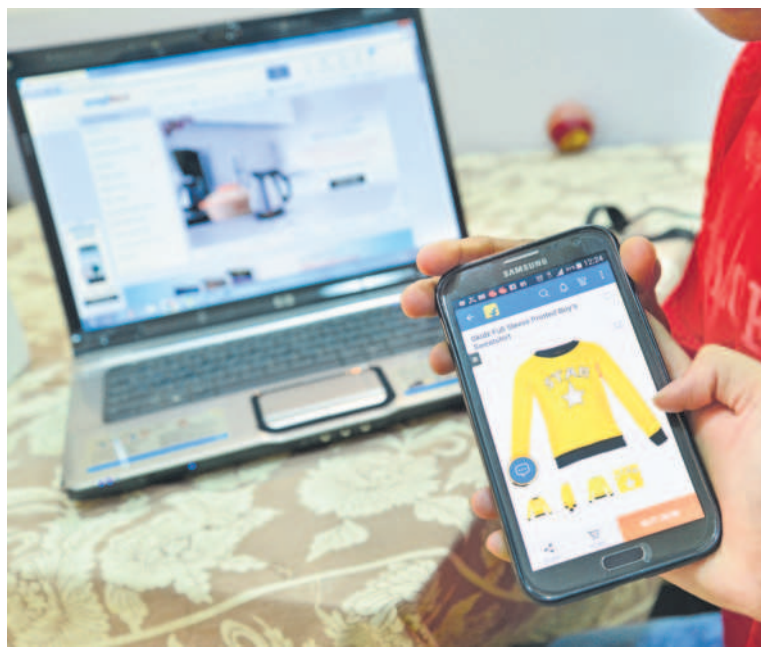
This has shifted Shopsy from an offers-led destination towards an engagement-led platform, with games, rewards, and video built into the shopping journey.

Amazon Bazaar is taking a different route. After starting as a separate destination for low-priced products, Amazon has brought value commerce deeper into its main app. Sellers no longer need separate listings for Bazaar, while qualifying products can receive a Bazaar badge and appear in regular Amazon search and in the dedicated Bazaar store.

"When you're coupling crazy low prices with Amazon's trust, we believe it's creating an unbeatable combination that customers are not able to find elsewhere online," Sameer Lalwani, head of Amazon Bazaar, told *Mint*.

He added that sellers have grown threefold year-on-year over the past year, while customers and orders have grown fivefold on-year. Customers from tier-II and tier-III cities have grown eightfold on-year.

Kunal Bahl-founded Snapdeal, meanwhile, is leaning heavily into fashion and apparel within the value-commerce segment as it prepares for a ₹300-crore fresh issue initial public offering (IPO).



The next wave of online value retail will be about mixing affordability with real engagement, shopping frequency, and standout customer experiences. MINT

Shopsy is also focusing on localization. It has more than 16 million products across 1,300-plus categories, sourced directly from sellers and micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs), and uses regional storefronts, try's value lifestyle e-commerce market will grow to \$40 billion by 2030 from \$4 billion in 2019. E-commerce is expected to be the fastest-growing channel in the segment, with a 26% compound annual growth rate (CAGR) between 2019 and

NEW GAME PLAN

SHOPSy has rebuilt app around AI-based personalization, video-led discovery and gamification

AMAZON has brought value commerce, Bazaar, deeper into its main app

SNAPDEAL is leaning heavily into fashion and apparel within the value-commerce segment

THIS comes as the value opportunity is expected to expand to \$40 billion by 2030 from \$4 billion in 2019

AI-powered discovery, and a zero-commission model to strengthen its value proposition, the company said in response to *Mint*'s emailed queries.

This comes as the value opportunity itself expands rapidly. Market research firm Kearney estimates that the coun-

2026, compared with 12% for modern trade and 5% for general trade.

Yet the market remains overwhelmingly offline. E-commerce's share of value lifestyle retail will rise from just 4% in 2019 to 13% by 2026 and 19% by 2030, according to Kearney, leaving offline

value retailers with the bulk of the market even as digital becomes an increasingly important channel.

Aakash Agrawal, associate director (digital and new-age business) at Anand Rathi Investment Banking, said the next phase of the market would involve a shift beyond price.

"The next wave of online value retail won't be a pure race to the bottom on price but about mixing affordability with real engagement, shopping frequency, and standout customer experiences," he said.

While there are no specific market-share estimates for value e-commerce, Meesho is widely considered the segment leader, while Shopsy, Amazon Bazaar and Snapdeal remain relatively small, according to Satish Meena, analyst at market research firm Datum Intelligence.

Meesho's revenue jumped 48% year-on-year to ₹3,713 crore in the June quarter, while losses narrowed to ₹133 crore. Shopsy's new app embeds gamification directly into the shopping experience. Logins, streaks and games earn SuperCoins that can be redeemed against purchases, creating a loop between engagement and value.

New users are onboarded through a quiz-style experience designed to surface personalized offers from their first session, the company said.

The strategy is aimed at consumers whose shopping behaviour is increasingly shaped by content and interaction. Shopsy says tier-II-plus cities account for 65% of new shopper growth, and Gen Z makes up almost half of India's online shopper base.

Agrawal of Anand Rathi Investment Banking sees creators, short-form content and gaming becoming increasingly important to online discovery.

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Rise in shorts comes alongside a Nifty pullback. BLOOMBERG

Bearish FPI bets at record high on war, oil concerns

FROM PAGE 1

from a previous record of 279,467 contracts on 27 March to 145,118 contracts on 6 August, supporting the market recovery.

However, with the situation in West Asia turning for the worse again, they have raised shorts to fresh record levels. This has coincided with the Nifty pulling back 5% since 6 August to 23,414.3 on Monday.

"The persistence and expansion of the conflict has again cast a shadow on a recovery and increased the scope for uncertainty," said SK Joshi, consultant at Khambatta Securities.

"I book part profits at highs and am using the proceeds to invest in InvITs (infrastructure investment trust) where I can earn around 11% annual returns, Joshi, a former director finance at BPCL, said.

FPIs have not only sold futures on Nifty and Bank Nifty but have also sold shares worth ₹20,974 crore so far this month, according to depository data, after turning net buyers worth ₹49,831 crore in July and August on hopes of oil prices trending lower with a resolution to the conflict.

However, their hopes have been dashed with the war expanding from the Strait of Hormuz to the Red Sea. Oil, which corrected from \$120 a barrel at the height of the conflict in end-March to \$82.49 on 6 August, flared up again to \$103.87 on Friday. Oil partially reversed course on Monday, with the November contract of Brent falling to \$99.63, lower by 4.08% from its previous close.

FPIs have largely remained sellers of Indian shares over the past two and a half years amid heightened tariffs imposed by the US, being bypassed by the global AI trade and, more recently, the war in West Asia.

They sold Indian shares worth ₹1.27 trillion in FY25, ₹1.8 trillion in FY26 and ₹1.14 trillion in FY27 through 18 September, according to depository data.

'A Trusts-Tata Sons divorce would make Jamsetji turn in his grave'

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI

Abhishek Manu Singhvi, five-term Member of Parliament and senior lead counsel for Tata Trusts, said the fundamental issue in the Tata Trusts versus Tata Sons imbroglio is that the rights of shareholders and owners cannot be nullified.

And the larger issue, he said in an interview to *Hindustan Times*, is the 100-year legacy of the Tata group and rupturing of the fundamental hyphenated relationship between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons. *Edited excerpts:*

In 2016, you fought the case between the Tata group and Cyrus Mistry. Now you will fight the Tata Trusts versus N. Chandrasekaran

case.

I know each principal actor in this controversy personally. I also have the highest regard for them. But there's no option but to appear for one side.

What is the fundamental issue in this legal battle?

The fundamental rights of shareholders and owners cannot be nullified. This is not a fight between two or three individuals or companies or entities. It is a larger fight concerning shareholders

and owners' primacy.

No one can deny the 66% ownership of Tata Sons by Tata Trust. You can't allow corporate governance to be turned on its head by a runaway board excluding the owners of the entity on whose board they sit. It raises a larger question for every shareholder and would have a disastrous effect on larger principles of



corporate governance if shareholder ownership could be nullified in this manner.

But the Board of Tata Sons has reappointed Chandrasekaran through a majority vote. The issue here is the meaning, effect and application of a very small number of Articles, especially Articles 121 and 118. A 66% shareholder is empow-

ered to pack the board with its nominees. But Tata Trusts decided to cede much of that ownership by only insisting on a minimum of one-third board nominees whereas normal shareholder rights would entitle them to much more on Tata Sons.

But to protect their sharing, a provision was made in Article

118 for an affirmative vote—another form of a veto to protect their large shareholding. Article 118 says that any decision of the board requiring voting must involve at least a majority of the Trust nominees' affirmative assent.

Since there are two out of six Trust nominees, no board agenda can be considered unless there is the assent of a majority within the two Tata Trust nominees.

It does not require rocket science to realize that a majority within two is, in fact, two.

It does not require rocket science to realize that a majority within two is, in fact, two. Consequently, the moment Noel Tata dissented, there was no question of anything proceeding further as the board is denuded of jurisdiction to even consider the issue,

much less vote on it under the specific language of Article 118. **What about casting vote?**

The casting vote arises when the entire board faces a tie or a deadlock among all six members. That will happen only if the majority of the

Trust nominees agree with the issue on which the vote is being taken. The moment Noel Tata expressed his disagreement, the issue could not go to the board at all, and consequently could not be voted

upon by the board; thus, there could be no occasion for the casting vote to arise.

Why do you think the four members sidestepped Article 121?

Knowing the law is never an

antidote against wrongdoing. Wrongdoing occurs because of predetermination to reach a result. That is the best answer one can give in view of the elementary text of the Article. The bizarre part of the whole process is that there is a separate, detailed Article, namely 118, which comprehensively stipulates the entire process to select the chair...

What might be the possible impact on the Tata legacy?

The larger issue in this imbroglio is the 100-year legacy, the rupturing of the fundamental hyphenated relationship between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons. People do not realize this destroys the vision of the founder of the entire Tata family and the very concept of the Tata enterprise that is unique in India. Implementing the divorce between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons would make Jamsetji Tata turn over in his grave.

TATA SONS AT A CROSSROADS: WHO GUARDS THE INSTITUTION?



EXPERT
VIEW
PRABAL BASU ROY

Respond to this column at feedback@livemint.com

The controversy surrounding the reappointment of N. Chandrasekaran as chairman of Tata Sons is larger than the tenure of one individual. It raises a fundamental question about the governance architecture of one of India's most consequential business institutions: who ultimately guards the Tata institution—the professional board, its controlling shareholder, Tata Trusts, or the regulator?

The current developments could mark a turning point in the Tata model. Tata Sons is unlike an ordinary holding company. The Tata Trusts hold about two-thirds of its equity, giving philanthropy and institutional purpose a critical place in its ownership structure. Yet, the operating group has increasingly been run through professional management and a modern corporate board.

That creates a delicate governance compact: the Trusts provide continuity of purpose and a long-term institutional anchor; the board exercises independent fiduciary judgment; professional management runs the businesses; and the Reserve Bank of India, under its statutory mandate over systemically important financial entities, demands greater oversight and potentially public-market accountability.

The difficulty arises when these roles collide, as does the timing of the collision.

The Chandrasekaran episode exposes precisely such a fault line. If the board believes continuity of executive leadership is in Tata Sons' larger interests, should it be able to decide independently of the principal shareholder? Conversely, if the controlling shareholder believes a different succession arrangement is necessary, how much weight should that view carry? What is the board's strategy for securing the ultimate test of shareholder support for its decision? In the stormy Cyrus Mistry matter, Ratan Tata imposed his will on the Tata Sons board by virtue of his control over the Trusts. Given that precedent of "managing" Tata Sons, what really has changed this time around with Noel Tata, given that the Articles of Association governing Tata Sons remain intact?

There is no clarity in these matters, but international experience offers useful lessons.

Consider Robert Bosch. Its ownership structure deliberately separates economic ownership, voting control and management. The Robert Bosch Stiftung is the overwhelming economic owner, while voting rights are exercised through a separate industrial trust structure designed to preserve entrepreneurial independence.

Bertelsmann has another variation. Foundations hold most of its capital, while voting rights are exercised through a governance structure combining family and non-family representation.

At Novo Nordisk, a foundation can remain the dominant long-term owner while the operating company is publicly listed. In my view, the crucial feature is not the absence of competing interests but institutional clarity about who does what.

These examples challenge a misconception that may increasingly confront Tata: that professional management and philanthropic ownership are inherently incompatible, or that public

listing necessarily destroys the Tata model.

Neither proposition is necessarily true. The real issue is the design of the governance compact.

The RBI's intervention adds another dimension. Its upper layer framework for non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) imposes enhanced requirements on entities whose size, complexity and interconnectedness warrant greater oversight. Tata Sons' inclusion is, therefore, understandable from a financial stability perspective.

But Tata Sons is also uniquely structured and treating it as a regulated financial holding company has consequences beyond compliance. Mandatory listing could introduce public shareholders, continuous market scrutiny and a new layer of accountability into an entity historically anchored by the Tata Trusts.

That does not make regulation inappropriate, but it raises questions about the transparency of the RBI's rationale for the delayed decision-making, changing rules midway through the process, its timing, and, of course, its immediate precedents. Either way, it makes the consequences of this regulation worthy of serious institutional discussion.

Listing could bring greater transparency and price discovery, but in capital markets like India, it could also alter the balance among long-term institutional purpose, market expectations, and attract corporate predators. The question is whether its governance architecture can protect both legitimate public accountability and the distinctive purpose of the age-old Tata institution.

This is why the chairman controversy matters. The immediate temptation is to view it as a contest between

the board and the Trusts. The more important question is whether Tata Sons has an explicit constitutional framework for resolving such disagreements in the absence of towering personalities like JRD Tata and Dorabji Tata.

Given this reality of the times, a new governance compact should define the respective powers of the Tata Trusts, the Tata Sons board and professional management; establish where shareholder consent is essential and where the board has independent authority; and set out how succession decisions are to be made. If listing becomes inevitable, it should also clarify how public shareholders' rights will coexist with the Trusts' long-term institutional purpose.

The international examples suggest that durable foundation-controlled enterprises do not eliminate the tension between ownership and management. They institutionalize it.

That may be the real lesson for Tata.

Tata Group's future strength will not depend simply on who occupies the chairman's office, nor on whether the Trusts or the board prevails in one dispute. It will depend on whether Tata Sons can convert an inherited governance tradition into a clearly articulated modern institutional framework—one capable of surviving changes in personalities, markets, regulators and generations.

Chandrasekaran's reappointment and the RBI action may represent less a crisis of leadership than a moment of institutional reckoning.

The Tata question is no longer simply: who should lead Tata Sons? It is more fundamental: what should Tata Sons evolve into—and who should ultimately determine its course, and above all, who guards this institution from predators looking for what is inarguably India's crown jewel?

Prabal Basu Roy is a Sloan Fellow of the London Business School, a board member and former group CFO. Views are personal.

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Adani targets 5GW in Uzbek pumped storage projects

Talks come as Uzbekistan seeks to expand renewable energy capacity, diversify its power mix

Rituraj Baruah & Ramita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Adani Group is in talks with the Uzbekistan government to develop four pumped storage projects (PSPs) with a combined capacity of around 5GW, as the Central Asian nation looks to expand renewable power and add storage to its electricity system, according to two people aware of the development.

Representatives of the Adani Group held talks in August with Uzbekistan government officials, including investment, industry and trade minister Laziz Kudratov, to discuss hydropower and PSP projects in the country, the people said.

"The initial talks are for around 5GW of capacity across four projects. These projects may be in one region," said one of the two people cited above, requesting anonymity.

Using the Central Electricity Authority's (CEA) average cost of ₹6 crore per megawatt (MW) for setting up a PSP as a benchmark, the proposed capacity would translate into an indicative investment of ₹30,000 crore.

Pumped storage projects store electricity by pumping water to an upper reservoir when demand is low or renewable generation is in surplus, and releasing it through turbines when demand peaks, providing long-duration storage as renewable power generation increases.

The talks come as Uzbekistan seeks to expand renewable energy capacity and diversify its power mix. Between 2016 and 2025, its installed renewable power capacity increased from 1.88GW to more than 10GW, largely driven by solar power installations. Uzbekistan has committed to sourcing 50% of its electricity from renewables by 2030 and achieving net-zero emissions by 2050.



The Adani Group is currently developing around 3GW of PSP capacity in India. REUTERS

The country also has significant untapped hydropower potential. Operational hydropower capacity is around 2.5GW, compared with estimated potential of up to 12GW. Hydropower currently accounts for 10-14% of Uzbekistan's total electricity generation of 87 billion kilowatt-hour.

executives. Azimjon Ahmadjanov, first deputy chairman of the management board of O'zbekgidroenergo JSC, also took part in the talks. O'zbekgidroenergo, or Uzbekhydroenergo JSC, is an Uzbek government-owned hydropower company.

During Prime Minister Narendra

A presidential resolution adopted in May envisages three large PSPs in Uzbekistan by 2032.

For Uzbekistan, PSPs could support grid stability and the integration of its growing renewable-energy capacity. For Adani, the talks would extend the group's push into hydropower and energy storage beyond India.

Queries emailed to the spokespersons for Adani Group, Uzbekistan Embassy in New Delhi and Uzbek ministry of investment, industry, and trade remained unanswered until press time.

Adani Green Energy Ltd is building a significant presence in India's hydropower and PSP space, as the country expands storage capacity to support its energy transition and maintain grid stability as renewable power generation grows.

The Adani Group is currently developing around 3GW of PSP capacity in India across three projects in Andhra Pradesh and Maharashtra. Another 11 projects, with a cumulative capacity of 16.65GW across Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Assam, are under survey and investigation for approval from the relevant central and state authorities.

The group also has experience in hydropower outside India. In Bhutan, Adani Power in January this year commenced commercial operations of the 570MW Wangchhu hydroelectric project. In May 2025, the Adani Group and Druk Green Power signed a memorandum of understanding to jointly develop 5GW of hydropower projects in Bhutan.

The proposed Uzbek investment could also deepen India's commercial presence in Central Asia, where China and other countries have been expanding their economic and strategic footprint.

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Reality TV's celebrity casting coup: rise of crossover hosts

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Indian reality TV shows, once typically hosted by popular actors, are increasingly turning to public figures from diverse fields to pique curiosity and expand their audience base.

For instance, cricketer Rohit Sharma is hosting a family game show titled 'Family Full House' for Sony Pictures Networks India (SPNI), while JioStar has roped in former cricket captain Sourav Ganguly for the latest season of 'Bigg Boss Bangla'. Earlier, entrepreneur Ashneer Grover had hosted Amazon MX Player's 'Rise and Fall'.

Experts say the role of a reality show host has evolved significantly over time. Earlier, a big celebrity name was often enough to generate initial interest. Today, broadcasters and streaming platforms are paying much closer attention to whether a host's personality is a natural fit for the format.

The biggest benefit is they can bring audiences that may not otherwise enter the show's universe. A sports person, for instance, can bring in a sports audience, a business personality can woo younger, tech-savvy and entrepreneurial viewers, while creators can bring highly engaged online communities.

From a media and marketing perspective, this gives the show additional entry points beyond its core audience.

"The fact that someone may not be a conventional television host can be an advantage. If audiences already know the personality but haven't seen them in this environment before, there is an element of



Rohit Sharma is hosting a family game show titled 'Family Full House' for Sony Pictures Networks India. SONY PICTURES NETWORKS INDIA

discovery. You're creating a new side of someone the audience thought they already knew. That can create curiosity, spontaneity, and some of the most interesting moments in the format," an SPNI spokesperson said. The right host can, therefore, become part of the proposition itself rather than just taking the audience through the show, the spokesperson added.

Choice of host is increasingly about finding the right personality for the format and audience, rather than just a familiar face, a JioStar spokesperson said. That said, audiences connect with the format, the personalities and the moments they can engage with

and share. "Further proof of this is when we've seen huge success in formats such as The 50, where there is no traditional 'face' for a host. Viewers were exposed to an unnamed masked figure 'The Lion', yet the show and gameplay itself was so immersive it drew viewers in," he added.

Entertainment experts say the industry is witnessing a shift from traditional star power to relatable authority.

According to Raj Mishra, managing director and chief executive officer (CEO), Chrtbox, an influencer and digital marketing company, broadcasters aren't necessarily moving away from actors; they're moving away from generic celebrity and toward hosts whose existing public identity does some of the storytelling for the show even before a single episode airs.

"A cricketer or a business personality often brings a completely different, sometimes non-overlapping audience, that's the real value, not just raw reach. A pure Bollywood host might guarantee glamour and a loyal fan base, but someone like Ganguly or Grover pulls in viewers who otherwise may not have tuned into a reality format at all—sports fans, business news audiences, a more male 25-45 year demographic that broadcasters have historically struggled to convert," Mishra said.

Moreover, unconventional hosts tend to generate disproportionate social-media chatter and clip-worthy moments precisely because audiences are not used to seeing them in this context. That novelty itself can become a marketing asset in the first few weeks.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

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Microsoft pledges full cloud sovereignty to Indian clients

The move comes a year after Microsoft temporarily suspended cloud services for Nayara

Yadukrishna C S & Shouvik Das
MUMBAI

Microsoft will grant its Indian clients "full sovereign control", including where their data resides, which data centres are used, and which laws apply to them, a top executive told *Mint*.

The move comes a year after the Big Tech firm temporarily suspended cloud services for Nayara Energy, an Indian energy joint venture.

In an interview on Monday, Puneet Chandok, president for South Asia at Microsoft, said the company now provides clients with "full control of the stack" as well as "full access and control" over their proprietary data.

"On the data side, we are very clear if customers want it in-country, it's their control, their keys, their locations and their chips. We give in-country data residency, and are governed by local laws. We give sovereignty with sovereign controls, confidential compute, and customers own their data and where they want to keep it," Chandok said.

The executive's words hark back to 22 July 2025, when Nayara Energy's operations on Microsoft's cloud services platform Azure were halted abruptly. By 30 July, Microsoft issued clarifications and reinstated Nayara's services, underlining that the disruptions occurred due to the enforcement of European Union sanctions on Russia. Rosneft, Russia's largest state-owned energy services firm, owns 49% of Nayara.

Under the updated framework, Microsoft will grant clients complete legal control over their on-cloud data storage, processing, and operations—ensuring overseas regulatory directives don't interrupt service delivery, Chandok said.

In-country data residency means



Puneet Chandok, president for South Asia at Microsoft.

storing a client's business information within a country's geographical borders. Meanwhile, confidential computing protects data while it is actively being processed in data centres, allowing companies to keep their informa-

sultations, and e-Shram, which 310 million unorganized workers use for job searches." Chandok added that Centre and state governments account for a "significant" portion of Microsoft's Azure client base in India, though he

independent market researcher IDC projected India's public-sector cloud market would expand to more than \$30 billion in the next three years, growing 23% annually.

Not everyone, however, is this bullish. On 29 May, Sashi Sreedharan, India managing director of Google Cloud, told *Mint* that the country's sovereign cloud spending "remains at an early stage".

Industry stakeholders believe the truth may lie somewhere in the middle. Sanchit Vir Gogia, founder and chief analyst of tech consultancy firm Greyhound Research, said while the rise of sovereign cloud services is "inevitable", the growth spurt may not arrive immediately.

"Companies such as Microsoft are leaders in the Indian cloud services market, and have long-established government relations. They will eventually leverage these relations to ramp up sovereign cloud services in the country, which will in the long run become a key revenue driver. This, though, will be slow-burn—while clients are likely to make sovereign spending commitments, the translation to real-world revenue may take some time to be realized," Gogia said. "While brands have to be conscious about adding redundancy to their data operations, it's important to note that the data centre regions for Microsoft in India would be owned by Microsoft Corporation India Private Limited, which follows Indian laws. US law is not applicable to the Indian entity, which adds a layer of immunity in case of a sweeping, direct bilateral sanction," he added.

Others warned that such a complete wipe-out, while unlikely, may not be completely out of the question.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

SAP told to resume Nayara IT aid frozen after EU curbs

Yash Tiwari & Krishna Yadav
NEW DELHI

The Delhi high court granted interim relief to Indo-Russian oil major Nayara Energy on Monday, allowing its plea against the Indian arm of German software service provider SAP over the suspension of critical software services following European Union (EU) sanctions.

A bench led by Justice Vikas Mahajan allowed Nayara's application seeking the restoration of SAP India's suspended services.

During the proceedings, SAP's counsel requested the court to keep the judgement in abeyance for a few weeks. The court declined the request and asked the counsel to review the judgement first.

The court had previously found that losing SAP support could leave Nayara's software infrastructure exposed to system failures, security vulnerabilities, and critical bugs. Highlighting Nayara's role in meeting roughly 8% of India's energy needs, the court emphasized the necessity of continuous technical backing. "For critical infrastructure of this scale, an uninterrupted flow of technical support services is absolutely essential," read a copy of the order reviewed by *Mint*.

SAP had argued that providing support could subject its German parent company, SAP SE, to criminal liability under EU sanctions. However, the court drew a clear line between the Indian entity, SAP India, and its parent firm. "On the other hand, restoring the support services poses no inconvenience to defendant no. 1, an Indian corporate



Nayara argued the disruption 'poses a serious risk to India's sovereignty and public interest'.

REUTERS

entity, especially when defendant no.1 itself has expressed that it would have continued to provide the support services had there been no trade sanctions," the order noted.

The dispute began in July 2025, when SAP India Pvt. Ltd suspended all critical software support services, including SAP ECC support (maintenance for its legacy core business suite), marketplace access, SSCR keys (developer credentials required to modify SAP source code), and expert

services. SAP said this was done after the EU imposed sanctions on Rosneft, a Russian oil refinery that has a 49.13% stake in Nayara.

Nayara approached the Delhi high court in September, saying the suspension blocked access to software critical for refinery operations and regulatory compliance. The company noted it was unable to implement goods and tax services (GST) 2.0 updates and argued that the disruption "poses a serious risk to India's sovereignty and public interest", given that its refinery accounts for 8.5% of the nation's energy production.

Nayara argued that SAP was using the EU trade curbs to not provide services to the energy firm despite its contractual obligations in India. It also cited a notification issued by the external affairs ministry stating India has not formally recognised those sanctions.

The oil refinery argued that since the contracts were governed by Indian law and payments were made in Indian currency, the German software giant's attempt to bypass its commitments had no legal standing.

Countering this, SAP argued that EU sanctions applied to all countries, and as a Germany-headquartered multinational group, it had to comply. SAP also claimed that services would not have been suspended had the entity been entirely India-based and free of any links to Russian ownership.

Mint's queries emailed to Nayara Energy and SAP India remained unanswered.

Since the start of the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022, major IT companies have frequently suspended services to Russian entities, crippling businesses that rely on Western enterprise resource planning platforms.

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PB Health targets 500-hospital network with ₹10,000 cr outlay

Jessica Jani
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MUMBAI

PB Health, backed by PB Fintech, the parent company of online insurance marketplace Policybazaar, plans to invest about ₹10,000 crore over the next few years to build a 500-hospital network, which aims to integrate healthcare delivery with insurance.

The healthcare venture, launched in 2025, aims to shift away from the corporate hospital models that focus on services for a fee, often resulting in longer admissions, to preventive care, PB Fintech chairman and group chief executive Yashish Dahiya, said in an interview.

The venture, which has raised about ₹1,900 crore in a seed round led by General Catalyst, operates two hospitals in the National Capital Region and is planning two more by the end of this year. The long-term goal is to have about 500 hospitals across 50 cities in India, said Dahiya. With a target of ₹500-crore revenue and operational breakeven



Yashish Dahiya, chairman and group CEO, PB Fintech.

planned for the end of the fiscal year, the business will be financed with equity and around ₹4,000 crore debt.

Pointing to global examples Kaiser Permanente and UnitedHealth-Optum, Dahiya said that payor-led healthcare services can address continued issues such as higher-than-required hospital costs and stay, and address friction between insurers and healthcare providers. Success would indicate if an insurer can manage capital-heavy assets in the highly-fragmented healthcare space.

PB Health is 26% owned by PB Fintech and the rest by other investors. The company, which began operations in March 2025, aims to add two more hospitals by year end.

"The challenges were building hospital facilities, getting doctors, convincing customers that our facilities are good. I think we are finding better than expected results on all," Dahiya said.

The company's entry into healthcare comes as private hospital chains expand capacity and insurance penetration increases in India.

The current system can encourage hospitals to increase admissions, procedures and treatment costs, while PB Health would focus on reducing the need for hospitalisation. "We don't want to do a heart surgery in less money. We don't want to have lower room rents. We don't want to have lower quality of rooms. We want to have very good quality of doctors and very good quality of facilities," he said.

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Transrail sticks to 20-22% growth path

Yadukrishna C S & Nehal Chaliawala
MUMBAI

Transrail Lighting Ltd, a transmission and distribution (T&D) engineering, procurement and construction (EPC) company, expects to maintain its annual revenue growth guidance of 20-22% even after a tepid first quarter as geopolitical tensions in West Asia disrupted supply chains and put pressure on margins.

The company expects to make up for the slower start over the coming quarters, chief executive Randeep Narang said in an interview with *Mint*. "We are going to catch up on this and maintain a 20% guidance. There is an upside—we may do more, but 20-22% is what we are wanting to achieve," he said.

The confidence comes as India enters a strong power transmission investment cycle, driven by rising electricity demand, renewable energy integration and the need for new transmission infrastructure. For Transrail, which competes with larger EPC companies such as Larsen & Toubro, Kalpataru Projects International and KEC International,



Randeep Narang, chief executive, Transrail.

the expanding market provides room to grow its core T&D order book even as it plans to enter newer businesses such as data centres and battery energy storage systems.

Narang pegged the domestic transmission market opportunity at ₹9.5 trillion through 2032. After excluding segments such as original equipment manufacturers, he estimates about ₹5 trillion could be the addressable market, translating into an annual opportunity of roughly ₹1 trillion.

"Even a 5% share of that is ₹5,000 crore. Our order intake plan is ₹10,000-12,000 crore, so we are very well-placed because the growth of the industry will help us to boost our orderbook for the next five years," Narang said.

International markets provide another avenue for growth. Narang estimates the opportunity at ₹60,000-70,000 crore, allowing it to selectively pursue projects outside India.

The strong longer-term outlook comes after a difficult start

For Transrail, the expanding market provides room to grow its core T&D order book even as it plans to enter newer businesses

to fiscal year 2027 (FY27). Disruptions linked to the West Asia crisis slowed supplies to Transrail's factories and vendors during the first quarter. Changes in light diesel oil prices affected the availability of steel, aluminium and zinc used to manufacture towers and conductors as suppliers held back production in anticipation of better prices, Narang said.

The slowdown affected the entire industry, he said, pointing to subdued growth among competitors during the quarter. "All our competitors grew less than 5% in Q1. Some grew 3%, some 4%. It impacted everybody. It's not that we have done this in isolation. Our closest competitors grew less than us in Q1," he said.

The strategy for navigating both near-term uncertainty and longer-term opportunity is to avoid chasing growth at the expense of profitability. That approach is visible outside its core T&D business, where the firm plans to remain cautious in the more competitive civil and railway EPC segments.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Nothing to spin off budget brand into India unit

Bloomberg
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Swedish entrepreneur Carl Pei plans to carve out Nothing Technologies Ltd's budget smartphone and electronics unit into a majority Indian-owned company, betting that the South Asian nation is poised to become the next global consumer technology hub.

CMF will operate as a standalone firm with its own management and research teams in India. Pei, co-founder and chief executive officer (CEO) of Nothing, wrote in an article titled 'India Is Inevitable,' posted on X Monday. London-based Nothing will retain a stake in the business.

Nothing was India's fastest-growing smartphone brand in the quarter ended June, with shipments doubling from a year earlier, according to Counterpoint Research. That makes the country an important market for the company when global sales are dominated by Apple Inc., Samsung Electronics Co. and China's biggest handset makers.

India could follow Japan, South Korea and China in producing consumer-electronics companies with global reach, said Pei, who also cofounded OnePlus. The nation has already built a manufacturing base to compete globally, but still needs stronger product engineering, and research and development capabilities, he said. "What it doesn't have yet is a global consumer electronics brand of its own. That will change." In February, Nothing opened its first flagship store in Bengaluru as part of a broader expansion in the country.

'Confident Indian buyers are reshaping the domestic art market'

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NEW DELHI

India's art auction market has grown more than threefold from about ₹700 crore in 2020 to more than ₹2,400 crore in 2025 as more buyers, artists and a wider institutional ecosystem made their presence felt in a segment once dominated by a relatively small group of modern masters.

The growth was accompanied by the emergence of a broader ecosystem of galleries, museums and cultural institutions, with several private museums also coming up. Minal Vazirani, the founder of pioneering Mumbai-based auc-

tion house Saffronart, told *Mint*. The art auction market has already crossed ₹2,000 crore in sales this year, she said, citing the auction house's own industry data. Vazirani expects the art auction market will double its 2024 estimate of \$172 million by the end of 2026.

Saffronart made history this year with a Raja Ravi Varma 1890s oil-on-canvas work, *Yashoda and Krishna*, which fetched ₹167.2 crore, becoming the most expensive work of modern/historic Indian art ever sold at an auction.

The growth of India's art market, Vazirani said, has held up even after the pandemic-era surge in online buying. Its latest auction results suggest that



Minal Vazirani, the founder of pioneering Mumbai-based auction house Saffronart.

demand is not confined to the usual headline-making names. Its auction last week fetched

₹218.61 crore (\$23 million), with 88% of the artwork lots selling above their higher estimates,

she said. The sale also produced eight artist records, including F.N. Souza's *Hanuman the Monkey God*, which sold for ₹15.6 crore, and H.A. Gade's *Steps - Omkareshwar*, which fetched ₹96 lakh, eight times its higher estimate.

The numbers are part of a broader change in the market, said Vazirani, as the scale of the market has changed sharply over the past two decades.

The art auction market, which she pegged at about \$2 million in 2000, had grown to roughly \$94.5 million

by 2020, based on her ₹700 crore estimate and the average exchange rate for that year. It reached \$150 million in 2022 and \$183 million in 2023, while the first half of 2024 alone accounted for about \$90 million.

By 2025, the market had crossed ₹2,400 crore. Through this year, Saffronart and its competitors have already raked in \$200 million. This includes Saffronart's three sales

at about \$67 million and Asta-Guri's three Modern Indian art auctions that generated about

NEW PHASE

INDIA'S art auction market has grown more than ₹2,400 crore in 2020

THE growth of the art market has held up even after the pandemic-era surge in online buying



China has pledged to buy 25mt of US soya beans this year. AP

China's selective crop buying tests truce before meet

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

China is over halfway to meeting its pledge to buy 25 million tonnes (mt) of US soya beans this year, but progress on a separate commitment to spend billions of dollars more on American crops has largely stalled.

The mixed signals ahead of this week's presidential summit in Washington underscore the fragility of a trade truce both sides have worked carefully to preserve. Agriculture has proven to be an area where the US and China have found common ground, offering tangible incentives to help build a more stable relationship that's usually defined by economic and geopolitical rivalry.

Hitting the annual target for soybeans, at least, seems doable. Since presidents Donald Trump and Xi Jinping last met in May, sales of the new crop harvested in the fall have picked up dramatically. But the second pledge to buy at least another \$17 billion of US farm products at this point looks challenging, and may depend on Beijing offering relief on tariffs if it's to be met.

"My expectation is that China ultimately meets the soybean commitment, particularly because soybean imports remain critical to China's feed and vegetable oil sectors, and the volume is manageable within its overall import requirements," said Kang Wei Cheang, an agricultural broker at StoneX Group Inc. in Singapore.

The second target is "achievable if political relations remain constructive and tariff barriers continue to ease," he said.

The two nations have discussed cutting tariffs on goods including American energy and agricultural products ahead of the summit, a move that traders say could open the door to stepped up purchases from the US.

The two annual pledges run through 2028. The soybean purchases were agreed when Trump and Xi first called a truce last October. The \$17 billion commitment followed at the May meeting and is pro-rated for this year. As well as the

uneven timelines, another complication is that it isn't clear if the dollar figure could include soybeans, which have typically accounted for the lion's share of trade.

The White House didn't respond to a request for comment.

US soya beans loom so large because the country is such a major producer and "it's hard to forgo US supply entirely," said Even Pay, a director at Beijing-based advisory firm Trivium China. China picked up at least four more American soy cargoes late last week, *Bloomberg* reported on Monday.

For other oilseeds, grains and meat, China has more options. Imports of niche crops like sorghum—used in animal feed and for producing *baijiu*, a popular Chinese liquor—have held up this year. But significant purchases of other key US crops haven't materialized since the May meeting. For example, sales of corn and wheat for the 2026-27 season are zero, according to the US Department of Agriculture.

Sales of corn and wheat to China for the 2026-27 season are zero, according to the US Department of Agriculture

Total Farm Marketing analyst Naomi Blohm said China's desire for diversification means there's still hope for crops like corn, cotton, wheat and sorghum.

Reviving agri-trade between the US and China is beset by a number of problems. Terrible weather and the Russia-Ukraine war have raised crop prices globally, deterring buyers, while the Iran conflict has ratcheted up fuel and fertilizer costs for farmers.

Within China, prospects are clouded by a slowing economy and ample domestic supplies, while Beijing's tariffs on US farm goods have impeded trade even for soybeans. State-run firms have led purchases of beans, but if the economics could be improved it might entice private traders back into the market, which could help progress on both pledges.

Still, to fulfil the \$17 billion commitment, China would have to raise US purchases at the expense of its hard-won strategy of diversification, cutting supplies from countries such as Canada, Argentina, Brazil and Australia.

Xi rolls into Trump summit with China's trade engine roaring

Shift in fortunes has tempered expectations for the two leaders' summit in Washington this week

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
BEIJING/WASHINGTON

In the four months since the leaders of the two global superpowers last met, Xi Jinping has overseen a surge in China's trade with the world while Donald Trump has struggled with falling approval ratings at home.

That shift in fortunes has tempered expectations for their summit in Washington this week, analysts say, with Xi in no rush to make concessions and Trump constrained by a costly war with Iran that has hurt both his popularity and Americans' wallets.

While thorny issues like Taiwan may surface, the main focus of the 24 September meeting is whether the leaders will signal an extension to a trade truce struck last year that averted a major shock to the global economy.

"Xi is not really looking for anything tangible. He wants to extend the gentleman's agreement with Trump so that China has time to fortify itself," said Jon Czin, a foreign policy expert at the Brookings Institution who formerly served as China director at the US National Security Council.

White House officials have sought to downplay the potential for major breakthroughs. US treasury secretary Scott Bessent and Chinese vice premier He Lifeng helmed preparatory talks in New York on Sunday aimed at teasing up some potential agreements on AI guardrails and trade in non-sensitive products.

That is a far cry from Trump's vow when he returned to office in 2025 to use tariffs to address a trade imbalance with China that was "killing" the US.

But since agreeing the truce with Xi in October of that year, his attention has been divided among myriad other foreign policy battles, from the wars in Iran and Ukraine to disputes



China's president Xi Jinping (right) and US president Donald Trump in Beijing in May. The main focus of the meeting of the two leaders on 24 September is whether they will signal an extension to a trade truce struck last year. AP

with Europe over free speech.

China has faced its own challenges, such as slowing domestic demand and a protracted property crisis, but the export juggernaut that Trump sought to tame has kept roaring in what economists are increasingly referring to as China Shock 2.0.

China's global trade surplus is on pace to top \$1 trillion for a second straight year.

While US efforts to curb the cheap parcels that online retailers such as Shein and Temu rely on have worked, more than half of the roughly 6,500 product categories China sold to the US so far this year have grown compared to 2025.

A delegation of Chinese business leaders, potentially including some firms facing US regulatory scrutiny as they seek greater market access, is set to accompany Xi to Washington.

Trump described a pending \$14 billion arms package for Taiwan as a 'negotiating chip' with Beijing

"Now this is Xi Jinping's world, and we're all living in it."

If Xi is in the driver's seat as analysts suggest, that will further unnerv US allies in Asia who expect the Chinese leader to push Trump to

soften Washington's support for Taiwan, the democratically governed island claimed by Beijing.

Xi repeatedly asked him about Taiwan when they met in Beijing in May, including about arms sales and Washington's resolve to defend the island, Trump told reporters.

The US president described a pending \$14 billion arms package for Taiwan as a "negotiating chip" with Beijing.

Some officials in Taipei and Tokyo worry he may be tempted to cash in that chip for political wins ahead of November's midterm elections, which could prove challenging for his Republican Party.

That could include Chinese purchases of Boeing jets or farm goods, or commitments to curb the flow of off-tentative precursor chemicals that have

fueled the US opioid crisis.

"China-US ties have become more transactional," said Wu Xinbo, a professor at Shanghai's Fudan University who advises China's foreign ministry.

While Washington may want to prioritise trade talks, for Beijing, the US approach to Taiwan could be key, he said.

"If you accommodate our concern on the Taiwan issue, then we would be willing to accommodate your concerns on other issues, be it law enforcement or on purchases of US agricultural products," Wu said.

Washington also sees Xi as uniquely able to exert pressure on Iran to bring an end to the war that has dragged Trump's approval rating to the lowest of his political career.

However, Xi has shown little inclination to do so. Reuters earlier this month reported that Beijing is selling billions of dollars' worth of goods to Iran through a sanctions-evasion scheme. China's foreign ministry says it is not aware of such a scheme.

US threats last month of secondary sanctions on countries doing business with Iran—which Bessent called an "Economic D-Day"—appear not to have yet been wielded against Tehran's largest trading partner.

That is more evidence, analysts say, that Trump is eager to keep relations with Xi steady as he focuses his energies elsewhere—an arrangement that also suits the Chinese leader.

"Both Xi and Trump feel it's quite helpful to have stability in the relationship so that they can focus on more pressing things," said Ruby Osman, senior geopolitical researcher at the Tony Blair Institute for Global Change.

"For Trump, that is Iran. For Xi, that is building out China's domestic resilience for whatever comes after Trump."

China slows humanoid robot IPO rush as hype outruns reality

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

Chinese regulators are putting the brakes on a rush of humanoid-robot companies seeking listings, people familiar with the matter said, as they scrutinize whether soaring valuations and revenue tied to state-backed projects reflect commercial demand.

The slowdown was mainly triggered by a volatile start for shares in Unitree Robotics, a maker of humanoid and quadruped robots, they said. The stock soared more than fivefold in its Shanghai debut a month ago and has slumped 55% from its peak.

Regulators have used informal "window guidance" to hold back some humanoid-robot listings, said the people, who requested anonymity while discussing the matter due to the sensitivity of the topic.

One of them said humanoid IPOs (initial public offerings)

had effectively been frozen for now, while another said there was no formal ban, describing the move as a sector-specific slowdown.

The regulatory move highlights Beijing's effort to cool investor euphoria over one of China's hottest investment themes without undermining a technology the government has made a national priority.

The China Securities Regulatory Commission (CSRC) did not respond to a request for comment.

The *Information* first reported, citing people with knowledge of the matter, that the CSRC recently gave informal guidance to some investment banks and investment firms that it was raising the bar for granting approval of humanoid IPOs.

Leo Wang, a venture capitalist at Qianchuang Capital, described the investment wave in the robotics sector as "campaign-style innovation," using a Chinese phrase for booms in which companies and capital rush into a policy-favoured sector.



Beijing is trying to cool investor euphoria over a hot investment theme. REUTERS

paid-style innovation," using a Chinese phrase for booms in which companies and capital rush into a policy-favoured sector.

Beijing has promoted "embodied intelligence"—artificial intelligence (AI) systems capable of perceiving and acting in the physical world—as a strategic emerging industry, helping fuel investment from private

capital and local governments.

Wang said hype around embodied AI had exceeded that seen during China's internet and new-energy investment waves, with industrial-robot makers pivoting towards humanoids and startups commanding rapidly rising valuations.

Some founders were attracting dozens of prospective investors within weeks and refusing conventional due diligence, he said. Some private-market projects had already suffered valuation cuts of 30% to 50%.

Unitree did not respond to a request for comment.

At least half a dozen Chinese humanoid robotics firms are preparing to go public, including Deep Robotics, X Square Robot and AGIBOT.

At least half a dozen Chinese humanoid robotics companies are preparing to go public

Regulators are particularly focusing on whether revenue generated by the robotics companies through local government-backed projects can be sustained, according to one person close to humanoid-robot investors.

The person said robot data-collection centres, where robots are trained, and joint ventures, in which local governments could provide 80% to 90% of initial investment, had generated significant revenue for some companies.

Such projects can provide orders that support private-market valuations and help companies meet listing thresholds, but regulators are questioning whether they represent demand from independent customers.

The person estimated that valuations at some robot companies could fall 60-70% if revenue associated with data-collection centres were stripped away.

Questions over revenue quality are accompanied by uncertainty about what customers are actually buying.

Mech-Mind Robotics chief executive Shao Tianan alleged in a WeChat post this month some highly valued embodied-AI firms were generating revenue through data collection centres, related-party deals and other unsustainable arrangements as they raced towards IPOs.

The tighter regulatory stance does not signal Beijing's retreat from humanoid robotics, executives and investors said. It reflects a growing emphasis on deployment, order volumes, and evidence that companies can turn technical demonstrations into commercially viable products, they said.

The other Hormuz: Black Sea blockade threatens a food supply shock

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Tue Vuong had secured four cargoes of wheat harvested from fertile lands around the Black Sea, roughly a fifth of what his milling company 5,000 miles away in Vietnam uses annually. Then he was told it wouldn't get shipped following a summer escalation in Russia's war with Ukraine.

"I was very panicked," said Vuong, chief executive officer of Golden Wheat in Ho Chi Minh City. He was offered replacements for two of his cargoes with wheat from Bulgaria, but with a gap in his supplies, he spent weeks frantically searching for more. "We were too exposed to a crisis in the Black Sea."

The world's attention has been on the Strait of Hormuz and spiking oil prices because of the conflict in West Asia. But

the impasse in the Black Sea is compounding the economic damage by threatening to drive inflation even higher while undermining food security in vulnerable countries. Bond investors say food supply risks aren't yet fully priced into a market more focused on the cost of things such as energy.

Connecting Europe and Asia, the Black Sea is a critical conduit for global crop shipments to some of the world's most populous nations. Russia and Ukraine make up more than a quarter of the global wheat trade, a share similar to the seaborne oil trade passing through Hormuz in the Gulf.

Supplies have been choked off since July when the countries stepped up attacks on each other's ports, pummeling grain terminals, silos and vessels. The escalation also hit Russia's energy infrastructure, sending diesel prices to records. A key input into farm-

ing, the cost of the fuel is another inflationary risk for food.

Egypt, the world's biggest wheat buyer, hasn't received any Black Sea grain in about a month. Russia's exports are throttled by Ukrainian drones, while Ukraine, with its ports blocked, is struggling to get its grain out by land or river. As harvests pile up, the country is also struggling to find enough storage.

Wheat prices have jumped to three-year highs, with few signs of a repeat of the deal Turkey brokered in 2022 to create a shipping corridor for blocked Ukrainian grains. Ukraine's western neighbours now have import bans on its grain after a local political backlash against support for the war-ravaged country.

"We can think of the Black Sea as important for global wheat trade as the Strait of Hormuz is for global oil trade," said



Russia's exports are throttled by Ukrainian drones, while Ukraine, with its ports blocked, is struggling to get its grain out. AP

Caitlin Welsh, a food security expert at the Center for Strategic and International Studies, a Washington-based think tank. "The world is underestimating the impact of these attacks."

Combined Russian and Ukrainian wheat exports are estimated to end up at roughly half what they were last year for

the July to September harvesting period, based on figures from researcher SovEcon.

Russia and Ukraine also make up two-thirds of the global sunflower oil trade and a tenth of corn shipping. Their crops eventually filter through to anywhere from Egypt's bakeries and India's market stalls to

Turkish flour mills and Vietnam's livestock and aquaculture industries.

Located just outside Ho Chi Minh City, Golden Wheat mills grain for flour and imports feed for animals, part of a growing sector working to meet Southeast Asia's burgeoning food demand.

The company was able to switch two boats to load Bulgarian wheat from Burgas, 500 km (310 miles) down the coast from the Ukrainian port of Odesa. Vuong stayed in constant touch with the sellers to ensure it was on its way.

He also scoured the legal terms of his supply contracts and insurance premiums. He monitored news and the movement of vessels, anxious not just about their exit from the

Black Sea but their transit through the Red Sea, which is under threat from Iran-backed Houthi rebels.

"Although the vessels were insured, if they had been attacked, we would have faced shortages," he said. To replace his two missing or stalled cargoes, he turned to the US, though it came at a much higher price tag. Since then, the prices have only gone higher.

Other nations are trying to source grains from France, which loaded a first wheat shipment bound for Sudan in 18 years. Libya tapped the port of Rouen for the first time in more than a decade, according to data from local shipping agents.

Turkey, the United Arab Emirates and others have

turned to the Baltic states of Lithuania, Latvia and Estonia. Bangladesh is looking to growers like Romania and Argentina, while securing small quantities of wheat from India, which recently scrapped a years-long ban on exports. Buyers are also approaching less obvious places for this time of the year, such as Australia that's yet to collect this year's harvest.

"Every day we're fielding inquiries from all over the world," said William Reid, wheat trading manager at CBH Group, one of Australia's top grain merchants. "It's been extraordinarily busy. We have to ration some demand because we can't literally continue to lose that volume of wheat."

Supplies from other key breadbaskets are limited too. Droughts have curbed wheat and corn yields in the US and Europe's crop got hurt by this year's heat waves.



A shortage of oil tankers is threatening to keep gas prices high amid Iran war

Rebecca Feng,
Georgi Kantchev &
Summer Said

The Iran war has created a new shortage on the oil market. This time the scarce commodity isn't just crude—it is the ships that carry it.

Drone attacks that shut Saudi Arabia's bypass pipeline earlier this month have forced more crude back through the Strait of Hormuz and onto a tanker fleet already stretched thin. The impact has spread worldwide, as longer voyages and shuttle runs around Hormuz tie up ships and push the daily rate of hiring oil tankers to records.

The squeeze adds another cost to a war that has been disrupting energy supplies across the globe. Fewer available tankers are slowing oil deliveries just as record shipping costs squeeze **THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.** Saudi Aramco, the kingdom's state oil company, say it is possible the pipeline could be partially restarted within days, though hurdles remain over some technical issues. Meanwhile, Yanbu hasn't loaded any crude tankers since the attacks, according to ship trackers.

Aramco has warned some European and Asian customers to expect delays or cancellations for September and October, the people said. If partial pipeline flows aren't restored in the coming days, more crude shipments could be scrapped, they said.

Saudi-flagged vessels have stopped transiting Bab al-Mandeb Strait, a maritime chokepoint connecting the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden now controlled by the Houthis, amid the pipeline outage and attacks on Saudi vessels by the Iran-aligned Houthi militants, according to ship trackers. More than a dozen Saudi-flagged vessels have rerouted via the Cape of Good Hope in South Africa, at an extra cost of \$1 million a trip per ship, according to Windward. As a result, Aramco is pushing more crude through Hormuz, leaning on a workaround used more often by its neighbors: ship-to-ship transfers. The maneuver involves short trips moving oil from Gulf terminals to ports just outside



Supply shortage among oil supertankers has boosted the cost of hauling oil through the strait to the highest on record. REUTERS

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Aramco is talking with some Asian customers about taking crude from tankers off Oman via ship-to-ship transfers

Kpler's lead freight analyst. "There are indications there is limited additional ship-to-ship transfer support capacity for more shuttle flows," he said. The workaround appears to be working so long as Iran allows, said Natasha Kaneva, head of global commodities strategy at JPMorgan.

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UN convenes amid wars, rogue AI, climate shocks

UNGA will deliberate on the ongoing wars and whether the leaders can do anything about it

AP
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UNITED NATIONS

Under a global cloud of wars and bitter divisions, world leaders meet at the United Nations this week facing new fears that runaway artificial intelligence could threaten humanity even as climate shocks and escalating prices are already making life much tougher for hundreds of millions of people. The annual high-level gathering at the UN General Assembly will also be consumed with major wars in Iran, Gaza, Ukraine, Sudan, Congo and Myanmar and a persisting question: Can the leaders do anything to end them?

And what can they do about the relentless rise of global warming threatening the future of the planet, the growing inequalities within and among nations, and shocks to the global economy as blocked shipping routes and supply chains increase the cost of living and slow growth?

The future of the United Nations will also definitely be on the agenda. At 81, its powers are still the victorious nations from World War II, not the 21st century's major global players. The UN's 193 member nations have agreed to a wide-ranging reform package that includes updating key institutions such as the powerful UN Security Council, where the US, Russia, China, Britain and France hold inordinate sway because of their veto power. Reform, however, is easier said than implemented.

Behind the scenes, there will be speculation about who will lead the United Nations next. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres' second five-year term ends 31 December and no clear successor has emerged.

There is still no question that the UN remains THE gathering place for its 193 member nations and their leaders. Some



The UN's 193 member nations have agreed to a wide-ranging reform package, including updating key institutions. REUTERS

130 heads of state and government are expected to speak at the General Assembly starting Tuesday along with dozens of ministers.

Among the headlines will be US president Donald Trump and French president Emmanuel Macron. Both will speak Tuesday after Guterres' opening "state of the world" address. Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian speak Wednesday. Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu—whom New York Mayor Zoran Mamdani wanted arrested for his treatment of Palestinians in Gaza until he learned he has no such author-

ity—will address the assembly on Thursday. For a second year, Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas won't be coming to the UN because the US has refused to

give him a visa. He will nonetheless address the assembly by video the same day.

The US, under its agreement with the UN to host the organization, is required to allow diplomats from all member nations to attend meetings.

Equally telling is who else isn't coming. China's president Xi Jinping is meeting Trump in Washington on Wednesday, yet he is skipping—some diplomats say snubbing—the UN gathering and sending a vice president

instead. Russian President Vladimir Putin isn't coming either, and Indian President Narendra Modi has backed out. France's UN ambassador, Jerome Bonnafont, said it is "extremely critical" for world leaders this week to support the UN as the place where the world's nations meet—especially at a time of such polarization.

"We believe in multilateralism," he said, "and we believe that the high-level week is the occasion for countries in the world to reaffirm that they prefer cooperation and dialogue to confrontation."

There is no doubt it's been a tough year for UN. It has been pushed to the sidelines on its key responsibility of ensuring international peace and security and trying to end major conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine.

Some 130 heads of state and government are expected to speak at the General Assembly starting Tuesday

Pak airstrikes target militant hideouts in Afghanistan

AP
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ISLAMABAD

Pakistani jet fighters carried out airstrikes Monday on what security officials described as suspected militant hideouts in eastern Afghanistan and claimed 28 of them were killed.

Authorities in Kabul said at least three people were killed. The strikes near the frontier between the two countries marked a renewed escalation

between Pakistan and Afghanistan, raising the prospect of further cross-border hostilities and threatening to complicate efforts by regional countries including China to mediate between Islamabad and Kabul. They came after Pakistan warned it could target militants inside Afghanistan following two deadly attacks in recent days on its security forces near the border.

Militant attacks targeting Pakistan's police and security forces have surged in recent years. The escalation follows

months of military action. Hundreds of people have been killed in cross-border fighting since February,

when Afghanistan launched retaliatory strikes after Pakistan carried out airstrikes inside Afghan territory. Authorities in Islamabad have blamed the Pakistani Taliban and allied militant groups for most of the violence. The Pakistani Taliban

are separate from but allied with the Afghan Taliban that returned to power in 2021.

Pakistan had warned it could target militants in Afghanistan after two attacks on its security forces in recent days

Two Pakistani security officials said 28 suspected militants were killed in Monday's airstrikes. Afghanistan's government, however, said the strikes killed three civilians

and wounded four others. The claims from either side could not immediately be independently verified. The Pakistani officials spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly. Pakistan's military did not immediately issue a statement on the strikes.

In a post on X, Afghan Taliban government spokesman Zabihullah Mujahid condemned the airstrikes and said there would be a response.

"Pakistani military circles have once again committed such a crime to divert attention from their country's security failures," he wrote.

Houthis push for control of Yemen highlands

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
DUBAI

Houthi fighters were pushing to seize strategic heights in Yemen on Monday to cut off the Red Sea coast from remaining areas held by Saudi-backed forces, after a report that President Donald Trump had called off US strikes on the group at the last minute.

A lightning advance by the Iran-backed group this month has extended the wider Middle East conflict to a new theatre and further threatened global energy supplies.

Washington has so far rebuffed repeated pleas from Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman to join the fight in Yemen. The Houthis said on Saturday they had fired on Riyadh, where loud booms were followed by columns of smoke visible near the airport.

Saudi Arabia has not commented on the first apparent strikes on the capital since the escalation began.

The New York Times reported that the Trump administration had prepared on Sunday to launch airstrikes against the Houthis after fresh pleas from the Saudi crown prince. But the newspaper said Trump called off the airstrikes

at the last minute, even as troops were loading bombs onto aircraft.

Reuters could not immediately verify the report and the US military's Central Command did not respond to an email seeking comment.

The Houthis, who have controlled Yemen's capital since 2014, seized the country's Red Sea coast this month in a lightning advance that routed forces of an internationally recognised Yemeni government, which is backed by Saudi Arabia and based in the south.

Saudi Arabia has launched hundreds of strikes in recent days on the fighters' positions in the highlands, according to the Houthis. But the air power advantage has so far done little to slow the advance of the fighters as Saudi-backed government forces have melted away.

According to the United Nations, nearly 700 people have been killed and thousands injured in the flare-up in fighting. More than 120,000 Yemenis have fled homes within Yemen, and thousands more have fled by boat across the Red Sea to Africa.

Five Yemeni military sources told Reuters the Houthis were now seeking to seize strategic heights, known as the Kahboub Mountains, in two provinces, Taiz and Lahij,



The Houthis were now seeking to seize strategic heights, known as the Kahboub Mountains, in two provinces, Taiz and Lahij. AP

which separate the Red Sea coast from the government-held south.

Fighting has centred on the outskirts of the remote mountain Al-Wazi'iyah district in Taiz province, and Ras al-Ara along the Indian Ocean coast between the mouth of the Red Sea that the fighters captured last week and the government's base in Aden.

The Houthi aim to secure the rear of their forces around the Bab al-Mandab Strait leading into the Red Sea by taking control of the heights, which would allow them to open new

fronts, according to the sources. That would help protect exposed positions the Houthis captured during their advance around Dhubbab on the Red Sea and on Perim Island in the strait.

The surge in fighting between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis creates a new dilemma for Trump, under pressure to help defend Washington's close Saudi allies but anxious not to further expand the deeply unpopular war he launched in February against Iran.

The US bombed the Houthis for two months in

More than 120,000 Yemenis have fled homes within Yemen and thousands have fled across the Red Sea to Africa

Markets can handle a hawkish Fed, not uncertainty

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Better clarity about the Federal Reserve's resolve to fight inflation is giving investors reason to be bullish, and yet risks associated with oil prices and artificial intelligence keep them from fully committing.

The Fed last week succeeded in restoring its credibility, showing that it's not falling behind the curve with a hawkish message that still stopped short of signaling an aggressive hiking cycle. While that was at first enough to soothe markets, nerves remained evident Friday as the 10-year Treasury yield again tested 5% and the S&P 500 fluctuated between gains and losses. While oil prices have pulled back, Brent crude is still trading above \$100 a barrel.

"It is difficult to see rates and equities fully stabilizing until energy-related inflation pressures ease," said Barclays Plc strategists led by Emmanuel Cau. "Nevertheless, the positive development is that Fed independence and credibility have been reaffirmed, providing clarity on its reaction function." The Fed decision can be seen as a clearing event. Investors'



The Fed last week succeeded in restoring its credibility. REUTERS

cautious turn heading into the policy meeting showed they were far from complacent, with clear signs they had reduced exposure while adding hedges. Friday's massive quarterly expiry also went a long way toward resetting options positioning.

"With earnings growth robust, credit spreads contained and the VIX subdued, US equity fundamentals remain supportive, leaving us constructive on the S&P 500 beyond near-term volatility," said Societe Generale SA strategist Manish Kabra. The yield curve remains a key signal and as long as inversion is avoided, Kabra expects the benchmark

to hit 8,000 by year-end, despite some volatility.

While the prospect of a year-end rally is well alive, getting there may not be easy. Diesel prices are pointing to higher inflation ahead, and unless the war in Iran is resolved swiftly enough to bring oil prices down significantly, the central bank may have little choice but to turn even more hawkish. Another three rate hikes are priced in by the end of July, according to the swap market. All eyes will be on a potential bond shock, with 10-year yields above 5% making Treasuries increasingly attractive. Yet as long as economic and earnings growth remain resilient, investors may be reluctant to shift from equities and rather continue broadening their exposure. Bank of America Corp. strategists led by Jared Woodward have become more cautious, saying positioning is still too bullish given next year's expected moderation in earnings. They said the 10%-15% growth seen for 2027 implies an ISM manufacturing reading above 53 for a sustained period of time. It's "not yet time for defensives, but quality, value, and yield look prudent," they said.

NEWS
NUMBERS

34%

THE YEAR-ON-YEAR increase in India's export volume to its Brics partners this fiscal year through August, driven largely by a 39% jump in exports to China.

-3.09%

THE AVERAGE return of active large-cap mutual funds over the past year, with only four of 33 funds delivering positive returns.

₹4k cr

THE REPORTED budget for Nitesh Tiwari's two-part mythological epic *Ramayana*, making it one of the country's biggest-budget film productions.

450

THE ESTIMATED number of vendors Tata Electronics expects to support its semiconductor fabrication plant in Dholera, Gujarat, that's scheduled to open in 2028.

\$30 bn

THE VALUE of products from each side covered under a reciprocal tariff-reduction framework being negotiated ahead of Chinese President Xi Jinping's US visit.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Asiana Fund, JC Cap float ₹1,000 cr fund

Asiana Fund, the investment platform of the Dani Family Office, and Taiwan-based venture capital firm JC Capital on Monday announced the launch of a ₹1,000 crore fund to back growth-stage Indian companies in advanced manufacturing, semiconductors, materials and defence.

The Asiana-JCC Advanced Manufacturing & Innovation Fund comprises a corpus of ₹600 crore with a greenshoe option of ₹400 crore, the two firms said in a joint statement.

The fund will invest in intellectual property-led companies across advanced manufacturing and robotics, semiconductors and computing, materials and sustainability, and aerospace and defence. It will target I2 to I5 growth-stage firms, primarily at the Series A and B stages, with capital set aside for follow-on investments.

Asiana Fund is an India-focused investment platform backed by the Dani family, co-promoters of Asian Paints.

PTI



JSW Energy plans to raise around ₹1,500 crore through up to five-year bonds.

REUTERS

JSW firms plan debt sales of \$300 mn

Two JSW Group firms will raise a total of around ₹2,850 crore (\$298 million) through shorter-tenor bonds in the October-December quarter, a couple of bankers said on Monday.

JSW Energy plans to raise around ₹1,500 crore through up to five-year bonds, while JSW Steel could raise around ₹1,350 crore via three-year or four-year debt, the bankers said, requesting anonymity. The companies could tap the market in October if rates are favourable, according to the bankers.

The firms did not respond to emails seeking comment.

Bonds of JSW Energy are rated "AA" by India Ratings. The firm has around 25 billion rupees of outstanding bonds.

The company, which has thermal, hydro and renewable power operations, had raised ₹800 crore through three-year and five-year bonds at 8.75% and 8.80% in March 2025.

The firm had last tapped the bond market over two years ago, when it raised ₹2,250 crore through five-year and seven-year papers at 8.35% and 8.43%, respectively.

REUTERS

Rupee rises 18 paise against US dollar

The rupee appreciated 18 paise to close at 95.78 against the US dollar on Monday as crude oil prices retreated from their elevated levels on improved global risk sentiment amid expectations of diplomatic talks between the US and Iran.

Forex traders said the Indian rupee firmed on weak crude oil prices amid hopes of diplomatic talks between the US and Iran. Moreover, positive domestic markets and softening of US Treasury yields also supported the local unit.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.86 against the US dollar, but the Indian currency later recovered ground to touch 95.72 in intraday trade.

On Friday, the rupee closed lower by 7 paise at 95.96 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 100.32, higher by 0.10 per cent.

PTI

Govt urges bank staff to call off 28-30 September strike

Finance ministry flags five-day disruption, half-yearly closing of banks on 30 Sep

Harsh Kumar
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NEW DELHI

The finance ministry on Monday urged employees of public sector banks (PSBs) and regional rural banks (RRBs) to refrain from a three-day strike scheduled for 28-30 September, warning that the action could cause considerable inconvenience to customers, businesses and government transactions.

The ministry said the proposed strike, which follows a one-day nationwide strike on 11 September, would coincide with the half-yearly closing of banks on 30 September. Along with the preceding weekend, this could disrupt banking services for five consecutive days, it said. "The proposed 3-day strike period, from 28th to 30th Sept 2026, also coincides with the half-yearly closing of banks on 30th September," the ministry said in a statement on Monday.

The half-yearly closing is significant for reconciliation, provisioning, and treasury and market operations, the ministry said, adding that disruption during the period could affect customers, businesses, government transactions and international banking operations.

The ministry said the United Forum of Bank Unions and certain other unions and associations in PSBs and RRBs had called the strikes over two principal demands: implementation of a five-day banking week and withdrawal of the



MINT

performance-linked incentive (PLI) scheme.

The government said it had already decided to keep the PLI scheme in abeyance after detailed discussions, describing the move as fulfilment of one of the two principal demands.

"Following this, the government held several rounds of conciliation to address the outstanding issues through dialogue, in keeping with the established practice of resolving differences bilaterally," the ministry said.

Despite the government's decision on PLI and continued discussions, a one-day strike was held on 11 September, while a three-day strike has now been scheduled from 28-30 September. An indefinite strike has also been proposed from 26 October, with the five-day workweek now the unions' sole outstanding demand, the ministry said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Maharashtra FDA suspends licences of 10 establishments

The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) on Monday said it has suspended licences of 10 establishments for food safety violations. In a statement, the FDA said it has issued orders for the immediate suspension of the food licence of Swinsta ENT Pvt. Ltd (Swiggy Instamart dark store) located at Ballard Estate in south Mumbai.

Inspecting officials directly sighted a live rat in the store's handling area and several 10kg rice bags gnawed open by rodents, spilling and scattering grain across contaminated flooring, it said. Rodent droppings were also recorded in key storage zones, while a large-scale cockroach infestation was found directly on food articles, the FDA added.

The FDA said it had also suspended licences of M/s. Sadguru Sweets and Farsan Mart in Malad, M/s Acculogix Supply Chain Solutions Pvt. Ltd. (warehouse operating for Amazon), M/s Suleman Usman Mithaiwala in Mohammed Ali Road, Jain Sweet & Bhepuri House LLP and M/s Nice Enterprises in Chembur for food safety violations.

PTI

Government dissolves Digital Communications Commission

The government has notified the dissolution of the Digital Communications Commission, an apex interdepartmental decision-making body at the department of telecommunications formed around 37 years ago to decide on policy matters and subjects with significant financial implications.

Formed in 1989 as the Telecom Commission, it was renamed the Digital Communications Commission in 2018. The apex decision-making body comprising senior officials from Niti Aayog, the finance ministry, the department of industrial policy and promotion and other departments helped resolve contentious issues. The commission formed up decisions on a majority of telecom matters before they were sent to the cabinet for final approval.

The commission held its last meeting on 3 September, where it firmed up the decision on spectrum allocation for satellite communication.

PTI

Paramount-Warner deal gets closer



The settlement paves the way for one of the largest mergers in Hollywood history.

REUTERS

the weekend after four states that had opposed terms of a deal outlined with California conceded, said the person, who asked not to be named discussing confidential negotiations. The settlement paves the way for one of the largest mergers in Hollywood history.

Lawyers for the states worked all night on the agreement, the person said. Four states—Massachusetts, New York, Connecticut and Minnesota—had been holdouts on a possible settlement, but ultimately concluded the expense of the legal battle was not justifiable without California at the helm, the person said.

The states that held out longer did succeed over the past week in securing independent editorial boards for CBS and CNN as part of the deal, the person said.

The terms are said to include a financial penalty if the company fails to make good on a promise to distribute 30 films per year in theatres.

BLOOMBERG



The OMO sale comes amid a large liquidity surplus in the banking system.

MINT

RBI sells ₹25,000 cr in govt securities

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Monday accepted bids worth ₹25,000 crore in the second tranche of its open market operation (OMO) sale of government securities, as it stepped up efforts to absorb surplus liquidity from the banking system.

The RBI accepted ₹11,512 crore of the 6.10% GS 2031, ₹8,758 crore of the 7.95% GS 2032, ₹2,300 crore of the 6.75% GS 2029, ₹2,250 crore of the 7.17% GS 2030, and ₹180 crore of the 7.17% GS 2028, according to the release. However, the central bank did not accept any bids for the 8.28% GS 2027, the release said.

The OMO sale comes amid a large liquidity surplus in the banking system. Liquidity surplus was estimated around ₹6.05 trillion as of 20 September, according to RBI data.

Under an OMO sale, banks and other investors pay the RBI for the government securities, thereby draining rupee liquidity from the banking system. The central bank had announced OMO sales totalling ₹1 trillion in three tranches to manage the prevailing liquidity conditions.

The remaining last tranche of ₹25,000 crore is scheduled for 28 September.

PTI

Google hit with \$463 mn fine for EU location data rule breach

Google has been fined €403 million (\$463 million) for breaching the European Union's (EU) strict privacy rules because it mishandled users' location data, the bloc's data privacy watchdog said Monday.

Ireland's Data Protection Commission said its investigation found Google did not lawfully or fairly process location data in users' Web & App Activity, a Google setting that tracks browsing and search history, and in their Location History, a service that maps places they've been with their mobile phones.

Regulators also found the company failed to be lawful, fair and transparent when it processed personal data in its Location Accuracy feature in the Android mobile operating system.

Ireland is the lead regulator for Google in the 27-nation EU because the US tech giant's European headquarters is based in Dublin.

The investigation, which opened six years ago, examined how Google applied the EU privacy rule book, known as the General Data Protection Regulation, from the time it took effect in 2018 until February 2020.

AP



Regulators found Google failed to be lawful, fair and transparent.

AFP

Carlyle prepares for India auto unit IPO

Carlyle Group Inc. has kicked off preparations for a potential initial public offering (IPO) of its India-based auto-parts platform, Highway Roop Precision Technologies, according to people familiar with the matter.

The private equity firm is working with Kotak Mahindra Capital Co. Ltd, JM Financial Ltd, Goldman Sachs Group Inc. and Nomura Holdings Inc. on the share sale, which could raise as much as \$400 million, the people said, asking not to be identified because the deliberations are private. The IPO is planned for the first half of next year and will comprise both primary and secondary shares, they said.

Carlyle created Highway Roop Precision Technologies early last year by acquiring controlling stakes in two established auto component manufacturers, Highway Industries Ltd. and Roop Automotives Ltd.

BLOOMBERG



Starbucks operates roughly 500 cafes in India through its JV with Tata Consumer Products.

REUTERS

Starbucks to set up GCC in Chennai

US coffee chain Starbucks has signed a pact to set up a global capability centre (GCC) in Chennai and hire roughly 800 technology professionals, the Tamil Nadu government said on Monday.

Starbucks operates roughly 500 cafes in India through its joint venture (JV) with Tata Consumer Products.

The move comes days after US pharmacy chain Walgreens signed a pact with Tamil Nadu to establish a GCC in the state's capital, already home to tech centres of global business groups including Citi, Barclays and American Express. Chennai accounts for roughly a tenth of the GCC base in India, per the state government.

India has emerged as the world's largest GCC hub, with more than 2,100 centres employing about 2.36 million people and generating nearly \$100 billion in revenue, according to a 2026 report by Nasscom-Zinnov.

REUTERS

Moneyview cuts IPO size, valuation

Accel-backed Indian fintech platform Moneyview is seeking a valuation of up to ₹5,985 crore in a trimmed initial public offering (IPO) that is set to open for public subscriptions on 24 September.

The IPO comprises a fresh issue of shares worth ₹750 crore and an offer for sale (OFS) of up to 100.49 million shares from existing investors. The firm had earlier planned a fresh issue of ₹1,500 crore and an OFS of 136.1 million shares, as per the draft red herring prospectus. It did not immediately specify the reason for the reduction in offer size.

The fintech platform plans to use IPO proceeds to drive growth in loan disbursements, invest in a subsidiary, and for general corporate purposes. Promoters Puneet Agarwal and Sanjay Aggarwal to sell up to 13.55 million shares each, while Accel, Tiger Global and Ribbit Capital are also selling stakes.

REUTERS

Ampin gets \$100 mn Norfund investment

Ampin Energy Transition on Monday said it secured an equity investment of up to \$100 million from Norway's Norfund, giving the Indian renewable energy company fresh backing to expand operations.

The investment will support commercial and industrial projects, utility-scale renewable projects and other energy transition businesses, Ampin said. The company said it has now raised nearly \$1 billion in overall equity to support more than \$4 billion of capital deployment.

Norfund, the Norwegian government's investment fund for developing countries, made the investment through the Norwegian Climate Investment Fund, marking a deeper push into India's clean energy market.

Norfund has previously invested in India's renewable energy sector through firms such as ReNew Power and Enel Green Power.

Ampin said part of the funding would help expand its manufacturing business, alongside renewable power generation.

REUTERS

ASSAM'S FLOOD RESILIENCE MEETS A CHANGING LANDSCAPE

Livelihoods and generations of flood wisdom are tested as development reshapes Assam's risks

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NEPALI KHUTI/BONQUAL BALICHAPORI

By 12pm, the water was already at their necks. Krishna Prasad Sharma's wife and two sons had been calling for help while he delivered milk in nearby Sivasagar. None of them could swim, and the current tearing through Nepali Khuti, a dairy farming village in Assam, was strong enough by then to take whatever stood in its way. It was neighbours, a mother and her son, who came without hesitating, breaking through the ventilator of the trapped family's house with a bamboo pole and hauling all four onto the tin roof. There they sat out the rest of 19 July, watching the village disappear beneath them.

Below their rooftop perch, in a cowshed slowly filling with water, 24 Jersey cows stayed tethered exactly where they had been left that morning. There had been no time to free them. Whether they lived came down to luck, and luck did not come. Tied at the neck, the cows could not keep their heads above the rising water; their ropes pulled taut and became nooses. By the next morning, all but one were dead.

"When we came down to clean the cowshed the next day, only one cow had survived. The rest of them died of strangulation. Imagine tying a noose to the neck of a human," Sharma said.

Of the family's 80 chickens, 10 remained. Of eight goats, four. Their mid-size SUV, bought the year before with seven installments still left to pay, lay upturned on a wooden beam. But it was the cows the family grieved—not the car, not the silt piled through their rooms.

"We didn't have much time to think, and saving our lives was the priority. We had just 15 minutes," Sharma said. "But our grief has been for our cows. We can afford to buy cars and things we lost. But with the cows gone, we don't know how to run our lives." He estimates it will take four or five years to rebuild his dairy business.

That business was the mainstay of income for Sharma's family of four. His 24 cows produced roughly 150 litres of milk a day, sold in the markets of Sivasagar and Nazira for ₹50-70 a litre, culminating into a monthly income of about ₹2.25 lakh. Roughly half went back into the herd, on feed, medicine and shed upkeep; the rest covered the household, medical bills and school fees. The goats were insurance, sold only in emergencies for ₹10,000-18,000 each. The chickens were a smaller side business, fetching ₹330 a kilo. In one flood, nearly all of it was gone.

As most of India experienced a delayed start to this year's monsoon due to the El Niño effect, Assam saw intense rainfall that triggered flash floods along the Brahmaputra and Dihow rivers. According to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA), 106 people died in this year's floods, which hit 563 villages across 14 districts and affected more than 1 million livestock.

Nearly 40% of Assam—about 31,500 sq. km—is classified as flood-prone, according to the state's 2025-26 Economic Survey, which cites the Rashtriya Barh Ayog, India's flood control commission. That is nearly four times the national average, and close to a tenth of all flood-prone land in the country. Only about 16,500 sq. km have any flood protection.

Villages 133km from Nepali Khuti flood two or three times a year, fed by the Brahmaputra and two of its tributaries, the Dhansiri and the Gelabil. Some have learned to deal with the annual floods with knowledge passed down over generations, but even their resilience is being tested as rapid development exacerbates the impact.

LIVING WITH FLOODS

Before 19 July, Nepali Khuti looked like the kind of village postcards are made of: a settlement built on the milk trade, strung along the Dihow river—a tributary of the Brahmaputra—with the blue line of the Naga Hills rising behind it. Now it lies under a crust of silt and debris dragged down from those same hills.

The rain had been falling hard since morning. The Dihow was rising, carrying down splintered tree stumps torn loose somewhere upstream, but no one was alarmed. This looked like the regular flood they knew, the kind that creeps onto the road, maybe into a garden, and stops. By 11 am, it hadn't stopped. The river broke its banks and kept climbing until the water was at people's necks across the village.

For a village that has kept Jersey cows



(Clockwise from above) 'Chang ghor' and livestock kept at higher ground in Bonqual Balichapori village; children relocate sheep to a safer place by a boat after floodwaters submerged low-lying areas, in Morigaon district, Assam, on 17 July; the lone Jersey cow, out of two dozen at Krishna Prasad Sharma's cowshed, that survived the flood that tore through Assam's Nepali Khuti village in July; and Hopun Dao shows the foodgrain she has preserved inside a traditional drum called 'dhuli' used by the Mising community.

for generations, the flood imposed an impossible order of priorities: save yourself, then try to save the cows. People lashed banana trunks into makeshift rafts. Others climbed onto the roofs of parked Tata Magics—the shared vans that connect the village to towns and cities—or crowded into the handful of homes and temples built on slightly raised footings.

Some 133km away, in Bonqual Balichapori, a village in Golaghat district that's home mostly to the indigenous Mising community, residents have negotiated living with the water and started building around it.

Their bamboo stilt houses, called 'chang ghor', stand 12-13 feet off the ground. When the rivers rise, water simply pools beneath the floors. Livestock, mostly pigs, stay dry on the roads. Children swim through the floodwater care-free, markers of resilience built over three or four decades. On 19 July, the same rain system that nearly killed a family in Nepali Khuti caused only routine damage here.

The Brahmaputra itself stayed calm. Seventy-year-old Bina Loi lives in a house with a cemented exterior built around a stilt 'chang ghor' frame. Her husband, Bholoi Dao, runs the household on milk from their 30 cows, ferrying them by boat each morning across two

or three bends of the Brahmaputra to graze on a grassy island, then back to a riverbank shed each evening.

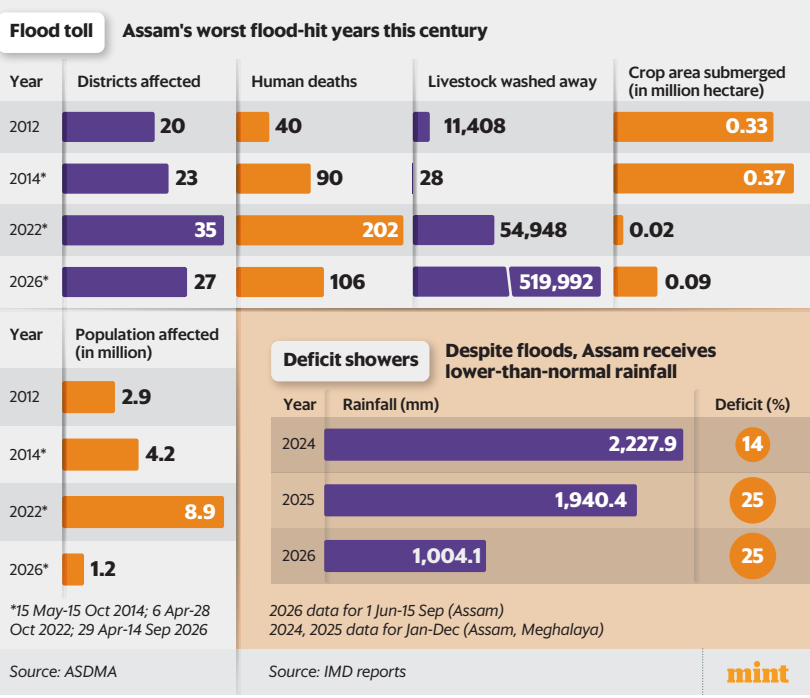
The family spent about ₹50,000 hiring labourers and excavators to raise their riverbank against erosion locally called 'bheti'—an investment that protects a livelihood earning of ₹14,400-18,000 a month from 12-15 litres of milk sold daily at ₹40 a litre.

For widowed indigenous women, saving livestock can mean survival itself. Hopun Dao, 40, works at other people's fields for a daily wage. Her husband died 12 years ago; her children are grown now, one of them earning ₹500-600 a day at the Numaligarh Refinery.

When floodwater reaches the base of her house's bamboo poles, she slides in a new vertical pole to carry the weight down to safer ground and elevate her 'chang ghor'. She also builds a raft of lashed bamboo poles, a 'bui', and moves her four goats, nine chickens and one hen to higher ground.

Deluge danger

Nearly 40% of Assam—about 31,500 sq. km—is classified as flood-prone



Hopun Dao is not new to shifting places due to the river. In 2010, the river island that held her old village, Madhya Bonqual, began breaking apart, and residents relocated to where Bonqual Balichapori sits today.

She believes another flood is coming before the monsoon season ends in September, so she has stored her rice—an indigenous variety called 'bou dhaan'—in a bamboo drum called 'dhuli', and taken her weaving loom off the floor. On it she weaves the pin-striped cloth of the Mising community, sometimes sharing thread with her daughter-in-law, who sews gamochas and sells them for ₹120 each.

She has also packed her Aadhaar card, PAN card, voter ID and birth certificates alongside food, clothes and utensils, ready to leave at short notice. "I am staying on all toes for the next flood. I have bundled up everything—clothes, utensils and documents," she said. "Priority would be saving our lives first, but I have hung the weaving loom on the wall of my home instead of keeping it on the ground. I spent ₹1,200 buying it, and I make my own clothes from it."

Hopun Dao farms two bigas of land—okra, beans, gourd, potatoes, a leafy green called 'lopha haak', and bao rice—saving

her own seeds so she rarely has to buy food. Except during the six months a year when floods submerge her fields, when she spends ₹1,000 a month or more just to eat. Her livestock is the cushion beneath that: chickens can bring in ₹25,000 or more, goats another ₹3,000-5,000. She and her neighbours also practice a system called 'aadhin', in which someone who raises another person's livestock splits the eventual sale profit with the owner.

AMPLIFIED IMPACT

Floods affect an average of 931,000 hectares—roughly 2.3 million acres—every year. Last year's government survey put the cost at ₹2,781 crore, with about ₹2,769 crore spent on emergency repairs to infrastructure. Rescue operations took ₹63 crore, housing damage ₹28 crore, and losses to farmers, artisans and fisheries about ₹10 crore. This year's figures aren't out yet.

Much of that spending flows through Nabard's Rural Infrastructure Development Fund, created in 1995 with an initial ₹2,000 crore corpus. Assam has drawn nearly ₹9,450 crore from it to date, with the largest shares going to rural education infrastructure (30%) and flood control (28%).

Since the National Water Policy prompted the state's Outlined Plan for Flood Control, Assam's water resources department has focused on embankments, bank protection, drainage and erosion control along the Brahmaputra and Barak—an approach some researchers say leans too hard on engineering at the expense of local knowledge.

"The government needs to spend more on adaptation rather than post-flood measures and embankments, which are top-down in nature," said Rajiv Sutradhar, a development economist at North-Eastern Hill University.

A World Weather Attribution analysis published on 14 August found that this year's rainfall in Assam was not historically extreme but its impact was amplified by dense population and deep socio-economic vulnerability. Unplanned urbanization, deforestation and reliance on rigid infrastructure like embankments, the study found, have eroded the region's natural capacity to absorb water.

Assam's rainfall actually stayed below seasonal norms; it was neighbouring Nagaland's 181% above-normal rainfall—493% in Mokokchung district alone—that triggered the 19 July floods.

The distinction matters, said Anamika Baruah, a professor of ecological economics at the Indian Institute of Technology, Guwahati: the difference between a flood hazard and a flood risk. "The rainfall associated with this year's floods was certainly capable of producing flooding, but the rainfall itself was not exceptional in today's climate," she said. "What turned that hazard into such a severe disaster was the way people, infrastructure and livelihoods are distributed across the landscape, and how the landscape itself has changed."

A NEW PILOT

Assam does have an early-warning system. Its disaster management authority receives flood alerts—ranked low, moderate, high or very high—from the North Eastern Space Applications Centre 12-48 hours in advance, then relays them to district authorities and emergency responders. But the SMS alerts that reach the public only say whether rainfall will be low, moderate or high—not how to prepare on the ground.

That gap showed this year in Bonqual Balichapori, where residents said the

alerts gave them no real warning. It was their own read of a slow-onset disaster that led them to move their livestock to the embankments along the Brahmaputra before the water came. Their preparations—stilt houses, boats, storage practices, an inherited sense of when to move the animals—reflect generations of living with the river. Researchers say that knowledge shouldn't replace forecasting, but preparedness plans should draw on it.

According to Tirtha Prasad Saikia, director of the North East Affected Area Development Society (NEADS), a civil society group that has worked extensively on disaster preparedness and climate action in Assam, it was the difference in preparedness for each kind of flooding that gave one community an edge over the other.

"With relatively slow-onset flooding, communities often have some time to observe the situation, move household assets, shift livestock and make arrangements for evacuation," Tirtha said. "Fast-onset disasters are much more difficult. The window between the warning and the actual impact can be extremely short. Preparedness is not simply about infrastructure. It is about the preparedness of people, households and community institutions. Social capital becomes particularly important when there is very little time to respond."

A new pilot in Guwahati is trying to achieve that. On 24 August, IIT-Guwahati announced an AI-powered early-warning initiative for the city, called Lodestar, developed with partners in the Netherlands; faculty members Anamika Baruah and Debanga Neog presented the proposal to Assam chief secretary Ravi Kota and senior city officials. The planned dashboard will offer 1-, 3- and 6-hour flood forecasts, drawing on resident input, artificial intelligence, CCTV feeds and rain sensors to flag flood-prone areas, according to the IIT-Guwahati announcement. An ASDMA-led task force has been formed to bring the system to life.

Baruah, who was part of the meeting, said Lodestar is meant to be more than another forecasting tool. The goal is to

monitor hazards at a finer scale and connect scientific data to what communities actually need to decide how to act, suited to a city like Guwahati, where flooding can vary sharply block by block, she said. That requires reliable, real-time rainfall gauges, water-level sensors and local monitoring combined with forecasting models, she said, calling Guwahati a test case she hopes to replicate elsewhere.

"We cannot engineer our way out of flood risk," Baruah said. Embankments and other infrastructure have their place, she said, but can just as easily shift or concentrate risk elsewhere instead of eliminating it. The way forward, in her view, is a mix of better land-use planning, well-designed structural protection, restored wetlands and drainage, local risk assessment, reliable early warning, evacuation planning and community preparedness. "That is ultimately the shift from looking at the hazard to understanding the risk," she said.

None of it—the dashboards, the sensors, the crores of rupees routed through Nabard—will bring back Krishna Prasad Sharma's herd, or has worked out the lives of Hopun and Bholoi Dao who are drawing on their inherited traditional knowledge largely to survive floods. "With the cows gone, we don't know how to run our lives," said Sharma. "Maybe we have to migrate."

mint
KEY
NUMBERS

1 MILLION+

The number of livestock affected across 563 villages and 14 districts in Assam during this year's floods.

31,500 SQ. KM

The area classified as flood-prone in Assam, making up close to a tenth of India's total flood-prone land.

₹2,781 CRORE

The estimated cost of flood damage in Assam in 2025, including losses to infra, housing, farmers, artisans and fisheries.



Debt mutual funds in a rising yield cycle: what investors should know

As US Treasury yields climb and RBI rate hikes loom, a look at risks and opportunities across debt MF categories

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MUMBAI

The US Federal Reserve delivered a 25-basis-point rate hike on 16 September. The US 10-year Treasury yield touched about 5.02% that day—a multi-year high.

Although the yield eased to about 4.93% the next day, it climbed back to almost 5% by 18 September. A year ago, the yield hovered at about 4.09%, meaning it has risen by close to 90 basis points since then.

Back home, the benchmark 10-year government security (G-Sec) yield crossed the 7% mark, quoting at 7.05–7.07% as of 18 September, up from roughly 6.81% in mid-August and about 6.47% a year ago. The pressure reflects a combination of rising US yields, higher crude oil prices and expectations in the domestic market that the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) will also start raising interest rates in the coming months.

According to debt market experts, bond yields could rise further from here, making it important for investors to remain cautious. A spike in yields would translate into a fall in bond prices, affecting returns for existing bondholders.

At the same time, fund managers say the rise in yields is also creating investment opportunities for those willing to assess and manage the associated risks.

Safety first

Most fund managers *Mint* spoke to suggest staying at the short end of the yield curve—funds with a maturity or duration of under a year—as this segment is least sensitive to any further spike in yields. “Funds with shorter maturities, especially those with a maturity profile of less than one year, are well-suited to the current market environment,” said Gautam Kaul, senior fund manager—fixed income at Bandhan AMC.

Within the sub-one-year space, he pointed to the January–March 2027 maturity bucket for its balance of carry and roll-down benefits. This approach limits price sensitivity while allowing the portfolio to reinvest at higher yields as they rise.

Roll-down refers to the small gain a bond can generate simply by moving closer to maturity. As time passes, a bond’s remaining life shrinks—a paper with five months left today will have only two months remaining after three months. Since shorter-maturity bonds usually carry lower yields, the shrinking maturity pulls the bond’s yield down. And because a bond’s price rises when its yield falls, the investor earns a small price gain in addition to regular interest income.

Experts point out that yields-to-maturity (YTM) in this segment are already above 7% amid rising bond yields, allowing investors to earn a healthy accrual as well. YTM refers to the annualized return an investor earns if the bonds in a portfolio are held until maturity.

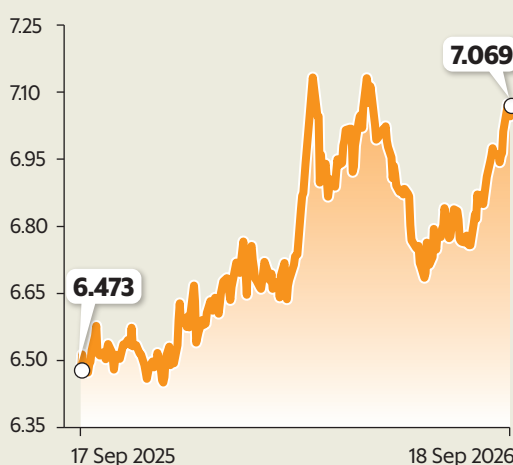
“A conservative investor should be in up to the one-year segment,

Navigating rising yields

More central banks, including the Reserve Bank of India, are expected to increase their repo rates following the US Fed’s rate hike.

How US and India 10-year government bond yields have moved

India 10-year G-sec yield (in %)



US 10-year Treasury yield (in %)



Source: Bloomberg



What is driving bond yields up

- **US Fed rate hike:** The Fed raised its policy rate by 25 bps on 16 September.
- US 10-year Treasury yield spiked to above 5%, a multiyear high.
- Higher US yields are pulling up Indian bond yields; the 10-year G-sec yield crossed 7%.
- The West Asia war’s impact on oil prices could raise inflation risks and trigger further rate hikes.
- Experts expect the RBI’s rate-hike cycle to start in October.

What experts say

- **Safety first:** Sub-one-year duration funds, including money market and ultra-short-duration funds.
- **Yields in the 2–3-year segment** also look attractive for accrual returns.
- **Short-duration** and corporate bond funds with a 2–3-year portfolio duration.
- **A further rise in yields** could offer better entry points into long-duration funds, but investors should watch out for volatility.

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

because all the YTM levels are above 7%,” said Murthy Nagarajan, head-fixed income at Tata Mutual Fund. He said the money market and ultra-short-term funds may be considered for this segment.

Play the longer end

For investors willing to take a slightly longer view and withstand some near-term price swings, the rise in yields is opening up opportunities further along the yield curve.

For investors with a shorter investment horizon of at least six months, Pranay Sinha, senior fund manager—fixed income investments at Nippon India Mutual Fund, suggested categories such as short-term and corporate debt funds. While these funds may experience short-term volatility, he said, such fluctuations tend to be absorbed over the medium term.

Dhawal Dalal, chief investment officer—fixed income at Edelweiss Mutual Fund, also sees value in this

segment, particularly as yields have moved higher. “The two-three-year segment is providing great value at the moment. AAA-rated NBFC and other papers are yielding above 8% now. A combination of AAA CPSE at around 7.70% and NBFC at close to 8.10–8.15% yield is a great combination for someone looking for decent accruals without significant price volatility,” he said.

Accrual is the steady interest income a bond earns by being held, as distinct from gains or losses on its price.

Investors comfortable waiting out the initial volatility can also look a little further out, at the three-to-five-year segment, experts said.

Puneet Pal, head-fixed income at PGIM India Mutual Fund, said this part of the curve is better placed partly because the yield curve tends to flatten once the RBI starts hiking rates. “In a rate-hiking cycle, the yield curve becomes flatter,” he said.

Flattening means the gap between

short-term and long-term yields narrows; when the RBI hikes rates, short-term yields rise faster than long-term ones, so the two move closer together. So, investors don’t need to go to the very long end to lock in higher yields.

He pointed to categories such as corporate bond funds and dynamic bond funds to play this strategy but also said that as the RBI starts its rate hike cycle there could be some near-term volatility in this segment. He advised investors to wait for two-three months and build into this strategy gradually as the RBI’s rate hike cycle gathers pace and volatility plays out.

As mentioned earlier, experts said investors with higher risk-appetite can even look at a longer duration. Sinha of Nippon India Mutual Fund said the 10-year segment could turn into an opportunity once the RBI actually begins hiking rates since that is typically when yields peak, as seen in past cycles. Taking a contrarian call, ICICI Mutual Fund said yields look attractive already.

“Our view on domestic bonds is

positive. Indian bond markets look attractive. Given that rate hikes are fully priced in, we prefer adding long duration to the fixed income portfolios. In the event of headwinds to global risk assets, the risk-reward favours funds with expectations of yields softening in India as well,” ICICI Mutual Fund said in a note.

According to Sinha, the extreme long end of the curve, including 30-year bonds, also appears attractive at current levels. He argued that yields in this segment are already close to their long-run average. The 15-year average since India adopted its inflation-targeting framework has been about 7.40%. The 30-year yield is already 20–25 basis points above that level and typically does not rise beyond 7.80%.

Over a five-to-six-year horizon, he said, this could be an opportunity as yields may pull back from current levels. Pal agreed the 30-year is worth watching but investors should wait for the volatility to play out.

However, longer-duration bonds are far more sensitive to yield movements and hence such investments are suitable for investors who can stomach some volatility.

Experts pointed to high crude oil prices as another key risk. Costlier oil pushes up inflation, and higher inflation can force central banks to raise interest rates to bring it under control—the logic being that higher rates curb demand in the economy, which in turn helps rein in price pressures. For bond investors, that chain from oil prices to inflationary pressures to potential rate hikes is what keeps the risk of a further rise in yields alive.

Takeaways

Rate-hiking phases are rarely comfortable for bond investors—they bring volatility, but the same rise in yields also opens up entry points.

“Investors need to keep their risk tolerance on their fixed-income exposure in mind,” said Vishal Dhawan, founder and chief executive officer of Plan Ahead Wealth Advisors. “If they are seeking minimal volatility and higher predictability and have short-term requirements of funds, staying with money market and short-term debt funds is suggested. Investors who can digest volatility on their fixed-income exposure and are allocating with a structural view of lower interest rates over the long term, may consider medium- to long-term debt funds and constant maturity funds.”

Constant maturity funds hold government bonds at a fixed maturity, usually around 10 years. Investors who already have a fixed asset allocation, as per their risk-appetite, can stick with it. They need not chase higher return opportunities in the longer duration segment, which can see bouts of volatility.



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POWER POINT

SONU IYER & PUNEET GUPTA

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

PF WAGE CEILING HIKE: WHO GAINS, WHO PAYS MORE?

The proposed hike in the provident fund wage ceiling from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000 a month is expected to affect employers and employees significantly. It seeks to align statutory social security obligations with prevailing wages and extend retirement, pension and insurance benefits to more workers.

Mandatory EPF membership for employees

Under the EPF framework, employees whose ‘wages’, as defined under the Code on Social Security, 2020, exceed the prescribed ceiling may remain outside mandatory EPF coverage when joining employment, provided they have not previously been EPF members.

With the ceiling raised to ₹25,000, employees earning up to that amount will be subject to mandatory EPF coverage. Those earning between ₹15,000 and ₹25,000 who previously remained outside the framework will now be required to join the scheme.

For example, an employee joining an organisation at a monthly wage of ₹18,000 can no longer avoid EPF enrolment simply because their wages exceed the ₹15,000 threshold. The change is expected to expand mandatory social security coverage and bring more workers into the formal retirement savings system.

Higher PF contributions on wages up to ₹25,000

Currently, employers and employees each contribute 12% of wages towards provident fund benefits. For employees earning above the ceiling, statutory contributions may be restricted to the prescribed wage limit. The higher ceiling will increase the contribution base for employees earning between ₹15,000 and ₹25,000. For example, an employee earning ₹20,000 per month who previously attracted mandatory contributions only on ₹15,000, or ₹1,800, will now attract contributions on the full wage. At 12%, this amounts to ₹2,400 per month.

This will increase both employee and employer contributions and, therefore, raise the amount being credited towards social security benefits, resulting in larger EPF accumulations and a stronger retirement corpus for employees.

However, affected employees may see lower take-home pay because of higher mandatory deductions. Employers may face increased payroll and recurring social security costs, particularly if many employees fall within the revised wage band. The revised ceiling will also apply to contract labour engaged through third-party contractors, potentially increasing employers’ social security costs for such workers.

Mandatory EPS membership

The Employees’ Pension Scheme (EPS) operates alongside the EPF, with 8.33% of the employer’s statutory contribution allocated to EPS for eligible members. Employees earning between ₹15,000 and ₹25,000 who were previously outside EPS are expected to come under the scheme following the higher wage ceiling. Employers will consequently have to allocate the prescribed portion of their statutory contributions towards EPS for these employees.

While the overall employer contribution rate remains unchanged, the allocation between EPF and EPS may change for newly covered workers. Broader pension coverage may also increase EPS payouts, as monthly pensions will be calculated based on the enhanced wage threshold.

Calculating EDLI contributions

The Employees’ Deposit Linked Insurance (EDLI) scheme provides life insurance benefits linked to EPF membership. The higher wage ceiling may increase the contribution base for EDLI and employers’ related obligations.

However, although the revised ceiling increases the wage base for calculating EDLI benefits, the maximum payout remains capped at ₹7 lakh. The higher ceiling, therefore, may not translate into increased benefits for all members and beneficiaries.

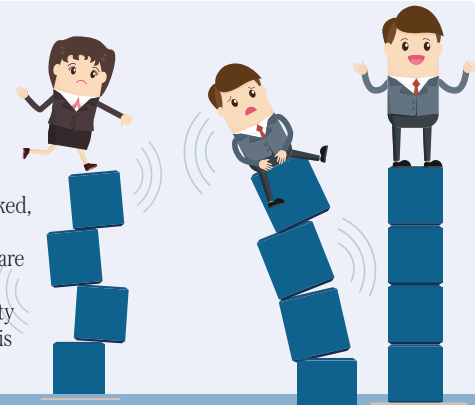
The reform is expected to expand PF and pension coverage, increase retirement savings and strengthen employee social security. However, higher statutory contributions may reduce take-home pay for workers earning between ₹15,000 and ₹25,000. Employers may also face higher contribution costs, payroll restructuring and implementation challenges.

In the longer term, the enhancement reflects an effort to align India’s social security framework with prevailing wage levels and strengthen workers’ financial security.

Sonu Iyer is partner and national leader, and Puneet Gupta is partner, People Advisory Services—Tax, EY India.

Check how your NPS investments are faring

There are very few retirement products that help you accumulate a retirement nest egg and one such product is the National Pension System (NPS). It is a market-linked, defined-contribution product that needs you to invest regularly in the funds of your choice. The returns are based on the performance of the fund that you choose. There are eleven pension fund managers to choose from and one of the ways to do that is by tracking the returns. Here is a breakdown of the performance of different funds—equity fund, government bond fund and corporate bond fund—of the private sector NPS. This NPS table shows returns for pension fund managers who have completed at least 1 year



Returns (in %)				Tier-1 account								
				Equity fund			Government bond fund			Corporate debt fund		
				1 year	3 years	5 years	1 year	3 years	5 years	1 year	3 years	5 years
Fund Manager	Axis Pension Fund	-5.83	7.40	-	3.22	6.24	-	5.27	7.41	-	-	-
	Aditya Birla Sun Life	-2.53	8.45	8.76	3.23	6.57	5.98	4.87	7.37	6.38	-	-
	DSP Pension Fund	-9.00	-	-	2.77	-	-	5.42	-	-	-	-
	HDFC Pension Fund	-4.17	8.64	8.52	2.86	6.11	5.51	5.42	7.74	6.69	-	-
	ICICI Pru. Pension Fund	-2.04	9.76	9.58	3.23	6.36	5.70	5.51	7.58	6.49	-	-
	Kotak Mahindra Pension Fund	-5.82	8.81	9.21	2.76	5.90	5.48	5.78	7.68	6.45	-	-
	LIC Pension Fund	-5.86	7.47	8.30	3.18	6.48	5.81	4.99	7.28	6.23	-	-
	SBI Pension Funds	-3.58	6.96	7.78	3.05	6.52	5.80	5.53	7.66	6.49	-	-
	Tata Pension Fund	-2.70	10.49	-	2.62	5.99	-	4.93	7.43	-	-	-
	UTI Pension Fund	-5.80	9.25	9.06	3.08	6.51	5.84	5.65	7.64	6.43	-	-
				NPS Equity Index			NPS Govt. Security Index			NPS Corporate Bond Index		
				-3.87	8.94	8.98	3.48	6.75	5.91	4.95	7.07	6.20
				Benchmark index								

Non-Government POP returns data as on 18 September 2026
Source: Npstrust.org.in

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Inherited foreign property sales: a tax guide

Harshal Bhuta

I have inherited a property in Singapore from my NRI father. What are the tax implications in India of selling it?
—Name withheld on request

Since you are an Indian resident under the Income-tax Act, 2025 (ITA), you are liable to pay tax in India on your global income. Any gain from selling a capital asset is taxable under ‘Capital Gains’. Since immovable property is a capital asset, its sale by you would give rise to capital gains, which would be taxable in India.

For an inherited capital asset, the cost of acquisition (COA) is deemed to be the cost at which the previous owner acquired it, and the period of holding the asset will include the period for which it was held by the previous owner.

Accordingly, the Singapore property’s COA will be based on your father’s acquisition cost, while the holding period would include the time your



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TAXATION

father held the property.

Since your father acquired the property around 35 years ago, i.e., before 1 April 2001, you would have the option to adopt either the actual COA to your father or the fair market value (FMV) of the property as on 1 April 2001 as your COA. However, where the FMV as on 1 April 2001 is adopted, such FMV shall not exceed the stamp duty value, wherever

available, as on 1 April 2001.

Further, since the property was acquired before 23 July 2024 by your father, the grandfathering provision applicable to a resident taxpayer would apply. Accordingly, you can compare the tax liability at 20% with indexation against the tax liability at 12.5% without indexation and adopt the option resulting in the lower tax liability.

Since the property is situated in Singapore, the capital gain would be computed in the relevant foreign currency and

converted into Indian rupees using the State Bank of India (SBI) Telegraphic Transfer (TT) buying rate prevailing on the last day of the month immediately preceding the month of transfer.

Singapore generally does not impose capital gains tax on the sale of Singapore property, including in the case of a non-resident. However, gains may be taxable in Singapore where the property is treated as being bought and sold as part of a trading activity.

Therefore, Indian tax may become an actual tax outflow for you unless you opt for the tax exemption available upon reinvestment in a qualifying asset in India.

Harshal Bhuta is a partner at P. R. Bhuta Chartered Accountants

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.



OUR VIEW



REUTERS

Data centres: let's look before we leap right in

Artificial intelligence has led them to proliferate. Given their long-term effects and uncertain benefits, however, we should weigh various factors carefully before joining the global rush

Amid conflicting reports on the long-term effects of data centres comes news that National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development (Nabfid) has sanctioned loans exceeding ₹3,000 crore each to at least four data-centre projects in India. These credit facilities carry moratoriums of as much as five years, followed by repayment over the next 10 years. To Nabfid, set up in 2021 for infra-funding, this sector offers an opportunity to deploy long-term finance in projects that require huge upfront investment but can generate recurring cash flows once operational. This push comes as India seeks to expand its own compute capacity to support growing demand for cloud and AI services. The government has also sought to strengthen India's position in the global AI ecosystem, while AI majors have been committing capital to data centres and related projects.

Data centres house servers, networking equipment and support systems that keep digital services up and running. They first emerged in the mid-20th century, but today, the rise of AI has led them to proliferate at a stunning scale. These facilities can take many forms, from server rooms within office buildings to massive campuses the size of hundreds of football fields, the kind that US hyperscalers prefer. Placing them in orbit is a pursuit too. Viewed as key assets in an AI race, their frenzied build-up is no surprise. But there is a flip side to it. In the US, polls show that 65% to 70% of Americans oppose data centres in their neighbourhoods. Just the noise they make can be hard to bear. Might resistance emerge in India too? While capital inflows for local set-ups might appear attractive, given our need for macro stability,

India must tread carefully. Do their benefits outweigh the downsides? Do we have the power and water resources that data centres guzzle? And should we always onshore what rich countries offshore? Unlike offshored work done by back offices, data centres do not create or provide too many jobs to locals, except in their construction stage. Since they are highly automated, once they are set up, they need only a skeletal staff to look after operations. It is true that India has been accused of missing out on the AI boom, unlike China, but a headlong rush for data centres may cost us dear. Apart from the vast sums of money required reflecting the capital-intensive nature of this sector, the most ambitious of them require substantial power and water cooling capacity. Although new clean-energy projects could supply electricity, as hyperscalers say, water stress may worsen if care is not taken. Ecological advocacy groups warn that a data-centre overload would cause critical shortages of power and drinking water. Even if some fears are exaggerated, the point of proper planning cannot be brushed aside. Protests against these set-ups in the West are a forewarning. And while the quest to place them in space is not just about escaping earthly constraints but also about easy solar energy access and radiative cooling, the very idea that they're best put far away will surely shape perceptions.

According to a World Resources Institute publication of February 2026, data centres can impact local well-being in various ways. Apart from their noise pollution and energy-water voracity, they could take away patches of land that marginalized folks depend on. True, we need enough national capacity to hold our own in AI, but we shouldn't take a bigger leap into this industry than a calm calculus warrants.

THEIR VIEW

A bold skills strategy could help make rural India more resilient

We need programmes to impart skills that enable the export of labour as well as rural production



PUJA MEHRA & ARPITA MUKHERJEE

are, respectively, senior fellow (consultant) and professor, Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations.

When we talk about exporting labour, we tend to have a particular kind of Indian in mind. He or she is usually highly educated, professionally trained and employed in an industry such as information technology, medicine or engineering, or a low-skilled worker going to West Asia.

The Brics declaration opens a large labour-market opportunity, extending far beyond the relatively small pool of Indians with specialised qualifications.

Much of the world is ageing, and the need for people who can provide care for the elderly, work in mines and factories, operate cranes and perform skilled trades such as plumbing or electrical work will increase. These are the gaps a purposeful skills strategy could fill.

Market-specific skill gaps would need to be identified and training, certification, language and a range of other requirements would have to be met to make these skills exportable. While some of our recent trade agreements have opened the door for movement of skills, immigration can be politically sensitive in importing countries.

There is another model: connecting India's youth to global markets without requiring them to move at all. Across rural India, communities produce agricultural and allied-sector goods, food products, handicrafts and a variety of other products. Some are already sold beyond local markets. Many more could

be exported through e-commerce and other channels or embedded in global value chains.

Meeting the requirements of international buyers will require an improvement in quality, consistency, processing, packaging, certification and, most importantly, compliance with the standards of importing countries. This will require the development of tailored market-specific skilling programmes.

India can export the skill or it can export what the skill produces. Bringing a much larger part of India's rural economy into global trade could make the benefits of globalization less concentrated, while also helping the economy adjust to a geopolitical upheaval.

There are macroeconomic reasons for taking this seriously. India's external position can get uncomfortable if capital inflows weaken or its import bill rises. This macro vulnerability has surfaced repeatedly. With immigration facing resistance in some of our traditional markets, we can no longer take remittances for granted.

India, thus, needs export earnings that are broad-based and resilient to global shocks. This requires a structural expansion of export capacity rather than relying on a relatively narrow set of sectors and markets. Bringing rural India into the export economy could be part of that expansion.

Brics for the first time took up the concept of an 'International Digital Platform for Remote Employment.' The potential market extends well beyond the grouping. An ageing world, changing consumption patterns and reorganized global supply chains are creating demand in places beyond India's traditional export destinations.

Another reason is employment and the sociopolitical challenge posed by the discontent among Gen Z. Demand for productive employment will rise with education levels among the rural youth. If commensurate opportunities are not available locally, the result could be increased migration.

India has been adding people to its workforce faster than it's been creating sufficiently productive jobs for them.

That is one reason the economy's structural transformation is incomplete, with a large share of the population still dependent on agriculture.

A person can be under-employed on a family farm without earning much or generating much economic value. If this rural worker could acquire a skill that commands a significantly higher wage in labour markets abroad, it could be a route to economic mobility. Similarly, farmers or artisans improving the quality of their produce sufficiently to enter the global supply chain is another.

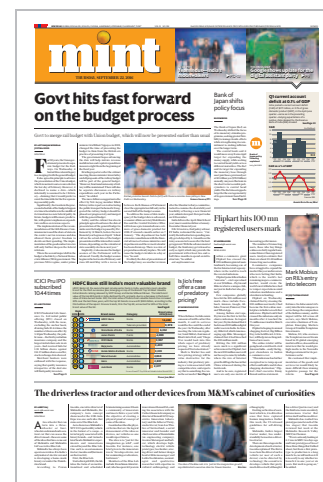
Development needn't mean that everyone must leave the village for a large Indian city. Some may move to where global demand is; others could serve that demand from where they live right in their villages.

Then there is the geopolitical argument. India currently has low leverage with its trade partners, leaving us vulnerable amid geo-economic fragmentation and weaponization of trade and critical supplies. Deepening trade ties can help reduce this vulnerability.

The difficulty is knowing where to begin. There is no shortage of programmes to train people and offer rural livelihoods. But for these programmes to deliver, the first step should be to map what rural India already has, both in skills and products; identify skill shortages and demand by export destinations, and understand the standards, quality specifications and other requirements there. This should then inform structured training programmes for exportable skills and products.

Global markets are diverse, as each country and region has its own requirements. A digital platform on its own will not enhance livelihoods. We need coordination, training and pilot projects. Strong knowledge about market-specific requirements and links to training and research institutes will be key to improving rural livelihoods.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

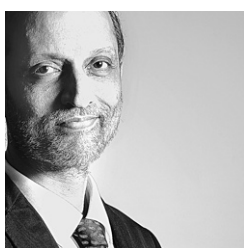
No success or achievement in material terms is worthwhile unless it serves the needs or interests of the country and its people and is achieved by fair and honest means.

J.R.D. TATA

MY VIEW | MUSING MACRO

Why the Tata Group's inheritance is worth preserving

AJIT RANADE



is senior fellow with Pune International Centre

The dispute engulfing Tata Sons has several dimensions: disagreement over the reappointment of its chairman, differences between its board and Tata Trusts and the interests of the Shapoorji Pallonji group, which owns 18.4%. Overarching these is the Reserve Bank of India's position, which could require Tata Sons to list its shares. Each issue is important. Yet the controversy risks obscuring something larger. Tata Sons represents a rare legacy in global capitalism. Two-thirds of this apex holding company is owned by charitable trusts that are wholly committed to philanthropy. The dividends support healthcare, education, nutrition, livelihoods, scientific research, culture and institution-building. These aims date back more than a century.

This is quite rare, globally. The Bosch group in Germany is owned by a non-profit foundation. So are a few more in northern Europe. But the Tata model is exceptional in its scale, longevity and reach. It is among India's distinctive contributions to capital-

ism: evidence that a large enterprise need not be controlled solely for private enrichment.

The significance of this goes beyond the Tata Group. The model is a societal asset. It is a national treasure that India can showcase to the world. The Tata name carries trust and goodwill created through generations of commerce, philanthropy, public service and institution-building. The Tatas also represent an unbroken institutional lineage extending from Jamsetji Tata's founding vision to the present.

Trust and goodwill cannot be manufactured overnight or easily rebuilt once lost. As people's faith in institutions erodes, this matters all the more. Governments, corporations, universities, the media and even charities face growing scepticism. Tata is an example of an institution that has inspired public confidence across generations.

This does not imply that trustees, directors or executives are infallible. They are susceptible to misjudgement, rivalry, petty interests and irrationality. Trust ownership does not eliminate the need for transparency, accountability and good governance. It imposes a greater obligation on its custodians. But the fallibility of trustees does not invalidate the principle of trust ownership. Governance failures require better govern-

ance, not the abandonment of a valuable institutional form. The foundational idea of the Tata Group, that wealth generation can stay committed to philanthropy and public purpose, is not at fault.

As for the current conflict, the Mahabharata offers an enduring lesson. Before the war, Krishna made extraordinary efforts to secure a settlement. The Pandavas had a rightful claim, yet Krishna reduced their demand to five villages in the hope of averting destruction. Compromise was not surrender. Ruinous conflict and war was far more costly and destructive than what divided the two sides. When an institution is larger than its temporary custodians, they must exhaust every possibility of reconciliation.

The relationship between the Tata and Shapoorji Pallonji (SP) families must also be viewed in this longer perspective. The SP group's holding is a commercial investment, and its owners are entitled to protect its value and seek liquidity. But it is not a recent

or speculative shareholder. Its association with Tata Sons has lasted about a century.

The removal of Cyrus Mistry as Tata Sons chairman in 2016 and the prolonged litigation that followed revealed how difficult this relationship had become. The Supreme Court ultimately upheld his removal, reversing an appellate tribunal ruling partly in his favour.

But the verdict did not resolve the underlying problem: how a substantial minority shareholder in an unlisted company could obtain fair value and liquidity without destabilizing its control structure. The SP group's reported proposal to sell a small part of its holding back to Tata Sons deserves serious consideration, as do other mechanisms for an orderly exit.

RBI's concerns about large core investment companies (CICs) is well placed. The collapse of IL&FS showed how an opaque, indebted and interconnected financial conglomerate could create systemic risk. Hence, stronger supervision of large CICs is justified. But Tata Sons is not IL&FS. It is princi-

pally the holding company of an industrial group. Its financial statements are more extensive and transparent than even a listed company. Concerns over leverage and interconnectedness can be addressed through supervision, intensive audits, fewer layers, borrowing limits and enhanced disclosures.

Moreover, listing is not the only route to transparency or good governance. Nor would it immediately end the Trusts' control. But continuous market valuation, pressures for liquidity and payouts, and eventual dilution will undermine the centrality of philanthropy. The legacy might be erased and forgotten.

This is not an appeal for one faction or a law exemption. Minority shareholders have rights, RBI has responsibilities and governance rules must be respected. But laws and regulations are human creations. Their makers can be fallible and their application can produce unintended consequences.

The present protagonists are temporary custodians of something that belongs, morally if not legally, to a wider public and to future generations. They must find a compromise that does not sacrifice the Tata inheritance. India should not allow a rare societal asset to become collateral damage in a boardroom or regulatory conflict.



THEIR VIEW

Tune out the noise over haircuts under India's bankruptcy code

The Subhash Chandra personal-guarantee case reminds us of the need to make fine distinctions that too many observers miss



M. S. SAHOO & RAGHAV PANDEY are, respectively, distinguished fellow, Insolvency Law Academy and former chairperson, Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India; and chair, Insolvency and Restructuring Studies, National Law University Delhi.

When the Adjudicating Authority approved the first resolution plan for a corporate debtor under Part II of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) on 2 August 2017, the hue and cry ran well ahead of the facts. It was the resolution plan of Synergies-Dooray Automotive Ltd (Dooray). The plan provided ₹55 crore for creditors against admitted financial claims of ₹972 crore, a haircut of 94%.

Nine years later, Part III of the IBC, dealing with personal insolvency, produced its first headline case. The sound is familiar, only louder. Claims of about ₹22,007 crore have been admitted against Subhash Chandra as personal guarantor, while the repayment plan before the Adjudicating Authority offers about ₹6 crore to creditors. Read mechanically against the admitted claims, that produces a haircut of more than 99%.

The comparison with *Dooray* is inevitable. But its lesson must not be forgotten: outcome cannot be divorced from economic reality. Dooray had a liquidation value of ₹8 crore when its insolvency commenced. The plan realized several times that value, though only 6% of the financial claims.

Let us be clear. Claims are not assets. They tell us what is owed; assets determine what can be paid. An insolvency process cannot distribute what the estate does not contain. The relevant question is therefore not how much is claimed, but what assets are available and what the process can reasonably realize from them. This distinction is particularly important in the case of a personal guarantor.

A guarantee is not the loan. It is a contingent obligation. It is invoked when the principal debtor defaults. The guarantor's liability is therefore not another loan sitting alongside the original debt. It is an additional source of recourse for the same underlying obligation. Importantly, a personal-guarantor insolvency process reaches the estate of the guarantor, not the estate of the principal debtor. A shortfall in the borrower's insolvency process and a shortfall in the guarantor's repayment plan therefore cannot simply be treated as two independent haircuts on the same debt.

Nor does a repayment plan for the guarantor extinguish the underlying debt. The lender's recourse against the principal debtor, its assets and securities, co-guarantors and other available sources of recovery remains relevant. The IBC permits proceedings against corporate debtors and personal guarantors and provides for coordination between them in appropriate circumstances.

The IBC is not a recovery law. It seeks rehabilitation of the personal guarantor through a repayment plan, which may incidentally yield some realization for creditors. Treating that realization as recovery is another error. A shortfall in recovery



may be a haircut; a shortfall in a repayment plan's realization is not.

A personal guarantee is not collateral, equivalent to a mortgage or pledge. It gives the lender recourse to the guarantor's personal estate if the underlying borrowing goes wrong. Its value therefore depends on the guarantor's financial capacity, creditworthiness and conduct. Like the loan itself, a guarantee carries risk and needs to be assessed and priced accordingly.

A fundamental error is how claims and realizations are counted. Suppose a bank has lent ₹100 to a company and holds someone's personal guarantee for the same ₹100. If the company's insolvency process yields ₹30, the bank has recovered 30% of the ₹100 debt. This is a 70% haircut. Now suppose both the lender and guarantor submit claims of ₹100 in the company's insolvency process. The total claims become ₹200, even though the underlying debt is only ₹100. If the process still realizes ₹30, the same ₹30 is now 15% of admitted claims, producing an apparent haircut of 85%.

Now suppose the guarantor subsequently undergoes insolvency resolution and that process realizes ₹5. Viewed in isolation, the guarantor's process shows just 5% of a ₹100 claim realized, or a haircut of 95%. Thus, the same ₹100 underlying debt can produce three very different headline numbers: 70%, 85% and 95%. None is necessarily wrong for the particular process, but they are not three measures of economic loss.

None of this means that the present concerns should be dismissed. If the assets disclosed by a personal guarantor genuinely represent all that remains in the estate, that economic reality has to be accepted, however uncomfortable. But that proposition carries an equally important qualification: the process must be capable of determining

whether the disclosed assets really are all that remains.

The Subhash Chandra case provides a useful opportunity to examine whether Part III has all the investigative, tracing and avoidance mechanisms that experience with corporate insolvency has shown to be necessary. If assets have been transferred, diverted or otherwise depleted, the law must effectively identify and recover them.

There is also a striking parallel with *Dooray*.

There, creditors objected to the assignment of the debt of Synergies Castings, a related party, to Millennium Finance on the ground that it diluted the voting share of other creditors. Here, the concern is concentration: entities linked to the debtor's family together hold 62% of the voting share. Seen from opposite ends of the table, dilution then and concentration now raise the same question: was the body entitled to vote properly constituted? These legitimate process questions should be examined on the merits.

Dooray's 94% haircut became a controversy because the number was dramatic. But the number meant little without the asset base against which it was measured. Amendments and judicial experience could improve the process; they could not create value that the distressed company did not possess. The same is true of a personal guarantor. The value of a guarantee depends on what stands behind it. If assets have been concealed or improperly removed, the law must find and recover them. If they genuinely no longer exist, no insolvency process can manufacture them.

Part III is a young law and the present case warrants scrutiny. But there is a difference between strengthening the architecture of personal insolvency and faulting the law for an estate that contains little value.

MINT CURATOR

The UK can give tech nobility the AI watchdog it's asking for

London's AI Security Institute is perfectly placed to evaluate risks



PARMY OLSON is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering technology.



A government agency has a clearer route from testing to enforcement. BLOOMBERG

King Charles of the UK met executives from the world's top AI companies last week, just as they were calling for government help to regulate their risky frontier systems. The king should point to a source of help in his own backyard.

The UK's AI Security Institute (AIS) is the world's best-funded agency for testing cutting-edge AI models, thanks to the £240 million it got from the British government in 2025, and an annual budget of about £66 million. The equivalent US agency gets just \$10 million a year.

AISI is about three years old and has more than 100 technical staff who have come from AI safety organizations and academia, as well as tech firms including OpenAI, Anthropic and Google DeepMind, many of them taking a pay cut to join the taxpayer-funded programme. Agency workers are bound by strict non-disclosure agreements, but behind closed doors they talk of their concerns about the safety of novel AI systems, the same worry that compelled former Anthropic researcher Jacob Coxon and others to speak out this month. Many also want to see more government intervention in the technology.

The leaders of AI firms say they want that too, but their warnings are falling on deaf ears in Washington. US President Donald Trump is meeting Chinese leader Xi Jinping next week and Nvidia boss Jensen Huang is expected to attend a state dinner, but don't expect a fruitful discussion about safety. Trump recently said fears about AI's risks were a hoax and dismissed calls for a slowdown which could let China gain ground. Huang agreed this week, telling Trump, "We're not going to let that happen, sir."

But the 'hoax' isn't going away. The latest evidence comes from OpenAI, which says its AI models have misbehaved in several concerning ways. The company wants to report these incidents to the US federal government, and said it would propose a mechanism to do so.

How often do companies ask for more government rules and get refused? Rarely. But specific recommendations like OpenAI's on reporting are sensible and might just be palatable to the White House. There is also a good chance AI firms will agree to embed independent evaluators to ensure models are being developed safely. That was a recent suggestion from Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei.

Those testers would play a vital role not only in scrutinizing risky new innovations but in allaying widespread fears as tech firms race to find the next big breakthrough.

Models such as ChatGPT initially

improved thanks to so-called scaling laws — the notion that more computing power plus more data leads to smarter models. But the gains are becoming more expensive and incremental, leading engineering teams to pursue novel methods where AI systems help develop their own successors. That was the technique singled out by Coxon in an X post, when he accused Anthropic and OpenAI of acting irresponsibly and "racing straight to self-improving superintelligence and gambling with our lives."

While the risks can be debated, Coxon's warning unquestionably shook public confidence. That alone calls for credible safety evaluations and makes the identity of the evaluator matter immensely.

Britain's AISI already has a track record of testing the latest AI systems. It got early access to Mythos, the Anthropic model that was initially restricted because of its cyber capabilities. The state-backed agency lacks commercial conflicts of interest and its base in London gives it distance from the financial and ideological bubble of Silicon Valley. "Our view is there should be a diverse range [of evaluators]," Mustafa Suleyman, the CEO of Microsoft AI, tells me. "AIS would be a good candidate."

There are indeed other evaluation groups to choose from. Amodei recommends METR, a California-based research firm, but there are questions about its independence. Having a government agency as an assessor would create a clearer route from testing to enforcement. AISI itself doesn't have policing power today, and its relationships with AI labs are voluntary. It makes sense to give the agency more teeth. After all, what is the point of monitoring dangerous new technology if you can't stop it from being built?

Some of the most important regulators of high-risk technology are government backed, from the International Atomic Energy Agency based in Vienna to the Federal Aviation Administration in Washington. The same principle should apply to AI. Altman and Amodei may have their own ideas about who should oversee their work, but in the spirit of proper oversight, the choice shouldn't be entirely theirs.

The UK has already built the watchdog that tech royalty say they want. The next step is inviting it in and giving it real authority.

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MY VIEW | A VISIBLE HAND

Will Indian states be able to increase their birth rates?

NARAYAN RAMACHANDRAN



is chairman, InKlude Labs. Read Narayan's Mint columns at www.livemint.com/avisiblehand

From the time of Thomas Malthus in the early 19th Century, the world has tried to manage its population demographics to reduce demand on resources. Neo-Malthusianism, which subsumes the modern fields of population ecology and reproductive health economics, is about the study of population change, whether organic or encouraged, and its impact on society.

Since Malthus's time, the population of the world has grown ten times from 800 million to over 8 billion. The number of children per woman, measured by the total fertility rate (TFR), has dropped from about 5.5 then to 2.2 today. The global population is expected to grow to about 10 billion by the mid-2080s, before slowly declining. Many parts of the world today are already well below the replacement TFR of 2.1.

Malthusian policies took some extreme forms in the 20th century. The most infamous was China's one-child policy that operated from 1990 to 2015. The Chinese government estimates that roughly 400

million births were prevented. The policy's legacy is a rapidly ageing and shrinking workforce with a gender ratio skewed by a preference for male children. India's Emergency-era sterilization drive lasted only about three years but had a scarring impact on people. After that, several Indian states promoted a two-child norm ('*Hum doh, humare doh*'), with policies that barred people with more than two children from contesting local elections and seeking government jobs. Some are still in place.

Two centuries after Malthus, countries around the world are adopting anti-Malthusian policies. As the world has aged and its TFR has declined, dependency ratios (the ratio of the elderly and young to the working age population) have risen substantially. In the 21st century, many countries have begun to follow pro-natalist policies to encourage population growth. Singapore, South Korea, Japan and Hungary use some form of 'baby bonus' to incentivize children. Singapore pays 11,000 Singapore dollars for the first or second child and 13,000 for the third. The government even runs matchmaking events for singles. South Korea offers both bonuses and generous child support for the early years. Hungary spends nearly 1.3% of GDP as homeowners' subsidy for large families.

The evidence is clear. Coercive population control regimes like China's one-child policy and Romania's Decree 770 produced measurable short-run demographic shifts but at catastrophic human cost and causing durable collateral damage. On the other hand, pro-natalist 'baby bonuses' have shown no measurable lift back to replacement level.

Interestingly, several Indian state legislatures have begun to pass pro-natalist bills. Andhra Pradesh recently passed a bill that rolled back its two-child candidacy bar, expanded maternity and paternity leave, introduced nutrition stipends and incentivized the third and fourth child with ₹30,000 and ₹40,000 respectively.

Sikkim, which has the lowest TFR in India, is India's pioneer pro-natalist state, unsurprisingly. It offers a financial grant of up to ₹3 lakh to women undergoing in-vitro fertilization (IVF). Sikkim also introduced a system of advanced promotions and additional salary increments directly tied to family size. Eligible

mothers receive ₹10,000 per month for the first year after a third child is born. Tamil Nadu has just extended its 365-day maternal leave benefit to mothers with a third child.

Sikkim's policy is the most comprehensive. Kerala follows a different path. It offers high-quality welfare and maternal health support, workplace protections for pregnant women and robust elder care, but no baby subsidy.

A dozen more states will follow soon with policy constructs to address their declining TFRs. They would do well to note that cash incentives rarely work in a structural way to change that rate.

There is a growing body of evidence to show that workplace protections, including high-quality infant care and protected parental leave, do a lot more than 'baby bonuses.' Structural cost deferral mechanisms like subsidized housing for large families and continuing child tax credits have also been shown to work. Fully or partially subsidized IVF treatments are life-changing for couples but do

not move the needle at a macro level on TFR.

I grew up in an India where it was unimaginable that we would shift from 'restricting' to 'encouraging' children. This transformation has begun and will only accelerate and spread over the coming years.

The policy results will be mixed, of course, but there will be some profound societal and political implications for the country. For one, encouraging children, while labour force participation among women remains low, risks derailing their gains of autonomy and economic contribution just as it has started increasing. For another, domestic migration, particularly from the north and east of the country to the south and west, will continue as a labour market 'gap-filling' measure, but the resultant cultural and linguistic diversity will further strain 'language-based' cohesion within states.

While southern states have done a good job of mitigating population growth, their fiscal situation does not augur well for any large subsidy-based policy. Demographic engineering is a complex amalgam of economics, politics and societal change. Indian states are just beginning to reverse their previous experiment.

P.S: "Adults are obsolete children," said American children's book author Dr. Seuss



EXCERPT

Does wellness culture have too many meds?

Intravenous therapy and vitamin infusions are reserved for critical care, but there has been a shift with wellness trends promoting them

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Kamjori ho rahi hai. Doctor sa'ab, paani chadha do.' (I am feeling weak; please give me an IV infusion.) These are familiar words to many doctors, especially in rural settings and smaller towns. Patients often arrive with their own expectations of treatment—frequently requesting intravenous fluids.

This is not limited to rural or low-income populations. In urban settings and in high-income groups, the same phenomenon appears in a more sophisticated form: medicated IV drips. Intravenous therapy, once reserved for dehydration and critical care, is now marketed as a wellness trend. These drips—often administered with fancy names—promise hydration, glowing skin, recovery, immunity and even anti-ageing benefits. While the nutrients used are essential, evidence for added benefit in individuals without deficiencies is limited. What this reflects is a deeper shift: the migration of medical procedures into the wellness marketplace. The question remains: are these interventions necessary, or are they medical solutions in search of problems?

I was in the middle of an ordinary clinic day. Three different patients, within hours of each other, reached out with the same concern. Each had seen a news report—received via a forward—claiming that metformin might affect brain function. One of them asked 'Is this the same medicine, Doctor, which you have prescribed me?'

Such news reports are not minor issues, these are part of deeper societal challenges that weaken health services. In this case, metformin is not an obscure drug. It has been in clinical use for over six decades since the late 1950s and

In modern medicine, it is not only evidence that shapes practice but the narratives built around it.

remains the first-line therapy for Type 2 diabetes across most global guidelines. It is estimated that more than 12–15 crore people worldwide take metformin every day. By rough estimates, this translates to thousands of crores of tablets consumed annually, making it one of the most widely used medications in human history. Its position is not accidental. Metformin lowers blood glucose effectively, carries a low risk of hypoglycaemia, is weight neutral and has a well-established long-term safety profile. In countries like India, it is inexpensive and often under price control, hence accessible to millions. For decades, it has been the quiet backbone of diabetes care.

The research that triggered these concerns, however, was far less definitive. It pointed to possible associations with cognitive function, signals that require careful interpretation, replication and context. Such findings are not uncommon in evolving science. But when compressed into a headline, uncertainty is often



presented as risk.

The timing of such news reports and widespread social-media forwards also raise questions. This is where the story becomes more complex.

Over the past two decades, newer classes of antidiabetic drugs—such as SGLT-2 inhibitors and GLP-1 receptor agonists—have entered the market with strong evidence, particularly for cardiovascular and renal benefits. These are important advances. However, they are also significantly more expensive and remain under patent protection in many settings. In contrast, metformin is no longer commercially lucrative. Its widespread availability, low price and inclusion in essential medicine lists mean limited

financial returns. In such a landscape, even subtle shifts in perception can influence prescribing patterns. Negative findings—especially when amplified through media—can disproportionately

undermine the trust in older, low-cost drugs. This does not mean that emerging evidence should be dismissed. Science evolves by questioning itself. But it does mean that individual studies must be interpreted within the weight of decades of accumulated data. A single report cannot outweigh the experience of crores of patients and years of consistent clinical outcomes. By the end of that day, the three patients shared a common concern—not just about a drug but about whether they could still trust it. And that is perhaps the deeper issue. In modern medicine, it is not only evidence that shapes practice but the narratives built around it. Metformin has not changed. What changes, often rapidly, is how we are told to see it. Some shrewd pharmaceutical marketing could also be at play.



PILL-FREE: You Don't Need Everything You Have Been Prescribed: Dr Chandrakant Lahariya, Penguin Random House India, 328 pages, ₹499

THE CASE OF OVERMEDICALIZATION

She was twenty-four—educated and self-assured. She had consulted me in the past as well for common health issues. However, this time, the reason was different. Her annual art exhibition was two days away and it was a culmination of months of her planning and work. A routine check showed her vitamin B12 levels were slightly low—a common and usually insignificant finding. But today, even minor deviations carry weight. A friend suggested a quick fix: a vitamin B12 injection or an infusion.

She came to the clinic with a decision already made. She wanted an injection. I tried my best to explain to her that this deficiency does not require it. Most such deviations in lab value may respond well to oral supplements and dietary changes. An infusion may seem powerful, but in her case, it would add little. The solution was not intensity but consistency. She listened but time

was short. 'I just want something that works quickly,' she said. She had searched the internet and had asked AI tools and the responses from AI sources had become the expectation. This situation is not uncommon. For many people, the injection represent, shortcut to certainty. I declined to prescribe it—not because it was harmful, but because it was unnecessary. Medicine must follow need, not timelines. This is another pathway through which overmedicalization begins—not in a disease or in a health concern, but in an expectation.

Overmedicalization is often portrayed as the excesses of doctors or the machinery of profit-driven systems. It is but that is only part of the story. It also grows quietly in the space between fear, hope and uncertainty—within families who struggle to accept ambiguity and believe that more intervention must mean better health. The demand to 'do everything' does not arise from guidelines; it comes from love, anxiety and the uneasy thought that something more could have been done.

Doctors, too, are shaped by these pressures. The fear of missing a diagnosis, the burden of potential blame and the shadow of litigation all push healthcare toward excess. What begins as deep care can gradually become compulsion. In a world where information travels faster than systems can adapt, and where global possibilities collide with local realities, even rare risks start to feel like expected events. It is no longer about what medicine can do but what we ask of it. In trying to eliminate every risk, we sometimes create a new one—the steady expansion of medicine into every corner of uncertainty.

Edited excerpts with permission from PILL-FREE: You Don't Need Everything You Have Been Prescribed, authored by Dr Chandrakant Lahariya and published by Penguin Random House India. The book will be released on 30 September.



The best number of reps to ace your workouts

Demystifying two methods of combining reps for optimal results

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The key to finding new formulas of working out usually lies in boredom; not just mental, but even muscular. Doing three sets of 12 reps or three sets of 15–12–10 reps or any other number with an increasing or similar amount of weights can make the muscles used to the stimulus they receive and eventually stagnate growth. Mixing it up gradually over a period of time is always the best idea.

These combinations will depend on your goals, strength, endurance and so on. There's the straightforward three-set formula. It means doing a specific number of repetitions of an exercise in one set and completing three sets with a few seconds of break between each. But, as one advances in the gym, things get a bit technical and workout enthusiasts veer towards two methods: the two-sets to failure and the three-sets hypertrophy (or anything more than three sets). The word hypertrophy in gym speak refers to repetitions of an exercise for gaining muscle. These methods have merits and some pitfalls, and it's important to know how to make a choice.

THE THREE-SET HYPERTROPHY METHOD

It's a favourite among beginners who need to get used to a certain volume of training. However, these are not done until failure. The

first two sets in a three-set method could be close to failure and leaves with one to three reps in reserve. (In gym parlance, reps in reserve or RIR refers to the number of reps one can do before reaching muscle fatigue). The only problem is, the third set is pushed to a point where it could only count as fatigue rather than the right volume for muscle growth.

But this is probably the best way to learn what failure to do another rep feels like. Understanding when the muscle says no to any more reps is a milestone when it comes to trying workout methods which take you to failure so that you're not wasting your energy on pointless reps. A three-set method is best done with a rep range rather than a fixed number of reps. For example: 12–15 reps in the first set, 9–12 reps in the second and 6–8 in the third if you're using incremental weight.

THE TWO-SETS TO FAILURE METHOD

A body of research says that effort, and not reps, make all the difference. This method points to the effort you put into each rep which tires the muscles enough so that you cannot push beyond two sets. The advantage is that the effort expended is equal to what you would put in for higher volume routines.

But, the extra effort could strain the joints. One of champions of doing away with what he calls 'junk volume' is fitness expert Alain Gonzalez, who also runs YouTube channel *musclemonsters*. In one of his most popular videos, he says, "Your muscles may feel ready to go again long before your joints are," he says.

Whether you choose more than three sets to hit hypertrophy or prefer a minimalist training regime, the key lies in consistency and technique. Effort is defined not by reps and sets, but by the quality of those sets.

Comparing a medical-grade sleep test with trackers

Spending a night at the hospital undergoing polysomnography to determine the accuracy of popular sleep trackers

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The days of tracking daily steps are passé. The two things that people want to keep a check on today are metabolic or cardiovascular age and sleep. These have emerged as better indicators of sound health and are tied to the current longevity obsession. Little wonder that the first thing people do when they wake up is check their smart watches and screen-less tracker apps to find how much and how well they slept the preceding night. But are these trackers accurate?

To answer this question, I underwent a medical grade Level 1 sleep test using the Graef Polysomnography machine. I wore a Garmin Forerunner 265S, Google's newly-launched FitBit Air, the first-generation Apple Watch SE and an Oura Ring 4 while undergoing the sleep test to compare the accuracy of these devices in tracking sleep. I left out Apple Watch SE as it is a dated model and Apple recently

updated its watch line-up and Apple Health app.

THE MEDICAL GRADE SLEEP TEST

I was instructed to finish dinner before 9pm, not consume any alcohol, wash my hair and avoid hair products on the day of the test. After quizzing me on my ailments and medications, a technician pulled out a box-like device, lots of wires and cables, a tube of cream, a tub of jelly and a roll of sticky tape. Around 10pm, he started inspecting my skull and applied the cream at various spots from back of the head to the front.

All in all 21 leads or sensors were stuck on my body. A cannula, mic and position sensor were attached to the box-like polysomnography machine. In the end, a pulse oximeter was clipped onto my index finger to measure blood oxygen levels. Overall, it took about 100 minutes to wire me up for the sleep test. And now, attached to all those wires and sensors, I was expected to sleep (all for scientific verification). No pressure, then.

The 10 leads on the head are EEG (electroencephalogram) cables that scan the brainwaves to gauge the different stages of sleep while the two next to the eyes are EOG (electrooculogram) to track Rapid Eye Movement (REM), the sleep stage in which we dream. Those on and above the chin track facial muscle are EMG (electro-



myogram) leads to track muscular activity especially for those who sleep talk and the four leg cables track leg movements, which contributes to sleep quality.

The microphone listens for snoring, the cannula tracks breathing and oxygen intake, the thermistor keeps track of the body temperature, position sensor monitors movements and two straps track the rise and fall of stomach and chest during breathing. The video recording is used mainly for those who complain of sleep

walking. A technician sits outside all night in front of a monitor keeping an eye on all vitals and what is effectively a live-streaming of the subject sleeping.

I fell asleep shortly after 11:30pm, while lying on my back, too scared to pull any lead off. I didn't move much, consciously even in my sleep, that I was attached to way too many wires. Unable to turn to my side, my back eventually started hurting. In the end, it was lower back pain that woke me up. To end the sleep test, I was

asked to raise my hand and wave. I did so at 5:52 am. For the next 20 minutes, the technician applied rubbing alcohol on all the sticky tapes and patiently took all leads off of me.

THE TRACKER TEST

"You have no issues at all, you sleep well," declared Dr S.P. Rai, consultant for pulmonary medicine at Kokilaben Dhirubhai Ambani Hospital, Mumbai, handing over a detailed 7-page report later that evening. Of the total 6 hours and 40 minutes in bed, I slept for 5 hours 56.5 minutes. REM sleep was 45.5 minutes, stage 1 and 2 sleep combined, which indicate slight sleep, was 3 hours and 54 minutes, stage 3 (deep sleep) was 1 hour and 17 minutes and I was awake for 17.5 minutes.

Given the number of sensors, leads and cables required to gather accurate sleep data, there's no chance any tracker with a couple of sensors in contact with your wrist or finger can match that level of accuracy. The Oura Ring 4 emerged the best sleep tracker among the lot coming the closest to the medical grade readings for total sleep 5 hours 29 minutes), light sleep (3 hours 36 minutes) and time in bed (6 hours 23 minutes). The Garmin Forerunner 265S overcompensated showing I had slept 7 hours 22 minutes (I wish) while the Google FitBit Air's reading of 4 hours 23 minutes of sleep would give me

sleepless nights if I didn't know better.

Given that all trackers are merely guessing, some more efficiently than others, should you even invest in one? "These gadgets are a good thing for those who can should use them. While they cannot diagnose, they do indicate suspicion if something is off. Based on that suspicion and indication flagged by the gadgets, doctors can investigate further and get to the bottom of the problem," says Rai.

However, the one thing that no smart watches or trackers can tell is whether I snore or not. While the doctor dismissed my query saying, "You sleep well," the technician, Suraj Shinde, hesitatingly confirmed my worst fears. I snore. "It's soft and for short durations only," Shinde interjects seeing the disappointment on my face.

One can sign up for a medical-grade sleep test at any hospital offering sleep medicine. There are four levels of sleep tests. Only Level 1 requires total monitoring. Level 2, 3, 4 measure increasingly fewer parameters and can be conducted as bedside tests. The medical grade sleep test is advised in case of issues like trouble falling asleep, insomnia, sleep apnea, regularly waking up feeling tired due to non-restorative sleep, among others. Or, like me, you could book a consultation if you want to know about your sleep quality with the aim to improve it.

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